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EXPRESS investigation

IN COLLABORATION WITH INTERNATIONAL CONSORTIUM OF INVESTIGATIVE JOURNALISTS

2017 Doklam border fallout in Mumbai: China's top bank froze loans worth \$185 mn, told party cadre to alert embassy

'Internal and external' challenges of Industrial and Commercial Bank of China's lone India branch detailed in 178-page 'confidential' work summary

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, September 20

WHEN INDIAN and Chinese troops were locked in a face-off at Doklam along the northeastern border in 2017, the fallout was felt over 2,000 km down the map — in Mumbai, home to the Industrial and Commercial Bank of China's only branch in India.

The ICBC branch "proactively reduced its exposure to loan and investment risks and suspended the disbursement of 11 approved but undisbursed loans and bond investments totalling \$185 million". It also "organized" Chinese Communist Party members across every department to stay in constant touch with China's embassy and consulate.

These are the key revelations from internal documents reviewed by *The Indian Express* in China Capital — a global investigation led by the International Consortium of Investigative Journalists (ICIJ), which lifts the veil on how state-owned ICBC, the world's biggest bank by asset size, is a vital cog in China's geopolitical blueprint.

The investigation lays bare the extent of influence the Chinese state holds in all sections

11 YEARS,
5-FOLD
RISE

ICBC in India

₹6,378 crore

Assets as on March 31, 2026 — nearly five-fold rise in 11 years from Rs 1,386 crore as on March 31, 2015 in India.

₹3,522 crore

Investments as on March 31, 2026; of which Rs 2,885 crore is held in govt securities

₹1,871 crore

Advances as on March 31, 2026

₹4,194 crore

Customer deposits 2025-26 — up from Rs 3,439 crore in 2024-25

₹1,000 crore

Borrowings 2025-26 — down from Rs 1,296 crore in 2024-25

₹60.96 crore

Net profit for 2025-26

SOURCE: REGISTRAR OF COMPANIES (ROC), ICBC ANNUAL REPORT

of its economic infrastructure — and offers a rare peek at how China sought to ringfence its assets in India during the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



ONE BKC building, where ICBC's only India branch is located, at Bandra Kurla Complex, Mumbai. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

ICBC watchlisted \$500mn Vedanta subsidiary loan, recovered in full year later

Jay Mazoomdaar & Shyam Lal Yadav
New Delhi, September 20

A COMPLEX corporate structure; the parent company's limited access to much of the group's reported cash; a weak standalone financial position; and, the borrower's reluctance to provide information required for compliance checks.

These were among the con-

cerns flagged in internal documents of the Industrial and Commercial Bank of China (ICBC) even as it placed a Cyprus-based subsidiary of Anil Agarwal's Vedanta Resources on its internal watchlist in 2016 over a \$500 million loan.

However, records show the bank's exposure was repaid in full in 2017.

These records were reviewed

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Vidarsa Vinod, Sonam Maskar and Elavenil Valarivan won silver in the 10m Air Rifle event, Sunday. PTI

Neck pillows, no phones: How India's shooters tackled 2-hr bus ride to silver



Mihir Vasavda
Toyota City (Japan), Sept 20

THE ROAD to the shooting range, located at an elevation of 670 metres in Toyota City, runs

through the pretty Aichi countryside, with tall trees stretching up to the hills and scenic waterfalls. What Indian shooters hadn't anticipated, though, was a bus journey from Nagoya that could stretch to two hours on winding roads, with its own set of challenges.

To stay mentally and physically fresh at the Aichi Prefectural General Shooting Gallery, the Indian shooters used neck

pillows to prevent stiffness caused by the tossing as the bus changed direction. Phone screens were kept off to avoid motion sickness, and some opted to sleep before reaching the competition venue.

Despite the difficult journey, India opened its Asian Games tally here on Sunday with two

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

FULL COVERAGE, PAGE 17



Rameshwar Nath Kao

was built from scratch by Kao, a former Intelligence Bureau officer whom Prime Minister Indira Gandhi had tasked with cre-

ating India's first dedicated external intelligence agency. The achievement was not merely the establishment of a new agency. It was the speed with which Kao gave it the people, skills and institutional culture needed to operate at the highest level of national security.

According to former R&AW Additional Secretary B Raman's book "Kaoboy's of RAW", in the first few months after its formation, Kao gave officers two priority tasks:

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Russia, West Asia energy sites hit, India has a new problem: Sulphur

Prices up three times in one year, affecting availability of major complex fertilisers

Harish Damodaran
New Delhi, September 20

INDIA HAS staved off a potential food crisis by importing enough urea and liquefied natural gas to enable domestic production of high-nitrogen fertiliser.

But there is another critical commodity, sulphur, whose soaring prices — again, linked to the escalating West Asia and Russia-Ukraine conflicts — is impacting the availability of diammonium phosphate (DAP),

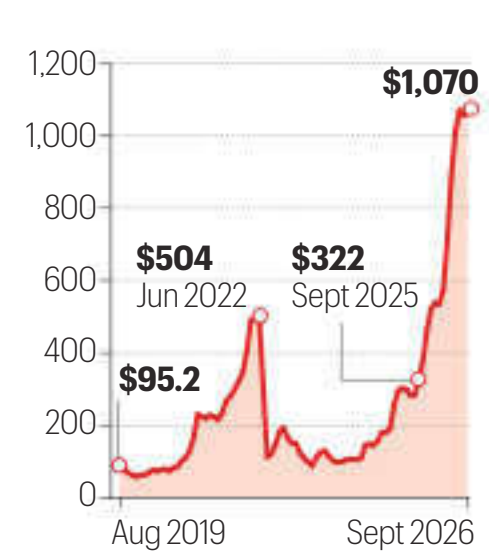
single super phosphate (SSP) and other major complex fertilisers.

Since the start of this year, landed (cost plus ocean freight) prices of sulphur imported into India have doubled to \$1,050-1,100 per tonne. The main reason: Ukrainian long-range drone and missile attacks on Russian oil refineries and gas complexes and Iran, likewise, targeting the energy infrastructure of Saudi Aramco, QatarEnergy and

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• Average import price of sulphur

(\$ per tonne, cost & freight to India)



Happening today

• A THREE-DAY special session of the Karnataka legislature begins to discuss the drought situation in the state and the Kasturirangan report on Western Ghats ecologically sensitive areas.

• BJP CHIEF Nitin Nabin will begin a two-day visit to Uttar Pradesh to lead organisational meetings and public programmes ahead of the polls.

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THE WORLD PAGE 12
UKRAINE LAUNCHES DRONE ATTACK AMID POLLS IN RUSSIA

Six high-tech Army labs to weed out foreign bugs from drones, cameras

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, September 20

E. EXPLAINED

THE INDIAN Army will soon be operating six AASHVAST labs across the country, where all its drones—and eventually CCTV cameras too—will undergo mandatory inspections to identify and eliminate firmware-level vulnerabilities. This will ensure that these do not fail during operations in contested zones and can perform their tasks effectively.

AASHVAST stands for Assessment and Analysis of Electronic Systems Hardware for

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Chinese parts cause for concern

This mechanism is significant in light of the Army's large-scale drone procurement initiative through the emergency route. The use of Chinese components in military drones has been a cause of concern for India, especially since many of these drones are used in operations along the eastern borders.

Tata Trusts challenges Chandra's 'casting vote' over his reappointment

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 20



N Chandrasekaran is the Chairman of Tata Sons

TATA TRUSTS, chaired by Noel Tata, has categorically rejected the decision to reappoint N Chandrasekaran as the Tata Sons chair and questioned the validity of using his own 'casting vote' to claim a majority after the two nominee directors of the Trusts voted differently over his continuation beyond his current term's expiry on February 20, 2027.

Tata Trusts holds 66 per cent in Tata Sons, the group holding company, and has two nominee directors on its board — Noel

INSIDE PAGE 8
SINGHVI, SALVE WEIGH IN ON TATAS BATTLE

Tata and Venu Srinivasan. On September 17, one director voted

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 5

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



"This generation is over-powered with information. To deal with them, you have to change... In a tsunami, only flexible trees that bend can stay alive"

GAJENDRA SINGH SHEKHAWAT
UNION MINISTER
PAGE 14

• HE GAVE IT PEOPLE, SKILLS, CULTURE NEEDED TO OPERATE AT HIGHEST LEVEL OF NATIONAL SECURITY

R&AW anniversary in spotlight, how its first chief built spy agency from shadows

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, September 20

IN THE last week of November 1971, India's external intelligence agency got an extraordinary piece of information. One of K Sankaran Nair's sources inside the Pakistani establishment had learnt that Pakistan was preparing a pre-emptive air strike on Indian air bases in the western sector. Nair passed on the warning. The Indian Air Force was put on alert. Pakistan eventually launched its air

strikes on December 3. India was ready.

Thirteen days later, the Pakistani Army surrendered in Dhaka and Bangladesh was born.

The man at the head of the organisation that had produced the intelligence was Rameshwar Nath Kao, the first chief of the Research and Analysis Wing. R&AW had existed for barely three years.

Established in 1968, R&AW, which will complete its 58th year of existence on September 21,

अब बारी आपकी

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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

China bank

border standoff.

With more than \$8 trillion in assets, ICBC is China's biggest commercial bank, placing it among an elite group of four state-owned financial behemoths that also include Bank of China, Agricultural Bank of China and China Construction Bank.

The China Capital revelations come from a dataset of 4.8 million documents from ICBC's London branch, including internal reports marked "trade secrets", confidential dossiers, and lists detailing over 4,000 corporate clients.

Collectively, the trove reveals how ICBC used its London operations as a financial hub for companies and conglomerates linked to sanctioned Russian and Belarusian business owners, debt-ridden states and China's political elite.

The ICBC archives are dated between 2005 and 2024 — a span when China ascended on the world stage and President Xi Jinping rose to power — and were first obtained by a hacking group, Hunters International, before being leaked to the ICLJ.

The consortium shared the records with 24 media partners, including *The Indian Express*, *The Times of London* and *Der Spiegel* in Germany, for the investigation involving 75 journalists from 24 countries.

ICBC did not respond to questionnaires from *The Indian Express* and ICLJ detailing the findings and seeking its response.

What 'confidential' dossier says about Doklam

The Doklam references feature in a January 2018 ICBC work summary of overseas branches marked "confidential" and "not for external distribution". The 178-page report covers the performance of 42 overseas ICBC branches and notes that the Mumbai branch faced "internal and external challenges" that year due to the Indo-China border impasse, but managed to maintain "normal operations".

Doklam stands at the tri-junction between India, Bhutan and China. The border dispute, which lasted 73 days in 2017, began with troops of the People's Liberation Army (PLA) occupying territory disputed with Bhutan.

Following attempts by China in June 2017 to construct a new road in the area, Indian troops responded, resulting in injuries on both sides. The standoff ended in August when both sides after holding diplomatic parleys agreed to disengage from their aggressive positions.

There are several references to the crisis and the resultant strained relations between the two countries in the ICBC report titled, "The net profit target was not met due to internal and external factors".

It cites the border situation as the reason the Mumbai branch could meet only 57.7% of the target set by its head office in Beijing.

The report states: "The primary reasons were as follows: first, during the period of border crossings, the branch proactively reduced its exposure to loan and investment risks and suspended the disbursement of 11 approved but undisbursed loans and bond investments totalling \$185 million, which impacted operating revenue by approximately \$6.36 million."

The admission of CCP members manning desks at the ICBC Mumbai branch during the Doklam crisis comes in a section titled "Strengthening grass-

roots Party organization building to mitigate the adverse impact of border incursions".

The work summary notes: "During the period of border incursions, the branch organized Party members across all departments to remain at their posts, actively maintaining communication with the embassy and consulate, and ensured the branch's normal operations..."

The crisis, according to the ICBC report, also led the branch to formulate contingency plans. The report reads: "The branch proactively reported to relevant departments at headquarters, comprehensively formulated contingency plans, reduced credit and investment exposures and minimised the adverse impact..."

During what the report calls the "tense period of the border standoff", the Mumbai branch, it states, took several unusual steps to foster a culture of "transparency, communication and trust". CEO tea sessions were organised, one-on-one discussions were held with local staff, and social activities were arranged for local colleagues to address their concerns about the situation, the report says.

The work summary is not the only document in the China

Capital dataset that points to close ties between ICBC and the CCP. ICBC, like other premier Chinese financial institutions, has a "Party Committee", and agendas of bank meetings from 2024 show key personnel assigned tasks such as taking on special duties from the Party Committee, or coordinating with the ombudsman of the Party Commission.

A 2022 financial report presented by ICBC's General Manager, international operations, lists this as a "major responsibility" for the bank: "...the main political task is to ensure that learning and awareness-raising activities are carried out in accordance with the Party's 20 pillars..."

The China Capital records also show that while assessing clients, ICBC managers in London weighed the commercial value of deals against the borrowers' or clients' ability to advance Beijing's economic agenda. According to the dossiers and data, this included policies such as Going Global, aimed at helping Chinese firms access foreign markets, and the Belt and Road Initiative, the massive infrastructure scheme spearheaded by President Xi Jinping — which India stayed away from.

With the International Consortium of Investigative Journalists

It adds that the bank was "unable to complete the full due diligence due to client being reluctant to provide the required information", prompting ICBC to commission an independent enhanced due diligence review from a third-party provider.

Even after the review, the report says "some areas were not detailed enough as per ICBC standards", leaving questions over ownership, source of funds, controllers and other regulatory information. Despite these concerns, the relationship ended without credit loss — and Welter Trading was removed from the watchlist.

China bank's India folder

In India, ICBC's sole Mumbai branch commenced operations in September 2011, growing nearly five-fold from its earliest available filing with the Registrar of Companies (RoC) in 2015 (see chart).

The Mumbai branch's latest balance sheet shows its top 20 borrowers accounted for over Rs 2,203 crore, or 58.14 per cent of total advances, in 2025-26. It opened at Bandra Kurla Complex on September 18, 2011 — the first mainland Chinese bank branch in India — as a "commitment to building up the commercial bridge between India and China".

The Chinese government holds over 70 per cent of ICBC, though offshore lending is just 8.5 per cent of its book, according to a CRISIL report in 2024. The report stated that the Mumbai branch "is mainly into corporate banking, trade finance and import/export related business".

On June 9, 2018, *The Indian Express* reported that the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has "raised objections to a proposal" for ICBC "to open a second branch in India", citing concerns that the bank "employed more than the authorised number of Chinese nationals at its existing Mumbai branch". The bank is yet to open a second branch in India.

ICBC did not respond to questionnaires from *The Indian Express* and ICLJ detailing the findings and seeking its response.

Ronak Pandit, the pistol high performance coach, said the buses are comfortable, with enough legroom and good seats. But that does not necessarily mean the journey is restful, particularly when athletes spend it glued to their screens. "We see a lot of athletes watching something on their iPads," he said. "What happens to your mind when you are doom scrolling? You develop cognitive fatigue. You don't want that before a match," Pandit said. "They have to be at their peak physically and mentally. We have to safeguard all that so that they have least fatigue."

Manoj also pointed to the conditions at the range itself. "The challenge is that light changes very frequently here. It's cloudy one minute and then it's bright and then cloudy again. Sometimes it's windy," he said.

The altitude is different too, although the adjustment is less about breathing and more about sight and aim. "We have to adjust our sight and aim. I was talking to Niraj Kumar (rifle shooter) and he said the surroundings reminded him of Ooty, where he trains," Manoj said.

Vedanta

by *The Indian Express* as part of China Capital — a global investigation by the International Consortium of Investigative Journalists (ICIJ), of which this newspaper is a partner, into 4.8 million files leaked from the London branch of ICBC.

Internal records of 2014 trace the bank's assessment of the loan to the Vedanta subsidiary from its decision to participate — and show that it commissioned an external enhanced due diligence review after the subsidiary allegedly failed to provide information required for compliance checks.

A Vedanta spokesperson said: "The syndicated facility was tied up with six leading international banks back in 2013 and since been repaid. As is common practice, the original lenders may transfer their exposure in the secondary market. Any exposure held by ICBC could have arisen through such a transfer and there is no current relationship. Vedanta has maintained transparent disclosures over the years, in line with its robust governance standards."

Records show ICBC joined a US\$500 million four-year syndicated facility provided to Cyprus-incorporated Welter Trading Ltd, a wholly owned subsidiary of Vedanta Resources Plc, with the parent acting as guarantor. It participated as a senior lender, with a total exposure of around US\$65 million split between its London (US\$29 million), Singapore (US\$20 million) and Mumbai (US\$15 million) offices.

According to internal ICBC records, Vedanta remained compliant with the loan covenants and the credit "performed in a regular manner" until late 2015, when weakening commodity prices and successive ratings downgrades triggered scrutiny, with concerns escalating in February-March 2016.

An internal ICBC watchlist memorandum said "the cause for concern" was a combination of falling commodity prices, "a

succession of multi-notch rating agency downgrades" and a waiver request under which "key financial covenants have been required to be relaxed".

The waiver request came as Vedanta faced refinancing pressure on about US\$1.3 billion of debt maturing in mid-2016, prompting S&P to downgrade the company in February 2016 and place it on CreditWatch with negative implications because of its weak financial position, refinancing risk and complex corporate structure.

After the majority of lenders approved the waiver, S&P removed Vedanta from CreditWatch in April 2016, saying it had secured adequate funding, could refinance its maturing debt through intercompany loan repayments and had obtained covenant waivers that "eliminate[d] the risk of covenant breaches".

Even after the waiver, however, ICBC placed the exposure on its internal watchlist.

An April 2016 memorandum noted that much of the group's reported cash was held by Cairn India Ltd and Hindustan Zinc Ltd, but Vedanta Resources' effective ownership interests were only about 37.6% and 40.8%, respectively. It cautioned that although the group reported large cash balances, only about one-third of that cash was effectively available to the parent company to meet its funding and debt obligations.

The cash-access issue coincided with Vedanta's June 2015 proposal to merge with Cairn India, which the company said would simplify the group structure and improve access to Cairn India's cash balances.

The ICBC memo also characterised the parent company as having "no operating assets" and relying almost entirely on dividends from subsidiaries, resulting in what it called "an extremely weak financial profile" for the holding company.

Moreover, a client due diligence report in 2017 states that "there was a failure on the part of Welter Trading Limited to meet its obligations to provide ICBC (London) PLC with the regulatory requirements we communicated to them".

has neck issues and did not want two hours of constant movement to aggravate them before a competition. "It's a two-hour journey from the hotel and in the bus we keep moving all the time," Elavenil, who won two silvers on Sunday, said. "So for me, it was very important that I keep my neck very stable because I already have neck pain and neck issues. I did not want to aggravate it before my competition."

Her solution: a neck pillow, earphones and the view outside the window. She listens to a playlist that shuffles between Hindi melody and English rock to classic Tamil. "I have been listening to the songs and get a good view of the countryside," she said.

The organisers had initially indicated that the journey would take around 70 minutes. "We didn't expect such a long journey," Manoj said. The coaching staff stepped in with advice only two days before the competition, once they realised how long the commute would be.

For Sonam, there is less of a playlist and more of a shutdown button. "I just sleep. If I look outside, I feel nauseous," she said.

Asiad

silver medals, both from the rifle range. Elavenil Valarivan, Sonam Maskar and Vidarsa Vinod finished second behind China in the women's 10m air rifle team event, before Elavenil added an individual silver later in the day. She was just 0.6 points short of Japan's Taichi Hinata in a gripping final, shooting 252.4 to Hinata's 253.0.

The medals were evidence that India's preparations at home, which focused on challenges at the shooting range, were effective. However, they had to improvise for those challenges on the road.

"We have advised all shooters to keep a neck pillow that they can use during their journey so that their neck doesn't get stiff," Manoj Kumar, the rifle coach, said. "And they have been told to avoid using their phones during bus journeys so that they don't get motion sickness. They can use the phone to listen to songs, but that's about it."

Elavenil took the advice particularly seriously. She already

R&AW

strengthen its capability for the collection of intelligence about Pakistan and China and for covert action in East Pakistan. "A little over two years is too short a time to build up an effective covert action capability, but the R&AW managed to do so," Raman said in the book.

He also recalls how Kao's men had completely compromised General Yahya Khan's communications. "Almost every day, Indira Gandhi and others entrusted with the conduct of the war had at their disposal extracts from the telephonic conversations of Yahya Khan and others with their officers in East Pakistan," Raman says in the book.

A childhood of loss

Yet the man behind the organisation remained largely in the shadows. As V Balachandran, a former R&AW officer who worked with Kao, tells *The Indian Express*, "People see then Army chief Sam Maneckshaw and BSF chief Rustam Ji in context of the Bangladesh war. But it was Kao who had laid all the groundwork for their achievements to follow. Kao never wanted to be talked about. He believed intelligence work had to be done quietly."

Kao's instinct for discretion was not simply professional. It had roots in a childhood shaped by loss and humiliation.

His father died when he was five, leaving his mother widowed at 25. The family struggled financially. Born in Varanasi, Kao found school in Baroda socially difficult. Classmates repeatedly mispronounced his surname as "Cow" and mocked him with nicknames such as "brown buffalo" and "sack of potatoes" given his obesity. According to Nitin A Gokhale's biography "*R.N. Kao: Gentleman Spymaster*", which draws from Kao's personal papers and recordings, Kao remembered himself at 11 or 12 as a boy who had become acutely conscious of being watched. He later recalled that he could not bring himself to eat in public without a servant accompanying him.

Decades later, he wrote that the discomfort of eating in public had never entirely left him. "I tended to withdraw into my own shell," Kao wrote, recalling those years, and believed that this had laid "the foundations of an introspective withdrawn approach to life in general". It is a revealing admission from a man who would eventually spend his career mastering the art of watching others without himself being noticed.

There was, however, another side to Kao. He developed an interest in ancient Indian history, temple architecture and sculpture, practised yoga and worked with clay, wood and stone, says Gokhale's book. He studied English literature, history and Persian at Lucknow University before completing an MA in English at Allahabad. He was interested in flowers and animals, and was known among colleagues for his cultivated tastes.

He joined the Indian Police in 1940 and moved to the Intelligence Bureau after Independence. Working under IB chief B N Mullik, he was put in charge of Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru's security. His travels with

Nehru brought him into contact with foreign intelligence chiefs and exposed him to the workings of intelligence agencies beyond India.

The 1962 war with China prompted the creation of the Aviation Research Centre, which Kao headed from 1963 to 1966. The ARC, with American assistance, developed aerial intelligence capabilities. Kao also helped establish the Special Frontier Force, which was intended to operate in the difficult terrain along India's northern borders.

How it began

After the 1965 war with Pakistan, Gandhi and her principal adviser P N Haksar tasked Kao with designing a separate external intelligence organisation. The new agency was to be different from the police-centric structure of the IB. It required people with varied expertise who could operate abroad without attracting attention.

Kao brought Sankaran Nair into the project. Nair, an experienced officer with a deep understanding of Pakistan and the wider Islamic world, became a central figure in shaping the organisation. Gokhale records that Nair regarded the structure Kao designed as his "magnum opus". The Cabinet Secretariat eventually gave the agency its name: Research and Analysis Wing.

Kao's ability to identify talent and impose standards was central to the organisation he built. According to Gokhale's book, Vikram Sood, who was recruited by Kao, recalled that the spy-master would carefully assess prospective officers and insist on precision in their reports. A report that failed to meet his standards could be returned with a simple annotation: "off". He was demanding but rarely theatrical, running disciplined meetings without shouting.

The 1971 war brought together the organisation's intelligence-gathering, covert and analytical capabilities. R&AW cultivated contacts with Bengali political leaders and resistance groups and helped prepare the ground for the war. The agency's role was to coordinate different elements of the Bengali resistance and sustain a campaign of attrition against Pakistani forces before the Indian Army's final intervention.

Balachandran says Kao had recruited people with specialised skills outside the normal bureaucratic channels; among them was a retired Army officer whose unit provided advance intelligence about Pakistan's planned air attack on December 3, 1971. His contribution, Balachandran says, was substantial precisely because it was not visible.

There were successes after Bangladesh. R&AW played a major role in the events surrounding the integration of Sikkim in 1975. But there were also failures, or at least moments that exposed the limits of intelligence.

In August 1975, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and most of his family were assassinated in Dhaka. There were questions about whether R&AW had been caught unprepared.

Balachandran denies this. "In 1975, Mr Kao went incognito to Bangladesh and informed Mujibur that a conspiracy was brewing. But Mujibur did not take it seriously. After the assass-

sination this question around what RAW was doing was asked by a police officer during a meeting. Mr Kao said, 'All I can say is that we were not surprised'. He did not boast that he had gone and warned Mujibur," Balachandran told *The Indian Express*.

Emergency cloud

R&AW also came under the shadow of Emergency when Kao was at the helm. The Opposition accused it of being the government's handmaiden. Balachandran, however, disputes this. "George Fernandes had once alleged that he had been arrested by RAW people during the Emergency. It was not true. It was the one arresting people. Not RAW. Kao actually tried to keep RAW away from all the palace politics. Sanjay Gandhi didn't think very highly of Kao. Mr Kao was very unhappy during those days," Balachandran said. As the Janata government took over, Kao retired prematurely in 1977, in an environment where the government was suspicious of the agency and had begun cutting down its budget and powers.

But retirement did not end Kao's influence. That year, R&AW chief N F Suntuok sought Kao's assistance in persuading Homi Sethna, then chairman of the Atomic Energy Commission, to advise Prime Minister Morarji Desai against signing the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty. Balachandran says Kao chose him to convey the message to Sethna.

A similar example of Kao's strategic imagination emerged in 1981, when India was struggling to convince foreign governments that Pakistan was pursuing a clandestine nuclear weapons programme. Diplomatic and intelligence channels had failed to gain sufficient traction.

When Kao learnt that *The New York Times* was investigating the "Islamic bomb" with *BBC Panorama*, he advised Suntuok to have Balachandran approach a senior Paris-based journalist and arrange a meeting with the newspaper's team. It was an unusual move: using the international press as a channel through which intelligence could influence policy.

Kao, meanwhile, had returned to the government. According to Balachandran, A C N Nambiar, one of Indira Gandhi's closest confidants, recommended that she rehire Kao. In 1981, Kao became Senior Adviser in the Cabinet Secretariat. Balachandran says he was effectively performing what would today be described as the National Security Adviser's role, but with an office of only two or three people.

His second innings ended abruptly. In October 1984, Kao was in Beijing, exploring a possible opening with China, when Indira Gandhi was assassinated on October 31. Chinese authorities arranged his passage to Hong Kong, from where he returned to India. After Gandhi's cremation, he met Rajiv Gandhi and asked to be relieved.

He never again held formal government office. Nor was he seen in public. He rarely appeared in photographs and did not publicly claim credit for his work. This did not surprise Balachandran — for, the Kao he knew was always "an extremely low-profile person".

Army labs

Vulnerabilities and Security Threats. Currently, one lab has been inaugurated in Delhi, with plans to establish at least five more in the coming months.

AASHVAST, a Firmware Analysis and Validation Suite, developed by QuickPay Pvt Ltd for the Directorate General of Electronics and Mechanical Engineering (DGEME), is designed to do more than just physically inspect drones. It also examines the software that operates these unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) — to identify and eliminate firmware-level vulnerabilities.

The Army has published a Request for Proposal in April this year to procure customised licensed software for validation of firmware and embedded systems for electronic components, including UAV components.

On August 14, the Indian Army's Additional Directorate General of Public Information had posted on X: "Equipped with advanced capabilities AASHVAST will enable evaluation of critical defence platforms thereby increasing cyber resilience. Aligned with the national vision of #Atmanirbhar Bharat, the facility will strengthen operational readiness as well as promote growth of the domestic defence ecosystem."

While the lab will initially test

all drones, sources said that CCTV cameras procured by the Army in future will also eventually be inspected by it for Chinese proprietary protocols or equivalent, which could be potentially embedded in these.

The idea behind establishing these labs, a first of its kind, was to neutralise the common threats of enemy interference in Indian drones, preventing them from performing their designated tasks in a contested area. Rajib Roy, Director of QuickPay Pvt Ltd, told *The Indian Express*.

So far, drones procured by the Indian Army did not have firmware-level vulnerabilities checked. The suite will close this critical gap.

Firmware vulnerabilities can be introduced during the manufacturing stage of a component or an upgrade process. For instance, unused codes could be introduced, hidden commands could be invoked at a certain location — thereby preventing the drone from performing its task.

There are approximately 14 types of vulnerabilities that the labs can detect. These include geospatial vulnerabilities, such as a malfunction that occurs when flying over a certain location, or issues that prevent a drone from reaching its preset destination. Other vulnerabilities involve unused and hidden codes that could cause a drone to terminate before reaching its target. Additionally, there are time and location bugs that may

cause a drone to operate normally except at specific times or locations.

The use of Chinese components in military drones has been a cause for concern for India, especially since many of these drones are used in operations along the eastern borders. Considering significant national security risks and possible data vulnerabilities, India has previously prohibited domestic military drone manufacturers from using parts made in China. In 2025, the Army Design Bureau submitted a detailed framework to the Ministry of Defence aimed at eliminating Chinese-origin components from UAVs.

People involved with the project said that AASHVAST labs will also examine drones for Chinese and/or other foreign-origin active components, as well as hidden passwords, embedded keys, remote access tools and location-based security controls. "This will help prevent situations where active components sourced from China are misrepresented as 'made in India' or another country, based solely on the invoice indicating their point of purchase," a person involved with setting up the lab said.

"There is no mechanism to determine what is embedded within the silicon. What is visible is merely the invoice, which shows (from) where the part was purchased. But that does not necessarily indicate its true origin," the person said.



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The building in Kalkaji. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Realtor killed, brother injured in late-night scuffle at building in Kalkaji

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 20

A 48-YEAR-OLD property dealer died and his brother sustained injuries after a scuffle broke out between them and another group near their house in Southeast Delhi's Kalkaji in the wee hours of Sunday, police said. Three persons, including two women, have been arrested, they said.

According to the police, they received a PCR call around 12.03 am on Sunday regarding a fight at L-8 Block, Kalkaji. A police team immediately reached the spot. Officers were told that a confrontation had taken place between residents of the ground and third floors of a residential building.

Manjeet Singh alias Bunty and his brother Dilbag Singh had sustained injuries, police said, adding that they were taken to AIIMS Trauma Centre. Manjeet was declared dead on arrival, while Dilbag, who sustained a fracture in the leg, was discharged after treatment, they said.

Police said a case has been registered under BNS for culpable homicide not amounting to murder. Police said they were trying to identify and arrest the rest of the accused.

According to police sources, Manjeet was carrying out construction work at a flat on the ground floor. Residents living



Deceased Manjeet

on the third floor had allegedly raised an objection. "This led to an argument ... and the situation escalated into a physical altercation," the sources said. Dilbag said he was informed around 11.30 pm on Saturday that his elder brother had been beaten up by a group of people near their home. "When I reached, my brother was already lying unconscious on the ground. I was overpowered and beaten up by the attackers. It was after my sister intervened that they let me go," he said.

Dilbag said the family was unaware of any dispute involving his brother's business. "We do not know what the issue was or why he was assaulted," the brother added.

Manjeet is survived by his wife and two teenage sons.

Police said multiple teams have been formed to examine footage of CCTV cameras installed in the building and surrounding areas and to arrest others involved in the incident.

4 killed as truck rams crane installing Traffic Police CCTV cameras

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 20

FOUR PERSONS were killed and two others injured after a truck allegedly crashed into a stationary crane and an auto rickshaw at a site in South East Delhi's Sarita Vihar where work was ongoing to install CCTV cameras for the Delhi Traffic Police in the early hours of Sunday, said police. Of the four, three were employees of the firm hired for the installation work — which had been going on for nearly six months, and was usually carried out in the night — and one was an auto driver. All four were sole breadwinners in their families, officers added.

According to police, the truck driver fled the spot after the accident and has not yet been traced. Efforts are underway to identify and apprehend him. The deceased have been identified as Umesh (23), Praveen (35), Anup (26) and Suraj (34). Suraj worked as an HR manager with Aabmatika Private Limited, the firm undertaking the work. Praveen and Anup were also the firm's employees, while Umesh was an auto driver whom they had hired for the work.

Sources said the workers were carrying out repairs near a divider when the accident took place around 3.20 am. Among those at the site, two were standing on top of the crane, one was standing near a tree while others were sitting inside the auto rickshaw. Safety cones had been placed on the road to alert motorists and protect the crew.

Initial probe indicates that despite clear hand signals from workers on the crane and a man standing below, the truck driver failed to stop and ploughed the vehicle into the team. Those injured in the collision have been identified as Akash (20) and Khem Singh



(Clockwise from top left) The dumper; deceased Anup, Praveen and Umesh. EXPRESS

(40). They were taken for medical treatment to a nearby hospital from where they were sent to AIIMS Trauma Centre. Another worker, Sudhir of Sangam Vihar, escaped unhurt.

Police sources said the driver may have dozed off at the wheel. A case has been registered at Sarita Vihar police station and an investigation is underway. Police are also examining CCTV footage and other evidence from the scene to establish the sequence of events leading to the collision.

Four families mourn

The accident has robbed four families of their only support, leaving behind grief-stricken relatives who have appealed to the government for assistance. Umesh, Praveen, Anup and Suraj were the sole breadwinners, according to their family members who reached AIIMS Trauma Centre to get their bodies.

Praveen, from Kanpur Dehat, had been working with Aabmatika Private Limited for 14 years. He is survived by his

wife and two children. He dreamed of educating them in good schools and making them successful.

"Anup, also from Kanpur Dehat, had been married for just two years and was the sole earner for his parents and wife. He often spoke about saving enough to buy their own home," his relatives said, adding that Praveen and Anup were cousins.

Suraj, from Nainital in Uttarakhand, had been living in Munirka for about eight years, working as a manager. He is survived by his wife and two daughters.

Auto driver Umesh, a native of Kasganj in Uttar Pradesh, had been living in Delhi for about 15 years. He is survived by his wife Rinki and two children. To sustain his family, Umesh drove a rented auto and delivered goods at night, according to his family.

Senior Delhi Traffic Police officer said that they are in touch with the company and will ensure all the help for the families of the deceased.

Election Commissioner Sandhu, CBI Director, top bureaucrats face SIR notice

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 20

ELECTION COMMISSIONER Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and several top serving and retired IAS officers, including Secretaries to the Government of India, are among the 31.63 lakh electors in Delhi who face Special Intensive Revision (SIR) notice to prove their eligibility to remain on the electoral rolls after their names were flagged in the Election Commission's centralised software over discrepancies, or other reasons, records show. CBI director Praveen Sood's details could also not be mapped with the previous SIR roll, as per the records.

The Election Commission on Friday uploaded the booth-wise list of the electors for the issuance of notices for either failing to map themselves with the electoral roll of the last intensive revision ("unmapped with last SIR"), or those having "logical discrepancies" in their details in the current and last rolls.

Sandhu, who is one of the three-member Election Commission, made to one of the lists of electors from two booths in New Moti Bagh, the government residential colony that is home to the senior-most office-bearers and bureaucrats. His name has been flagged for a notice for "self name mismatch", meaning that his name in the last intensive revision, which happened over the early 2000s across states, and current records differ. Confirming that Sandhu had been flagged for "discrepancy in name", the office of the Electoral Registration Officer of Delhi Cantt constituency said in a statement Sunday: "In the present case, the details, facts and documents furnished by the elector have been duly verified. The electoral entry pertaining to Dr. S.S. Sandhu, Election Commissioner of India, has already been validated and kept in the list for inclusion in the final electoral roll."

Jaishankar and LK Advani too on notice list

New Delhi: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and his wife were among the electors flagged for not having a link to the 2002 SIR roll in New Delhi Assembly constituency. Former Deputy Prime Minister LK Advani and two of his family members are also on the list of electors facing the SIR notice in the New Delhi Assembly constituency because of not providing a link to the last revision roll. DEVANSH MITTAL

Among the top bureaucrats who are in the list of the electors against whom SIR notices are being issued for discrepancies and "no mapping" are Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey, Principal Scientific Advisor to Prime Minister Ajay Kumar Sood, Health Secretary Punya Saila Srivastava, Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances Secretary Nivedita Shukla Verma, Fisheries Secretary Abhilash Likh, and his wife Sukriti Likh, also a serving secretary at the Department of Ex-service Men's Welfare, Fertiliser Secretary Rajat Kumar Mishra, and Land Resources Secretary Narendra Bhooshan. They are among the people who remained "unmapped with the Last SIR". The bureaucrats against whom SIR notices are being issued for mismatch of names include Expenditure Secretary Vumlungmang Vualnam, Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) K Sanjay Murthy, a former IAS officer, faces the notice for "parent name mismatch".

Several retired bureaucrats and officials are among the persons against whom SIR notices are being issued for discrepancies and "no mapping".

Among them are former NITI Aayog vice-chairman Arvind Panagariya, former Election Commissioner Arun Goel, former JNU vice-chancellor and UGC chairman Mamidala Jagadesh Kumar, former Animal Husbandry Secretary Alka Upadhyay, former Consumer Affairs Secretary Rohit Kumar Singh, his wife and former CISO director-general Nina Singh, former Defence Secretary Giridhar Aramane, and former Environment Secretary Leena Nandan. Their names appear on the list of 594 electors for whom notices have been issued at the two New Moti Bagh polling booths under the Delhi Cantt Assembly constituency, where most top bureaucrats have their official residences.

Delhi CEO responds

Reacting to reports of the notices issued to "VIP" electors, the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer said in a statement on Sunday: "All stakeholders are hereby informed that issue of notice does not mean that their names will be deleted from the electoral rolls of NCT of Delhi. System generated notices are being issued to the above said categories to correct their data in ECINET. No name can be deleted without giving an opportunity to being heard and a proper, speaking, and appealable order."

The EC had published the draft roll of Delhi after weeding out 47.56 lakh electors, having declared them absent, shifted, dead or duplicate, on August 31. After that, the EC's centralised ECINET portal began generating notices to those on the draft roll. In a statement on September 19, the Delhi CEO had said that notices were being issued to those not linked to the last intensive revision and those with "logical discrepancies".

Those whose names have been deleted or flagged have till October 30 to file claims and objections. The final roll of Delhi is scheduled to be published on November 4.



नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार



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A family still waiting

Nearly two years after their daughter Harshita Brella was killed in the UK, her family returned to the places where she spent her final days, seeking answers about a case that remains unresolved, reports SAKSHI CHAND

For Harshita's family, the meeting with investigators was the most important part of their visit as they began their trip to the UK on May 14 in pursuit of justice. The family travelled back to India on May 28.

emerged," Sonia said. "They said that in an ongoing investigation, no such information can be shared. But they said both countries are in touch as far as the extradition of Lamba is concerned." The family had also hoped to attend another significant proceeding arising from the investigation. They were not permitted to do so.

On August 29, 2024, Harshita reported domestic abuse to the police. She was subsequently classified as being at high risk of domestic abuse, placed in a refuge, and assigned an Independent Domestic Violence Adviser. Lamba was arrested on September 3 and released on conditional bail two days later, on the condition that he would not contact Harshita. Despite her classification as being at high risk, she was killed on November 10, weeks after making her complaint. Her body was found four days later.

The case prompted the Independent Office for Police Conduct (I.O.P.C.), Britain's police watchdog, to open an investigation on November 20, 2024, after a referral from Northamptonshire Police. The investigation examined the actions of four police officers and whether their handling of Harshita's abuse allegations warranted misconduct proceedings.

The I.O.P.C. later determined that the allegations were serious enough to warrant formal disciplinary proceedings. "After a thorough review of the evidence, we have determined four officers should face disciplinary proceedings," said Derrick Campbell, the I.O.P.C.'s director of engagement. "It will be for a police disciplinary panel to determine whether the allegations are proven."

On May 21, 2026, two of the four officers – a sergeant and a chief inspector – faced misconduct hearings. "At first, we were invited to attend the hearing, and we went with the lawyers," Sonia said.

However, the family was later informed that it was a private hearing. "This was really unfair to us. We wanted to attend the hearing and find out whether there had been any lapses on the part of the officers," Sonia said, adding the family had serious concerns about how the police handled Harshita's case. They questioned whether officers had taken adequate steps to protect her after classifying her as being at high risk.

"The police themselves had classified the case as high risk," Sonia said. "There are serious concerns about how the unit handled the case and whether they gave Harshita enough protection. We will have answers to these questions only when the proceedings are made public."

However closed off the official proceedings were, the family found something warmer waiting for them elsewhere.

The trip was also an act of advocacy, and the family had not paid for it themselves. NGOs and private donors raised the funds that sent them to England, and once there, the family found a reception they had not expected.

"Local council members turned up at Harshita's memorial without being asked. Refugee-support groups offered solidarity," Sonia says.

The Member of Parliament for Corby met with the family personally. "We were promised that the case would stay a government priority. That is a positive," Sonia says.

The case in Delhi

Harshita's father learned of his daughter's death on November 15, 2024. Four days later, he filed a complaint at the Palam Village Police Station alleging dowry harassment and murder.

The case has moved forward on paper, even as the search for Lamba has not.

The case is now before the trial court and has reached a crucial stage. On September 29, the court is scheduled to hear arguments on framing the charges.

Investigators, however, say their primary focus remains tracing Lamba, the main accused. "We have obtained and analyzed call detail records and other technical data relating to the mobile numbers of Lamba and his relatives on several occasions in an attempt to establish his whereabouts," a senior police official said.

In May 2025, the police declared Lamba a proclaimed offender. They also issued a Look Out Circular to prevent him from leaving the country or to alert authorities if he attempted to re-enter. "We have also frozen the bank accounts," a police officer said. Investigators have also tracked Lamba's digital footprint, the officer said.

Notices were sent to a long list of companies, including three airlines and nine e-commerce platforms, as part of the effort to locate him. The inquiries, however, produced no information that helped trace Lamba, according to a police status report.

The only breakthrough, officials said, has been the arrest of Lamba's parents.

Back in the UK, investigators said they remain committed to securing justice for Harshita and her family.

"The investigation into Harshita Brella's death is ongoing... we are continuing to work with the appropriate agencies both in the UK and internationally," Detective Superintendent Johnny Campbell said in response to a query from *The Indian Express*. "We remain as determined as ever to secure justice for Harshita and her family."

WE PROMISE to fight for you to get justice. We can't forget you, Harshita.

The words were handwritten on a small card tucked into a bouquet of white and pink flowers – one of several such offerings that Satbir Singh and Sudesh Kumari carried across England this May, retracing the final days of Harshita Brella, the daughter they had lost.

The first bouquet was left at the Corby Boating Club in Northamptonshire, beside the lake where their elder daughter Sonia Dabas took a photograph of them that she still returns to.

In it, Satbir Singh and Sudesh Kumari are posed stiffly outside the cafe. It is the sort of place a family might visit on holiday. This was not a holiday. It was, in fact, the first time either of Harshita's parents had ever travelled abroad. "For most families, the first trip abroad is a milestone — a chance to see a new country, spend time together, create memories that last a lifetime," Sonia says. "But for us it was nothing like that." For fourteen days, the family moved from one address to another, each one a place their daughter had been.

Nearly two years earlier, CCTV cameras above the boating lake cafe at the Corby Boating Club had captured Harshita walking beside her husband, Pankaj Lamba. It was the last time she was seen alive. "When police released the footage, we watched it over and over," Sonia recalls. "It was the last time we would ever see her walking, alive, and we kept looking for anything – some sign, something we'd missed."

And on May 14, 2026, Sonia accompanied her parents to England. At the airport, Sonia remembers, her mother kept looking for Harshita. "Late ho gayi hogi" (she must be running late), she kept saying," Sonia says. "Even now, some part of her has not fully accepted that Harshita is gone."

After they checked in, the lake was the first stop. From there they went to the house in Corby where Lamba had been staying, and to the curb outside it where investigators alleged he parked the car that would later carry Harshita's body to Ilford, in east London.

Desperate for anything the investigation might have overlooked, the family went door to door – something a neighbour may have seen or heard but never told the police. "But they were reluctant to speak," Sonia says.

From Ilford, Lamba is alleged to have taken the Elizabeth line to Heathrow, before boarding a flight out of the country. According to court records, he landed in Mumbai on November 12, 2024, and from there flew on to Delhi.

The broad facts of Harshita's murder have been public for nearly two years. What brought her family to England this May was not new evidence but the absence of it — the slow, unresolved muddle of a case that has produced no arrest and no conclusion. "We could not be with her

then," Sonia says, "but at least we came by where she was now."

Signs they missed

There is one detail Harshita's family keeps returning to: the car was parked directly outside the house where her husband lived, close to a tree.

"Of everywhere we went, that was the hardest place to leave," Sonia says. "My mother broke down completely laying the flowers there – she couldn't stop crying, and none of us could console her."

"So far we don't know if he killed her at her house, or his house, or the lake, or where," Sudesh says, his voice breaking.

According to Northamptonshire police, Harshita was allegedly murdered somewhere in Northamptonshire and driven to Ilford, where her body was discovered in the boot of the car on November 14th; a post-mortem listed strangulation as the likely cause of death.

The hardest stop was the room – one Harshita had moved into on her own, after she left Lamba and was placed under police

protection. It was a small, cramped space in shared accommodation in Corby, sublet with a stranger, a far cry from the life the family had imagined for her when she left India as a bride.

"If we had even a little idea she was living in such a small place, struggling so much, it would have been a sign, a clue that something was horribly wrong," Sonia said. "We could have stepped in so much earlier."

It was only in August, Sonia says, that Harshita first told her family about the violence in her marriage – around the same time she was seen fleeing her home after an altercation with Lamba, on August 29, 2024. She later filed a do-

mestic abuse complaint and was placed under police protection.

"We urged her to come home," Sonia says. "But she wanted to stay and see the complaint through." On November 10, she called home for what would be the last time – she was making dinner, she said, and waiting for Lamba, who wanted to talk. Four days later, she was dead. Even now, the shock of it sits visibly on Sudesh's face. "We could not do anything," she says, looking again at the photograph of the room, guilt threading through every word.

Meeting the investigators

For Harshita's family, the meeting with investigators was the most important part of their visit. Among those present were Detective Superintendent Johnny Campbell, Deputy Chief Constable Ash Tuckley, and Police, Fire and Crime Commissioner Danielle Stone.

But the meeting offered the family few answers.

Sonia said the investigators told them that the case involved a serious crime and that they could not disclose much because the information was sensitive. "They did not really reveal if any new facts had



(Clockwise from top) Parents and sister at the spot where Harshita was seen alive for the last time; the spot where the car containing the body was kept for the night after Harshita's murder; the spot where the car with her body was eventually found; Harshita's family still looking for justice.



The screensaver of Harshita's sister Sonia Dabas' phone. TASHI TOBGYAL

Timeline of the case



AUG 29, 2024: Harshita reports domestic abuse

SEPT 3, 2024: Husband arrested, later released on bail

NOV 10, 2024: Cops believe she was killed after call with family

NOV 11, 2024: Lamba 'leaves' the UK for India

NOV 13, 2024: Family raises alarm; UK police begin a missing-person probe

NOV 14, 2024: Harshita's body is found in the boot of a car in Ilford

NOV 15, 2024: Autopsy indicates strangulation

DEC 3, 2024: Delhi Police lodges FIR on charges of dowry death

MAR 14, 2025: Lamba's parents arrested

MAR 19, 2025: Lamba charged with murder and other offences in the UK

MAR 31, 2025: Delhi HC asks police to expedite efforts to trace Lamba

MAY 1, 2025: Lamba declared proclaimed offender in India

JUNE 2025: Delhi Police files a chargesheet in the separate cruelty/dowry case



President Droupadi Murmu, Union Minister Manohar Lal and Supreme Court Justice B V Nagarathna in New Delhi on Sunday. ANI

SC shifting from anthropocentric to ecocentric approach: Justice Nagarathna

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, September 20

DESCRIBING THE contribution of the Supreme Court to environmental jurisprudence as “overwhelming and significant”, Justice B V Nagarathna on Sunday said the apex court is now pushing for a shift from an anthropocentric to an ecocentric approach on this aspect.

“Environmental adjudication is an exercise in foresight, requiring courts to govern the present with an alert consciousness of the future,” Justice B V Nagarathna said while addressing the valedictory session of an international conference on “The Future of Environment and Climate Dynamics” organised by the NGT. President Droupadi Murmu was the chief guest.

Environmental law must move away from treating nature as property, commodity or resource, Justice Nagarathna said.

“The contribution of the Supreme Court to environmental jurisprudence has been overwhelming and significant. In fact, the Supreme Court is now pushing for a shift from an anthropocentric approach to an ecocentric approach in matters of environment,” Justice Nagarathna said.

An anthropocentric approach regards human beings as the central or most vital element in the universe, while an ecocentric approach places the natural environment and ecosystems at the centre of moral consideration, rather than just human beings.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

Tata

against the resolution to reappoint Chandrasekaran, the Trusts said in a statement on Sunday. But the Tata Sons board went ahead with its decision to reappoint him for another five years on the basis of the his casting vote.

In its statement, the Trusts said the Articles of Association (AoA) of Tata Sons provide that no decision can be taken unless it has the affirmative support of at least a majority of the Directors nominated by the Tata Trusts. “This is a separate condition under the AoA,” it said, pointing out that the AoA does not leave any decision of the board to a mere head count of directors.

“The condition failed, and so did the resolution... The Chairman’s casting vote is available only where there is equality of votes at the overall board level. It does not apply amongst Tata Trusts’ Nominee Directors. Whether the result of the vote was 4:1, or any other figure, is irrelevant. A condition is either met, or it is not. In this case the condition was not met,” it said.

While Tata Trusts nominee Venu Srinivasan supported Chandrasekaran’s reappointment, Noel Tata voted against it. Four directors voted in favour of the resolution. The board announced it had resolved by majority vote to reappoint Chandrasekaran.

At the meeting of the Tata Sons’ board on September 17, 2026, Chandrasekaran acceded to the board’s request to re-consider his decision. The Board thereafter resolved by a majority vote to re-appoint him as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years upon the expiry of his current tenure,” Tata Sons said in its press statement after the board meeting.

Former Chief Justice of India DY Chandrachud has separately provided a legal opinion saying the affirmative support of Tata Trusts’ nominee directors was required and that a chairperson’s casting vote could not replace a missing majority.

“It is now being suggested that a refusal of support

SECOND-YEAR STUDENT DIES BY SUICIDE ON CAMPUS

After students’ protest, IIT-B agrees to demands

Pallavi Smart
Mumbai, September 20

AFTER TWO days of student protests following the suicide of 20-year-old IIT-Bombay student Sahil Wakode, the institute administration on Sunday agreed to students’ 18-point charter of demands. The details of the agreement will be formally placed before students at an open house Monday, after which the students will decide whether to continue with their agitation.

The development came after a lengthy discussion between students staging a sit-in near the main gate and IIT-Bombay director Prof Shireesh Kedare and other senior administrators. While the institute has not issued an official statement on the agreement, a livestream of the meeting showed the director signing the 18-point charter submitted by the students.

One of the demands was immediate suspension of Prof Suryanarayana Doolla, who was investigating the exam that Sahil took and has been named in the FIR based on the complaint by his parents. On the demand for



IIT Bombay Director Prof Shireesh Kedare addresses protesting students on the campus on Sunday night. EXPRESS

his suspension, Prof Kedare is seen saying in the livestream: “We will follow the process.”

The charter sought both immediate action in Sahil’s case and systemic changes to institute’s academic, disciplinary and mental-health systems. Sahil, a 2nd-year BTech student of Energy Science and Engineering, died by suicide Friday, hours after he was allegedly found with a mobile during a mid-semester exam. His parents have held Doolla responsible and alleged that he faced caste-based discrimination on campus.

The students have demanded an independent probe into

circumstances surrounding Sahil’s death, with an interim report by September 30 and a final report by October 15. They have also sought an open house with the director, Dean of Student Affairs and other senior officials, including the head of the Energy Science and Engineering department, by September 22. “The initial statement by the IIT Bombay administration stating use of AI platform by Sahil during exams, is like putting an allegation against a student who is not even here to defend himself. There is a rule that disciplinary action taken against any student is kept confidential,” a protesting

Eminent cardiologist who introduced 2D Echo test in India

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, September 20

RENOWNED CARDIOLOGIST Dr G Vijayaraghavan, who is credited with introducing 2D echocardiography or 2D Echo test in India, died in Thiruvananthapuram, two days after he turned 84, on Sunday.

A recipient of the Padma Shri award in 2009, Dr Vijayaraghavan had done pioneering and extensive research on tropical endomyocardial fibrosis — a medical condition in which thick scar tissue forms inside the heart chambers — which was prevalent in southern India.

He was instrumental in establishing India’s first 2D echocardiography laboratory at Government Medical College in

Thiruvananthapuram in the late 70s. The technique enabled more non-invasive imaging of the heart and helped expand the role of echocardiography in clinical cardiology.

To make 2D echocardiography scanner a reality in India, he had partnered with an India-US venture, which supplied the first 2D echocardiography to the medical college in the state capital. This had later paved the way for revolutionising heart care in India.

Apart from being a clinician, Dr Vijayaraghavan was passionate about grooming the next generation of cardiologists in the country. By leading medical education programmes and echocardiography workshops across the country, Dr Vijayaraghavan trained doctors in the use



{ DR G VIJAYARAGHAVAN }
1942-2026

of emerging cardiac imaging technology, leading to adoption of 2D echocardiography in India.

Dr Vijayaraghavan had also been credited with introducing treatment for poisoning caused by consuming Cerebra Odol-

lum (known as Othallanga in Kerala), which had become a prevalent method to commit suicide. The treatment modalities introduced by Dr Vijayaraghavan is credited with saving several lives.

After graduating from Government Medical College in Thiruvananthapuram in 1964, Dr Vijayaraghavan, a native of Kollam, began his career at CMC Vellore before joining his alma mater in 1976.

With the support of Royal Brompton and Harefield Education, London, Dr Vijayaraghavan did extensive research on endomyocardial fibrosis. His research had also covered other cardiac conditions including rheumatic mitral valve disease, congenital heart disease, and coronary artery morphology.

At university in Wardha, 4-yr-old dispute leads to student protests, FIR filed

Anita Deshkar
Nagpur, September 20

FOUR YEARS ago, Mahatma Gandhi Antarrashtriya Hindi Vishwavidyalaya (MGAHV) in Maharashtra’s Wardha shifted two of its departments to its regional centre in Prayagraj, saying it would boost enrolment and that the transfer was being done in “lokhit” (public good). Today, the move at the university — the only one in India dedicated to the promotion of Hindi, with the language the primary medium of instruction — is at the centre of a 3-month-long protest, leading to an FIR against six students.

Now, the students have reached out to CJP, with its convenor Abhijeet Dipke saying that asking for essential amenities cannot be a criminal activity. “The students are fighting for their Constitutional Right to Education.”

The protests began on July 3, when over 250 students signed a petition and submitted it to the administration, seeking the reopening of the two departments — Women Studies and Film Studies — as well as the restart of PhD admissions frozen since 2022, and the revival of language programmes. The protesters also want the university to rein-

state its discontinued diploma and certificate courses, such as language programmes for English, French, Japanese, Chinese, Spanish and Urdu.

On August 20, the protesting students converged near the university’s administrative building. The same night, an FIR was filed against Rajesh Kumar Yadav, Ramchandra, Niranjan Kumar, Rakesh Ahirwar, Rahul Kumar and Shilpujan, on charges of wrongful restraint, obstructing a public servant and common intention.

The university alleged the students didn’t seek permission for protest. Incidentally, the university came out with its rules concerning protests on August 31. “The university’s Discipline Committee has recommended an independent inquiry, pending which six students/research scholars have been barred from entering the campus. The students will be given an opportunity to present their case,” the administration said in a statement to *The Indian Express*. Wardha’s Ramnagar Police Station officers said the university has submitted photos and videos as proof. “We have given them a notice and let the students go. All of these are bailable offences,” a senior police official said.

Maharashtra Airport Development Company Ltd.
CIN: U45203MH2002SGC136979

TENDER NOTICE

MADC invites Tender for Consultancy Services for Upgradation of Passenger Terminal Building, ATC Tower & Fire Station at Shri Guru Gobind Singh Ji Airport, Nanded.

The detailed tender document can be downloaded from the website www.mahatenders.gov.in from **21/09/2026** from **14.00 hours**.

Sd/-
Vice Chairman & Managing Director, MADC

NAVI MUMBAI INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT

NOTICE INVITING EOI CUM RFQ FOR ENGINEERING, PROCUREMENT AND CONSTRUCTION OF THE NAVI MUMBAI INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT- PHASE III AT NAVI MUMBAI, MAHARASHTRA

Navi Mumbai International Airport Limited (“NMIAL”) entered into a concession agreement with the City and Industrial Development Corporation of Maharashtra Limited (“CIDCO”) on January 8, 2018 (the “**Concession Agreement**”) for the establishment, construction, development, operation, maintenance, and management of Navi Mumbai International Airport, Navi Mumbai, Maharashtra, India (the “**Airport**” or “**NMIA**”) on a design, build, finance, operate and transfer basis.

NMIAL has completed the development of Phase I and II of the Airport, providing an aggregate capacity of 20 million passengers per annum (“MPPA”), and commenced airport operations with effect from December 25, 2025. NMIAL now proposes to undertake the development of Phase III of the Airport to create an additional capacity of 50 MPPA. Accordingly, NMIAL has decided to undertake the engineering, procurement and construction of Phase III works of the Airport (the “**Airport Project**”).

For proposed development of Phase III of the Airport, NMIAL hereby invites responses to this Expression of Interest cum Request for Qualification (the “**EOI-CUM-RFQ**”) from suitably qualified, experienced, and reputed contractors for the Engineering, Procurement and Construction (“**EPC**”) works of the Airport Project.

The scope of the Airport Project comprises of the design, engineering, procurement, construction, testing, commissioning, and completion of various airport facilities and associated infrastructure to provide an additional passenger handling capacity of 50 MPPA, including, inter alia, Terminal, ATC Tower, Multi Modal Transportation Hub at the Central Terminal Complex, Airfield works, other airside & landside infrastructure facilities, Cargo Complex, Fuel Farm, Hangars, Metro Stations and other related works at the Airport.

Interested applicants may download and submit their response to the EOI-CUM-RFQ by registering on the NMIAL’s e-tender portal: <https://nmiairport.abcpocure.com>. For further details and instructions, please visit the E-tenders section of our **website**: <https://navimumbai.adaniairports.com>

EOI cum RFQ access shall be available from **22nd Sept 2026**, till **IST 3:00 PM on 6th Oct 2026**.

Note: NMIAL reserves the right to reject any response to EOI-CUM-RFQ or change / cancel the tender process at any time without prior notice or without assigning any reasons whatsoever.

NAVI MUMBAI INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LIMITED
Email: nmial.tenders2@adani.com
Website: <https://navimumbai.adaniairports.com>

OBITUARY

HAVILDAR RAHUL

04-02-1996 20-09-2026

Fraternity of Army Educational Corps expresses profound grief on the sad demise of Havildar Rahul. He will always be remembered for his selfless and dedicated service to the Corps.

We pray to the Almighty to bless eternal peace to the departed soul and give strength to the bereaved family.

Maj Gen Tamojeet Biswas
Addl DG AE & HoS (AEC)
and All Ranks of Army Educational Corps

EXPRESS Careers

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Pratap College (Autonomous)
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Applications are invited for the posts of

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Detailed advertisement, Educational Qualifications, Eligibility, Scale, Category etc. information is available on college website: www.pca.ac.in and K.B.C.N.M. University website : www.nmu.ac.in in. Candidates are informed to submit their applications within 15 days from publication of this advertisement by post, by hand or by E-mail on the following ID:- kespca23@gmail.com

Application Address: Principal, Pratap College (Autonomous), Amalner, Station Road, Amalner-425401, Dist-Jalgaon (MS)

Atg. Principal
Pratap College, Amalner

Secretary
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Sant Muktabai Arts and Commerce College,
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Invites applications for the post of Principal from eligible Candidates.

Sr.No.	Designation	No. of Posts	Nature of Post (Granted/Non-Granted)	Category
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Details of the advertisement-Educational Qualifications, Eligibility, Scale, Category etc. available on the College website : www.smcollege.in
Candidates are informed to submit their application within 15 days from the date of the publication of this advertisement.
Address for Correspondence : The Secretary, Vidya Bharati Shaikshani Mandal, C. K. Naidu Road, Camp, Amravati-444602.

Secretary**President**



Mutual Respect

BJP'S NORTH EAST Delhi MP Manoj Tiwari and the party's Rajya Sabha MP from Bihar Shivesh Kumar took a walk down memory lane during an informal gathering at the former's residence in the Capital on Saturday. Both the leaders hail from the Purvanchal region. While felicitating Kumar, who has recently been appointed the national president of the BJP's SC Morcha, Tiwari sought to underline that Kumar's family is firmly rooted in the BJP and has been associated with the party for generations. He said he happened to hail from a village that has been represented by Kumar's family over the years. To this, Kumar pointed out that Tiwari's own role in the BJP began as the booth in-charge of the village where his family has traditionally been associated with the party since its Jana Sangh days. He said Tiwari is an inspiration for all members of the BJP, which prides itself on its connection with each voter down to the polling booth level.

For the Record

AS HE rattled off data points on his government's push and India's achievements in the field of renewable energy and climate action during his keynote address at the NGT international conference on Saturday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi kept asking lawyers to pay attention to the numbers. From solar energy capacity expansion to prevention of emissions, Modi said, with a hint of wry humour, that these figures may come in handy someday, drawing a chuckle from a crowd of judges, lawyers and bureaucrats.

Objection Overruled

SENIOR ADVOCATE Sidharth Luthra, appearing for Telangana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy in the 2015 cash for votes row, told the Supreme Court recently that the judge who dealt with the matter in the High Court had to face allegations of regional bias. This was when the state of Telangana had just been formed and the High Court of Judicature at Hyderabad was still the common High Court for Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, he pointed out. "An application was moved saying 'you cannot hear this (case) because you belong to Andhra Pradesh. So there is a regional bias'. So a new ground for bias was sought to be taken. The judge had to first deal with the issue of bias before hearing the matter. The state had recently been carved out. It was preposterous...It was very unfortunate," Luthra said. The application was eventually rejected.

Respectable role for Ishan: Maya's latest U-turn

Lucknow: In another U-turn on the role of her family members in the BSP, party chief Mayawati Sunday announced that her nephew Akash Anand and niece Deepika Anand will no longer be given any responsibility in the party. However, she said her brother Anand Kumar's younger son Ishan Anand will be taken forward with a "respectable role" in organisation. Mayawati said on X she had reconsidered involving members of Anand Kumar's family in BSP and decided to keep Akash Anand and his sister away from party affairs.

ENS

Jaishankar to attend UNGA, may raise Russia sanctions Bill with US

Divya A
New Delhi, September 20

DAYS AFTER President Donald Trump signed the Russia sanctions Bill — allowing the United States to impose penalties on Russia's energy trading partners, including India — External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar is set to travel to the US, offering a window for the two sides to have a discussion on the issue.

Jaishankar is visiting New York for the High Level Week of the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly next week, and will also hold several bilateral meetings on the sidelines.

Announcing his visit on Sunday, the Ministry of External Affairs said in a statement: "EAM's address at the High Level Session of the 81st United Nations General Assembly is scheduled for September 26. During the visit, EAM will also attend various plurilateral and bilateral meetings."

After the US House of Representatives passed the Bill on Wednesday, New Delhi said it "remains firmly committed to ensuring energy security for its 1.4 billion people" and warned of "potential implications" for "the bilateral relationship" with the US.

The MEA underlined that "this issue has been discussed



EAM S Jaishankar is scheduled to address the General Debate in the afternoon session on September 26. @DRSJAISHANKAR

at high levels in recent months with various US interlocutors". The US move comes at a time when Delhi and Washington are trying to firm up a bilateral trade deal after months of ne-

gotiations. New Delhi has also conveyed to Washington, in the past weeks and months, the adverse impact of such a punishing move on the bilateral relationship.

President Trump is also attending the UNGA Session. He will address world leaders from the UNGA podium on September 22, his second address to the UN session in his second term in the White House. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio is also expected to be present for the event.

Jaishankar is scheduled to address the General Debate in the afternoon session on September 26, according to a revised provisional list of speakers

for the high-level session.

The year-long 81st session of the UN General Assembly will be presided over by Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman, who was elected in June to head the 193-member UN organisation.

The session this year comes amid continuing geopolitical conflicts across the world, including the US-Iran war that has had a cascading impact on the Global South, owing to rising food and fuel costs in the wake of the continued disruption in the Strait of Hormuz.

The heads of government of Bangladesh and Nepal will address the General Debate on September 24.

Sky-high exercise

IAF CHIEF Air Chief Marshal A P Singh and his Japanese counterpart General Takehiro Morita flew in separate Tejas jets, India's homegrown fighter aircraft, as part of a formation sortie during the bilateral air exercise.

FOR THE 14-DAY exercise 'Veer Guardian', being held at Air Force Station, Jodhpur, the IAF is participating with a diverse mix of frontline combat aircraft including indigenous LCA Tejas, Su-30 MKI and Rafale. JASDF is taking part with its F-2A fighter aircraft. For the first time, JASDF fighter aircraft are operating from Indian soil as part of a bilateral exercise.

Chief of Air Staff Air Chief Marshal A P Singh with Japan Air Self-Defense Force Chief of Staff General Takehiro Morita during the joint air exercise 'Veer Guardian' 2026 at Air Force Station in Jodhpur on Sunday. PTI



EXPRESS special

As succession row rages in BSP, meet Mayawati's eight key aides

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, September 20

The BSP has continued to reel from "family issues" ahead of 2027 UP elections with party president Mayawati, 70, recently announcing her "antim faisla (final decision)" that neither of her two nephews, Akash Anand and Ishan Anand, will engage in politics by holding any party position.

Her decision came days after she "completely freed" BSP national convener Akash, seen earlier as her "political successor", of all responsibilities and appointed Ishan as the party's chief sector coordinator. Since 2024, Mayawati has fired Akash from top party positions twice, only to reinduct him later.

In 2022 polls, BSP won just one of the 403 seats. In 2024 Lok Sabha polls, the party drew a blank in the state.

Over the last one year, Mayawati has made repeated changes in the organisational roles of her family members as well as senior leaders in a bid to maintain her authority in the party as its sole power centre. There has however been a core team of BSP leaders who have been working closely with her for years, with Mayawati regularly consulting them.

Anand Kumar

Mayawati's younger brother, Anand Kumar, the father of Akash and Ishan, is mandated to attend all national meetings of BSP in Lucknow and Delhi. Earlier this month, Mayawati also asked him to convene regular meetings of the party's two sectors comprising all the states, barring UP and Uttarakhand, and visit these states and give her the party's progress reports. She retained the charge of UP and Uttarakhand.

The BSP chief expanded Ku-



Anand Kumar, Satish Chandra Misra, Mewalal Gautam, Vishwanath Pal, Naushad Ali, and Ramji Gautam



mar's role after scrapping the post of the chief sector coordinator held briefly by Ishan. She recently said she was firmly against "nepotism" but because she is a woman, she was forced to keep her brother Kumar with her to ensure her safety so that she could continue steering the party smoothly.

Mayawati first appointed Kumar, 59, as the BSP vice-president after the 2017 UP polls, when the party faced a loss for the second consecutive time. In 2018, she announced Kumar's resignation to counter allegations of nepotism, only to reappoint him within a few months. The BSP supremo frequently seeks Kumar's opinion on organisational affairs, party sources said.

Satish Chandra Misra

BSP national general secretary since 2003, Satish Chandra Misra, 73, is a senior lawyer and three-term RS MP. He was the UP Advocate General from May 2002 to August 2003 during the then Mayawati regime. Last month, Mayawati entrusted Misra with the charge of legal and media matters besides the responsibility of the EC-related affairs in view of the upcoming UP polls.

"Behan ji (Mayawati) always consults Misra ji on legal issues, especially when she has to give her political opinion in the media on any government proposal or Bill or any constitutional

matter," said a BSP functionary. Misra has also been given the responsibility of developing "bhai-chara (brotherhood)" between Dalits and Brahmins in line with the party's social engineering formula. In the run-up to 2022 elections, Misra had addressed the party's "prabudha varg vi-char-gosthis", special meetings involving Brahmins, across the state.

Mewalal Gautam

Another BSP national general secretary Mewalal Gautam, who hails from Fatehpur, communicates Mayawati's decisions to the party rank and file. He also coordinates organisational programmes as well as Mayawati's meetings with party leaders.

Last year, Mayawati gave him the responsibility to hold monthly meetings of "Pichhda Varg Bhaichara Committees", which were formed to reach out to OBC voters. When Mayawati was the CM from 2007 to 2012, he was her OSD.

Mayawati had assigned Mewalal the task of monitoring the party's campaign in all 84 SC-reserved seats of UP during the 2022 elections. But the party did not win any of these seats.

Arvind Kumar Gautam

Working from the BSP office in Delhi, party national general secretary Arvind Kumar Gautam plays a significant role in organising meetings of senior

party leaders in the national capital. He is also mandated to make necessary arrangements when the party organises the workers' events at Bahujan Prerna Kendra in Delhi and Rashtriya Dalit Prerna Sthal in Noida to pay tributes to B R Ambedkar and party founder Kanshi Ram.

When Akash Anand had been a key BSP face, Arvind also used to coordinate his tours for rallies and workers' meetings.

Sridhar

BSP treasurer Sridhar, who is from Tamil Nadu, has been involved in the party's affairs in the southern states because of his proficiency in multiple languages besides Hindi and English, sources said. During elections, Sridhar has been responsible for getting information about candidates with pending criminal cases published in the media or social media.

Ramji Gautam

RS MP Ramji Gautam, 50, is currently the BSP's only member in Parliament and one of the party's key "strategists" with a "sound understanding" of its functioning, according to insiders. His term expires in November this year. "Behan ji guides him on parliamentary matters and issues to be raised in the House," said party insiders.

Ramji, who is from Lakhimpur Kheri, is an MBA graduate

who studied chemical engineering, and also runs a business. In 2018, Mayawati named him as the BSP national vice-president. In June 2019, she made him the party's national coordinator as Anand Kumar replaced him as the vice-president. He has served as the party in-charge of several states including Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Kerala, Bihar, MP, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Delhi, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Rajasthan.

In 2022, Mayawati named Ramji as the BSP's central coordinator.

Vishwanath Pal

Months after losing 2022 UP polls, Mayawati in December that year appointed an MBC (Most Backward Class) leader Vishwanath Pal as the new state party chief. "His reputation in the BSP is of a missionary — a diligent and faithful worker. As he is the UP party chief, Behan ji regularly speaks to him to review the party's preparations for 2027 Assembly elections and about its organisational teams," sources said.

Pal has also been handling the party's outreach to OBCs while being engaged in supervising the work of its Pichhda Varg Bhaichara Committees along with Mewalal Gautam.

Naushad Ali

A former member of the UP Legislative Council, Naushad Ali is the lone Muslim face among the BSP's national office bearers. A party national secretary hailing from Kannauj district, Naushad has been among those leaders with whom Mayawati interacts to seek suggestions on minority issues. In February this year, he was allotted the charge of Lucknow, Kanpur, and Agra mandals to consolidate Muslim votes ahead of 2027 polls.

ROW OVER MIMICRY AT LoP EVENT
Party of jokers, says BJP; Congress hits back: Rahul Gandhi stands with students

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, September 20

A DAY after a stand-up comedian mimicked PM Narendra Modi at Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi's 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' event in Indore, the BJP lashed out at the Congress on Sunday, saying it had turned into a "circus" and called Gandhi an "asanskari naraz fufu (uncultured grumpy uncle)".

The Congress hit back, without referring to the BJP's attack, saying the people of the BJP-RSS have corrupted the education system, and asserted that Gandhi is standing with the students as they demand accountability.

The war of words started over a video shared by Congress on X in which comedian Pulkit Mani is seen mimicking PM Modi during a skit with Gandhi during the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' event Saturday. The video also included a few clips of PM Modi with international leaders and carried a tag — "Narendra Modi's foreign policy". In the video, the comedian is seen pointing to the audience and saying: "Maa ko kursi do, maa..."

Reacting sharply, Union Minister Piyush Goyal said on X, "Asanskari naraz fufu." "The irony writes itself. The need to come on stage every now and then just to drag Prime Minister Modi ji's name into cheap political theatre never fails to amaze me," Goyal wrote, asking Gandhi to "look in the mirror".

Union Minister Kiren Rijiju said, "I hadn't imagined that a party which was in power for nearly six decades would turn into such a circus that is busy entertaining their own shrunken supporters."

"Congress party has become a party of comedians and jokers! They are out forever.... RIP," Rijiju said. "Do you feel abso-



Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi in Indore. PTI FILE

lutely no shame in mocking an elderly mother and the PM," he asked Gandhi, posting on X a video of PM Modi in which he is seen asking for a chair for an elderly woman at his rally.

Without taking Gandhi's name, UP CM Yogi Adityanath said Sunday said "Congress's Yuvraj's behaviour" in his "jhooth ki goonj" programme was an insult to the entire "naari shakti". "Those whose only goal in life is insulting India and Indianness... the country should stop expecting from them..." he said.

Countering BJP's attack, the Congress on Sunday said Gandhi was only exposing the anti-student system.

Tagging Gandhi's post on the programme, Congress general secretary in-charge of communications Jairam Ramesh said: "Yesterday, Rahul Gandhi ji exposed the system that has been suppressing students. Who is this system? People of BJP-RSS who have seized control over the country. On education, on the economy, on politics, on every institution." "They have hollowed out and corrupted the education system. Because this system fears students. Students ask questions. Now Rahul ji stands with them, the fear among students has ended. Their voice is echoing across the country," Ramesh said on X.

‘Centre, Punjab keep blaming each other as drugs enter villages’

OF LATE, Jalandhar MP and former Punjab CM Charanjit Singh Channi has been at the centre of Punjab Congress's internal feud. In an interview with Man Aman Singh Chhina, the Congress leader speaks about the problems plaguing Punjab, his vision for the state if the party comes to power, and the problem posed by gangsters, among other issues. Excerpts:

While Punjab Police claims a large-scale crackdown on drugs, why does the Opposition still say 'chitta' (drugs) is easily available?

If government claims that seizures have increased, it begs the question: where are the drugs coming from and why is the supply continuing? Seizures are important but cannot be a measure of success by themselves. We need to examine the supply chain. More importantly, we need to see why these (drug) networks continue to operate.

I believe the Yudh Nashian Virudh campaign cannot be merely about hoardings, advertisements and political statements. The people need to see an impact on the ground.

If Congress returns to power, what would first change in the police, transfers or accountability?

The first change has to be in the way that the police system functions. Punjab needs professional, accountable and politically insulated policing. Transfers must not become a tool of political management. Accountability needs to be fixed at entry-level, particularly at district level. In the short term, we need stronger intelligence, better investigation and identification of drug networks to act against organised crime. The ultimate objective is not more arrests and FIRs but to break criminal ecosystem.

The Centre has listed Amritsar, Gurdaspur, Tarn Taran, Ferozepur, Fazilka



CHARANJIT SINGH CHANNI
FORMER PUNJAB CM

and Ludhiana as ultra-sensitive drug zones...

The Centre is absolutely right in identifying these districts as ultra-sensitive drug zones. Most of these districts are along the international border and the Centre has the responsibility of preventing drugs entering India. In 2021, the Centre expanded the BSF's jurisdiction in border states to up to 50 km from the border. The Centre must answer what more is being done to stop the supply of drugs at the border.

Apart from the Pakistan border, drugs can also reach Punjab from neighbouring states such as Rajasthan and Gujarat. Border security and inter-state trafficking require coordination of central agencies. This is not to say Punjab government can evade responsibility. What we have is a situation where the Centre and state keep blaming each other while drugs continue to percolate into our villages.

What would your '100-day plan' on drugs, and law and order look like?

At the heart of our approach will be political will, the courage to confront the drug mafia. The first 100 days would establish direction and accountability. The immediate task will be to break supply chain and take action against those who profit from drug trade. Those trapped in addiction should have access to treatment, counselling and rehabilitation. Our children must see classrooms, playing fields, and workplaces as path to a better future.

NLSIU cancels screening of Umar Khalid documentary

Express New Service
Bengaluru, September 20

AFTER POSTPONING the screening of *Prisoner No. 626710* is *Present* — a documentary on jailed former JNU student and activist Umar Khalid — last week, the student body and society committee of National Law School of India University (NLSIU), Bengaluru, has decided to cancel the programme.

The decision comes two days after IIT Hyderabad cancelled the screening of the documentary. At NLSIU, the documentary, directed by filmmaker Lalit Vachani, was initially planned to be screened on September 12. However, RSS-affiliated Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) opposed the move, writing letters to the Union Home Minister and the Governor, threatening to stage a protest against the event. A member of the student body said the screening could lead to FIRs against students and faculty, which could impact their education.

3 college students die as BMW falls off Mumbai Coastal Road

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, September 20

IN ONE OF the deadliest crashes on Mumbai's Coastal Road, three college students were killed and another critically injured when their BMW car crashed through the road's outer wall and plunged nearly 75 feet early Sunday.

The deceased were identified as Shanay Falgun Gajjar, 21, who was driving the car, Aditya Jakasania, 19, and Dhairya Sheth, 17. Their friend Aditya Oswal, 23, survived the crash but suffered severe head injuries and multiple fractures. He was initially taken to Nair Hospital and later shifted to Jaslok Hospital, where he remains unconscious in the ICU.

The four, all from Ahmedabad, knew each other through common friends. Jakasania and Sheth were pursuing a diploma in architecture at a college in Vile Parle and were staying in hostels in Santacruz.

Gajjar and Oswal were studying at a college in Kurla and staying separately as paying guests in Juhu. Their parents are businessmen, police said.

The group had come to South Mumbai to spend time together, police said, apparently treating the night as an outing before Sunday. Their movements and the places they visited before the crash are being verified.

The accident occurred around 5 am, when the BMW was travelling northbound from Marine Drive. Police said the car hit the outer wall while negotiating a turn and then plunged several metres away from the road, overturning three to four times. One of the occupants was thrown out through the sunroof and landed nearly 20 metres from the vehicle.

A motorist travelling behind the BMW witnessed the crash and alerted the police control room. A Tardeo police team



Wreckage of the BMW after it plunged 75 feet off the Coastal Road in Mumbai, early morning on Sunday. AKASH PATIL

reached the spot within about 10 minutes.

"Initially, we could see brush marks on the outer wall but could not locate the vehicle. We then went down and found the damaged BMW several metres away from the road," a police officer said.

All four airbags had deployed. The three students were found dead at the spot,

while Oswal was alive and was rushed to Nair Hospital, where doctors said he suffered multiple fractures and a head injury. He was later shifted to Jaslok Hospital by his family. The other three were declared dead on arrival, hospital staff said. Their bodies were sent for post-mortem.

Police suspect the BMW was travelling at a very high speed.

"Looking at the condition of the vehicle and the injuries suffered by the occupants, we suspect that the car may have been travelling at a speed of more than 150 kmph. The driver appears to have lost control while negotiating the turn," an officer said.

The BMW was registered in Gujarat in the name of Gajjar's family. Police traced the vehicle's registration details and contacted the registered mobile number. Gajjar's father answered the call and was informed about the crash.

Police subsequently contacted Jakasania's roommate, who told investigators that he had left his accommodation the previous evening to meet his friends. He was unaware of where the group had gone.

Forensic experts examined the crash site and the damaged vehicle and collected evidence. The Tardeo police have registered an accidental death report.

BRIEFLY



The electrocution incident happened near Kalachowki, Mumbai, on Sunday night. AKASH PATIL

MAHARASHTRA

8-yr-old, woman die of electrocution during Ganpati darshan at Lalbaug

AN EIGHT-YEAR-OLD girl was among two people who died on the night of Ganpati *darshan* in Lalbaug after a gush of water from a collapsed tarpaulin at a cold drink stall came in contact with electrical wiring, sending an electric shock through a crowd. Four others were injured in the incident outside the Kalachowki Cha Mahaganapati Mandal early Sunday. The stall owner has been booked. The deceased have been identified as Raghini Yadav (8) and Sujata (33). The victims were taken to Masina Hospital and Global Hospital. Police have booked stall owner Kamal Shetty, under Sections 106 (1) (for causing death by negligence) and 125 (b) (Causing grievous hurt by act endangering life or personal safety of others). ENS

Anti-drug drive: 12,111 arrested in Kerala so far

AS MANY AS 12,111 persons have been arrested in cases registered as part of Operation Toofan, a statewide anti-drug drive launched by the Kerala Police, officials said on Sunday. The police said, 11,241 cases have been registered under the operation so far, with 198 persons arrested in 188 cases on Saturday. Police have so far seized 24,010.6 grams of MDMA, 1,520.724 kg of ganja, 541.547 grams of heroin and 708.819 grams of brown sugar as part of the drive, which was launched in June this year after the UDF government came to power, officials said. PTI

Jharkhand Naxal leader dies in encounter

THE UP POLICE early Sunday morning gunned down a commander of a Jharkhand-based banned Naxalite organisation, Tritiya Prastuti Committee (TPC), in an encounter in the Ram Nagar area of Varanasi, officials said. According to police, they tried to stop Brijesh Ganju alias Gopal Singh Bhokta. He was on a bike with an associate at Tegara crossing towards Mughalsarai via Ramnagar. Brijesh jumped off the bike and allegedly began firing at the police. In the ensuing fire, he sustained bullet injuries. He was declared dead at a hospital. ENS

HC notice to Gujarat govt, Adani firm on journalist Ravi Nair's plea against NBW

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, September 20

THE GUJARAT High Court (HC) has issued a notice to the Gujarat government and Adani Enterprises on a petition moved by journalist Ravi Nair challenging a non-bailable warrant issued against him by a Gandhinagar sessions court, following which he was taken into custody and sent to jail on September 17.

A single-judge bench of Justice M K Thakker on Saturday passed an order and posted the matter for Monday.

In February, a magisterial court in Mansa of Gandhinagar district had convicted Nair of criminal defamation on the basis of a complaint filed by Adani Enterprises Limited. The court had sentenced him to one year's simple imprisonment and

imposed a fine of Rs 5,000 over a series of tweets he made between October 2020 and July 2021 and articles published on a website. Subsequently, Nair had challenged his conviction before a sessions court and the court granted him bail on the condition that he would remain present during the appeal.

On September 3, Nair did not remain present personally before the sessions court and sought exemption from the same. However, the application was rejected and the sessions court issued a non-bailable warrant against Nair.

On September 17, Nair appeared before the sessions court and moved an application for the cancellation of the NBW. However, the court rejected the application and ordered him to be taken into judicial custody. He was subsequently sent to jail.

EXPRESS special

Forces comb Pir Panjal to stop terrorist movement between Jammu, Kashmir

Forces operated out of Temporary Operational Bases for tight vigilance

Bashaarat Masood & Arun Sharma
Srinagar/Jammu, September 20

ON SEPTEMBER 4, a Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) terrorist was killed in Ashdar Gali, in the upper reaches of the Pir Panjal mountains, connecting Kashmir with Jammu's Poonch. The operation followed a four-month effort by joint forces of the Army, its elite para forces, J&K Police, and paramilitary forces deployed in the dense Pir Panjal mountains.

The operation showed a decided shift in the way security forces were approaching the arduous Pir Panjal, a terrain long considered a decisive advantage to terrorists: it showed that the joint team of forces operated out of a Temporary Operational Base (TOB), which helped the security agencies maintain a sustained presence and tight vigil over the area after a series of setbacks over the last three years.

"This is a temporary arrangement to maintain a more permanent footprint in the difficult mountain terrain," a senior police officer said. "Under this set-up, the security forces remain deployed in the mountains for extended periods, ranging from more than 10 days to several months. If a natural shelter is available, like a Gujar dhok (shack) or a cave, they use it as a temporary base. Otherwise, they operate from the dense forests without a shelter."



Temporary Operational Bases (TOBs) are scattered across the mountains based on intel by security agencies. SHUAIB MASOODI

Officials say the mountains are divided into three zones — the upper reaches, the middle range and the lower reaches. Typically, the army's elite paratroopers are deployed in the higher reaches. The middle range is manned either by the Rashtriya Rifles, the army's anti-insurgency force, or the joint teams of J-K Police and paramilitary forces, depending on what's required, and the lower ranges usually have J&K Police and paramilitary forces.

After the Pahalgam attack on tourists in April last year that killed 25 tourists and one local, J&K Police established a new elite unit within its Special Operations Group (SOG) to strengthen operations in challenging terrain. The units are named 'Snow Leopards' and 'Markhor'. While the 'Snow Leopards' unit is trained for high-altitude warfare in rough terrain during the winter, 'Markhors' are trained for gun-fights in dense forests.

"The paratroopers are specially trained and equipped for high-altitude warfare," said another senior officer. "They are often stationed at mountain tops and use drones to monitor

large swathes of the terrain."

Officials say that over the last four years, terrorists often exploited the high-altitude transit routes running through the dense forests to move between Kashmir and Jammu regions.

"In high altitudes, combat militants had several advantages. For one thing, they were at a stationary position that helped watch soldiers, and, for another, they had sophisticated weapons such as the American M4 carbine that were highly efficient in close combat," the officer said. "Now, the special troops deployed in these mountains are also equipped with more sophisticated weapons comparable to M4 carbines. They also have night vision devices for effective patrolling at night."

Manning Pir Panjal

The Pir Panjal mountains divide the Jammu and Kashmir regions. To the south are Jammu's Poonch and Rajouri districts, which connect to the Line of Control (LoC). Towards the north lies the Kashmir Valley. The mountains connect Kashmir to the Pir Panjal region — Poonch and Rajouri districts — of Jammu on one side, and

the Chenab Valley, comprising Doda, Kishtwar and Ramban districts, on the other. In Kashmir, the mountains stretch to Gulmarg and Baramulla, connecting the Valley to the Line of Control.

The Poonch-Rajouri axis in Jammu was a militant hotbed, and would see a large number of militants — mostly foreigners — openly moving through the forests. In 2003, the Indian Army, with the help of locals, launched Operation Sarp Vinash to flush out militants. The region was declared militant-free in 2012.

However, over the last few years, the difficult mountains covered by dense forests have been a major challenge for the security forces.

"Before, whenever the security forces launched operations south of Pir Panjal, the terrorists would move into Kashmir valley," the officer said. "Similarly, sustained pressure on this side of the Pir Panjal would lead them to move to Poonch and Rajouri. These temporary bases have taken away that advantage by allowing the security forces to maintain a sustained presence across these routes."

There are also other challenges — such as changing overground worker networks and newer terrorist hideouts in the area, which make tracking challenging.

Officials hope that the Temporary Operational Bases (TOBs) resolve these problems. The bases are scattered across the mountains based on "intelligence inputs and ground situation analysis" by the security agencies. Officials said while most remain operational for a few weeks, some — one at Ashdar Gali above the Doodhpathri meadow — are maintained for several months at a time, depending on the security situation and intelligence inputs.

• IN THE HATE CRIMES THAT FOLLOWED THE TERROR ATTACK, BALBIR SINGH, OWNER OF A GAS STATION IN MESA, ARIZONA, WAS ONE OF THE FIRST VICTIMS; ROQUE APOLOGISED IN 2016

Balbir Singh & Frank Roque: Among the tragedies of 9/11, a story of overcoming hate

Divya Goyal Gopal
Ludhiana, September 20

ON SEPTEMBER 11, 2001, as the World Trade Centre Towers in New York came crashing down, so did the world of the Sodhi family.

In the anger following one of the deadliest terror attacks the world has seen, people wearing turbans — mistakenly linked to al-Qaeda chief Osama bin Laden — became targets of racist assaults. One of them was Balbir Singh Sodhi, 49, who was shot dead outside his gas station in Mesa, Arizona, on September 15, 2001, becoming the first Sikh victim of the hate crimes.

Twenty-five years later, Balbir's story is less about hate than overcoming it.

Sometime in 2013-14, the Sodhi family made the first

overture to the man who shot Balbir five times, Frank Roque. Finally, in a 2016 phone call with a repentant Roque, in jail, they "forgave" him, "for his and our own peace". There were tears on both sides.

The same sentiment prevailed this September 15 when, to mark 25 years of Balbir's death, the local community of Mesa gathered to pay their homage. People from all faiths — Sikhs, Hindus, Muslims, Jews, Christians — led by local Mayor Mark Freeman and city council member Rich Adams, were present. Balbir's brother Rana Singh Sodhi told *The Indian Express*. "Ardaas (prayers) was held not just for the hate violence victims but for all who died on 9/11."

Balbir was one among eight brothers, with Rana, now 60, the youngest. Two of the

brothers are dead, four including Rana are in the US, while two still live in India. Balbir arrived in the US in 1988. His wife Harjinder Kaur and three sons live in the US, while two daughters are married and live in Canada and India, respectively. The family, which has its roots in Nadala of Punjab's Kapurthala district, owns multiple gas stations and restaurants in the US.

Says Rana: "Every year on his (Balbir's) death, we organise small events. This time, to mark the 25th, we coordinated with several organisations working on spreading awareness about the Sikh community to reduce hate crimes, including The Revolutionary Love, the Sikh Coalition, the National Sikh Campaign."

Speaking about the attack on



A memorial service on Balbir Singh Sodhi's 25th death anniversary at his gas station in Mesa, Arizona.

Balbir, in the US Congress on September 15, Greg Stanton, an elected representative from Arizona, said: "He was the very first victim of a hate crime after 9/11. He was murdered because of the colour of his skin and the turban he wore... But in the years since,

Arizona's Sikh community has transformed that tragedy into something greater: a call for peace, for understanding, for unity, forgiveness...."

Rana recalls that in the days after 9/11, as reports of hate crimes spread, the Sikh commu-

nity had got threats. A decision was taken by Sikh community to call the local media and explain who the Sikhs were, and how they had no connection to bin Laden. It was to happen on the coming Sunday. "On Saturday, my brother was shot," Rana says.

While there is no official data on attacks on Sikhs post-9/11, some organisations who collected such information put the number of those killed from South Asian communities at about 20. Balbir's killing stood out for being the first.

Around the time of Balbir's 13th death anniversary, Rana says, he ran into Roque's wife and daughter at a store where he had gone to buy flowers for his memorial. He could not place them at first, he says. "I even asked them if they were

customers at my Indian restaurant. But they said they never had Indian food... As I was leaving, something clicked. I remembered seeing them during the court proceedings."

Rana went back, telling Roque's daughter about what had happened. "I then invited them to come for the memorial that day. They refused, but told Roque about our meeting, how I was very polite to them."

In 2016, Valerie Kaur, who runs the Revolutionary Love Project, approached Rana to ask if he would like to speak to Roque. On September 16, 2016, the phone call took place, with Rana and Kaur at one end and Roque at the other, from prison. "He defended himself at first and said 9/11 broke him as an American. But, he said, his

daughter had told him how I was kind to her, and said he was grateful. And then came the apology. He said he was sorry for what he did. He said he was a heart patient, and if he died, he would ask God to let him see my brother, hug him and ask for forgiveness... We both broke down," Rana says.

"That was the moment of peace and closure for us, for him... My sister-in-law (Balbir's wife) did not want revenge... I told him we had already forgiven him." While Roque was given the death sentence by a local court, it was commuted to life by the Supreme Court. "He promised me if he came out on parole, he would visit schools, churches with me and educate Americans about Sikhs. But he died in prison in 2022," says Rana.

Tyeb, Bawa, Raza: NGMA Mumbai seeks CBI nod to display priceless ‘seized’ art

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, September 20

A TYEB Mehta painting worth Rs27 crore, a Manjit Bawa valued at over Rs7.7 crore... and 63 more works by some of India's most celebrated artists. All these are currently with the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA), Mumbai, but not on display. The reason: These are seized artworks belonging to accused persons facing trial in the Rs 34,000-crore Dewan Housing Finance Limited (DHFL) "fraud" case.

However, the NGMA now wants to display the artworks. On August 5, NGMA Mumbai Director Nidhi Choudhari, an IAS officer, sought the permission of the CBI to display these works as part of the gallery's curated exhibitions. In response to the request, the CBI has since moved an application before Special Judge Sanjeev Kumar Malhotra of Rouse Avenue Court.

Sixty-five paintings and three sculptures have been lying in the museum's storage for close to two years. The artworks include Bull by Tyeb Mehta, valued at over Rs27 crore; a Manjit Bawa work estimated at over Rs7.7 crore; S.H. Raza's Village, an oil-on-canvas work from 1956



NGMA Mumbai wants to display these works as part of its curated exhibitions. ARCHIVE

valued at over Rs3.50 crore; and a 1964 oil-on-linen work by F.N. Souza, valued at Rs2 crore.

The artworks are linked to the DHFL bank "fraud" case. The case was registered on a complaint by the Union Bank of India, the lead bank of a 17-bank consortium that had extended credit facilities of over Rs42,000 crore to DHFL since 2010. Of this, Rs 34,615 crore remains outstanding. The banks accused DHFL of siphoning off Rs34,900 crore. According to the CBI, DHFL allegedly diverted Rs 11,700 crore to 87 shell companies, 81 of which were linked to the Wadhawan group - whose members are key accused in the case. It goes back to September 6, 2024 when the then Special

Judge Ashwani Kumar Sarpal was hearing a plea by Deepak Ravi Kapoor, a prosecution witness, seeking the return of two paintings by Manjit Bawa and Tyeb Mehta. The prosecution had put their market value at around Rs 30 crore.

The two paintings had been purchased by the Wadhawans from the online auction house 'Astaguru' on June 11, 2018. As per the court order, the CBI "could not dispute the fact that these costly paintings are required to be kept in proper atmosphere under controlled temperature, away from moisture, to be handled and stored in proper manner as well as to avoid any damage to it even caused through normal wear and tear etc, so that its value is not de-

creased due to passage of time." "The apprehension of the applicant that the paintings will be destroyed or its value will be decreased while lying in the Malkhana of CBI can be removed by giving certain directions as the CBI is not well equipped to preserve the paintings in its Malkhana. The interests of the well known painters who had prepared these paintings are also required to be taken care of even though they had sold these paintings and received money," the court had said. The CBI had seized the paintings on July 8, 2022 from the house of a co-accused and argued before the court that they had been bought with diverted funds and were therefore "case property". Subsequently, other artworks were also seized. All of these are now lying at the NGMA in Mumbai.

While the court rejected Kapoor's plea for the return of the two paintings, it did not leave the works where they were.

"...in order to preserve the paintings and to avoid causing of any harm to it, it is directed to the CBI that these two paintings be shifted to National Museum or well known government museum or reputed art gallery including the National Art Gallery for proper preservation in controlled atmosphere, climate etc

with directions to produce the same as and when required by the court," the judge had said.

"These paintings be kept there till the conclusion of the trial and all the expenses for its preservation in the above-mentioned museum or art gallery shall be incurred by the CBI unless the said institution waive such expenses at the request of the CBI," the judge had said.

The issue resurfaced when a fresh application was moved by the CBI seeking necessary directions in connection with the NGMA letter dated August 5. The court took it up on September 8. On September 14, lawyers representing the accused persons submitted that the NGMA director's letter did not say that if the works were damaged "who will suffer that loss and whether they will get those paintings and sculptures insured in order to avoid any loss or damage". Nor, they said, did the letter clarify "for which period the National Gallery of Modern Art, Mumbai wants to display the seized 65 paintings and 3 sculptures."

A day later, the CBI told the court that the NGMA director was seeking permission to display the artworks in the gallery "on regular basis or till further directions of the court". The court will now hear the plea on September 24.

Salve, Singhvi weigh in on Tata boardroom battle

Salve: Tata global institution, can't be run by trustees; Singhvi cites SC order on Tata-Mistry case which upheld Trusts primacy

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 20

SENIOR ADVOCATES Harish Salve and Abhishek Manu Singhvi said that the ongoing battle between Tata Sons and Tata Trusts is likely to move from the boardroom to a courtroom.

Salve is likely to appear for Tata Sons, with Singhvi representing Noel Tata or Tata Trusts in the case. Singhvi said on X that shareholder — owners' fundamental rights "cannot be nullified in the manner in which they have been."

The Tata Sons board on Thursday approved a five year term for chairman N Chandrasekaran in a 4-1 vote, after he said in August that he would not seek another term. Noel Tata, Chairman of Tata Trusts, which holds about 66% of Tata Sons, voted against the move. Trust's nominee Venu Srinivasan voted in favour.

The board, decided by majority to proceed with steps towards a public listing after the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) rejected a Tata Sons' application for deregistration as an upper layer non-banking finance company.

Salve, a former Solicitor General of India who has acknowledged advising Tata Sons and Chandrasekaran, spoke to ANI from London when asked about



Senior advocates Harish Salve (left) and Abhishek Manu Singhvi

a listing. He described the Tata Group as India's largest corporate enterprise and said it is "the face of India". He said the group holds assets it has received from the government, including Air India, does defence work for the government and is setting up hydrogen projects.

"They are a global institution. A global institution cannot be run by three trustees saying we want it to go by our culture, what culture are we talking about? Today, in the day and age of transparency, an institution must refresh itself from time to time and the best talent must run this institution for the sake of not just the company, not for the shareholders, but for India," he told ANI.

Singhvi, a Rajya Sabha member who has previously represented Tata Sons in 2021 against Cyrus Mistry, is advising Tata Trusts. In a post on X, he said he was entering the dispute as lead lawyer for one side and

regretted that the issues could not be resolved amicably, citing earlier work with Ratan Tata.

In his reading, the Supreme Court's 2021 judgment in the Tata-Mistry case gave the Trusts primacy in their relationship with Tata Sons and upheld the special Articles. He said unanimity in Trust voting and the veto provisions had been applied for decades, and that a relationship of over a hundred years should not be severed. Without collegiality, he said, the issues would require legal resolution.

In a statement on Sunday, Tata Trusts said the September 17 resolution is void ab initio. It said Article 121 of Tata Sons' Articles of Association requires the affirmative vote of a majority of Trust-nominated directors, and that a casting vote applies only where board votes are equal. It also said Tata Sons has voluntarily adopted governance practices of public companies.

'Disparaging to Sanatan tradition': UP CM targets former V-P Ansari

Press Trust of India
Noida, September 20

UTTAR PRADESH Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday accused former vice-president Mohammad Hamid Ansari of attempting to tarnish India's image with his statements "disparaging India's Sanatan tradition and insulting its Hindu tradition".

Addressing the 'Prerna Vimarsh' event at the Gautam Buddha University in Greater Noida, Adityanath said India's cultural traditions should not be viewed as a threat, referring to

the "unfortunate statement" made by Ansari two days earlier.

The former vice president on Friday cited former prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru's view that the "real danger to India was not communism, but Hindu right-wing communalism" while speaking at an event in New Delhi commemorating late constitutional expert and author A G Noorani.

He was speaking at an event organised at the India Islamic Cultural Centre to commemorate Noorani and referred to his 2019 book, "The RSS: A Menace to India".

Adityanath said, "It does not befit us to refute it; however, his statements were truly alarming regarding India's traditions and culture. An attempt was made to tarnish India's image. He made statements disparaging India's Sanatan tradition and insulting its Hindu tradition, and made malicious attempts to link it to terrorism." "India is a secular state in the global context because it is a nation of Sanatan Dharma, with a majority of its people taking pride in their traditions, the lineage of sages, ancestors, deities and cultural heritage," he said.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

In proud memory of "BRAVE HEARTS" of 6h Battalion The Dogra Regiment, who made the supreme sacrifice while serving the Nation during INDO PAK WAR on 21 Sep 1965. Their act of valour, raw courage & devotion to duty will always remain a source of inspiration and motivation to all of us.

'BRAVES DIE, BUT ONLY ONCE'
REMEMBERED BY COMMANDING OFFICER AND ALL RANKS 6 DOGRA.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans on their Balidan Diwas.

CONSTABLE
BIMAL BARUA
69 BN BSF
05.08.1963
- 21.09.1991

CONSTABLE
PRADEEP KR
MISHRA
100 BN BSF
17.06.1978 -
21.09.2005

CONSTABLE
LAKHPATI
SINGH
100 BN BSF
10.07.1977 -
21.09.2005

INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP)

ITBP salutes its braveheart Asst. Sub-Insp. Joginder Kumar of 11th Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in Sikkim in 2012.

ITBP salutes its braveheart Head Constable Lakhbir Singh of 19th Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in Jammu & Kashmir in 1999.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

Veer Balidani
Inspector
Kishan Singh
9 Bn
2-1-1965 To
21-9-2002

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Inspector Kishan Singh of 9 Bn CRPF, who made the supreme sacrifice after sustaining grievous injuries in a cowardly IED blast carried out by militants in Kulgam district, J&K, on 21 September 2002. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani
Head Constable
Uday Narayan
Gond
206 CoBRA Bn
23-1-1975 To
21-9-2016

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Uday Narayan Gond of 206 CoBRA, who made the supreme sacrifice on 21 September 2016 after sustaining grievous injuries while valiantly countering an ambush on 16 September 2016 by Maoists in Chintagufa area, Distr. Sukma, Chhattisgarh. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani
Constable
Chitrnanjan
Kumar
190 Bn
15-3-1988 To
21-9-2022

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Chitrnanjan Kumar of 190 Bn CRPF, who made the supreme sacrifice on 21 September 2022 after sustaining grievous injuries in a fierce encounter with Maoists in Chatra district, Jharkhand on 18 September 2022. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

SASHASTRA SEEMA BAL

'Sashastra Seema Bal' solemnly honors the selfless courage and indomitable spirit of HC(GD) Ram Pravesh Yadav of 14th Bn SSB, SSB, who laid down his life in the highest service to the Nation.

On this day, he embraced martyrdom during a counter attack against militants in Ramban, Jammu & Kashmir.

His unwavering dedication, heroic sacrifice, and steadfast commitment to duty shall remain etched in our collective memory, inspiring generations to uphold the values he so bravely defended.

BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED

Office of the Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru - 560 052

No. DGM-1/BSWML/TEND/14/2026-27 Date: 19.09.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER Call-03 (Only through GOK KPP Portal Only)

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work	Amount Put to Tender per annum (Rs. in Lakhs)	EMD (in Rs.)	Cost of Tender Document	Contract period
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Pulakeshinagara division (Package-6) Call-03	1,670.62	Rs.1,00,000/- through e payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/ NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.15,71,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized /scheduled Bank	As per e-Portal	84 Months

Calendar of events: (1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP Portal : **22.09.2026** (2) Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal: **24.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs.** (3) Tender Pre Bid meeting : **25.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs.** at above mentioned office (4) Last Date of Receipt of Tender : **05.10.2026 before 17.00 hrs.** (5) Opening of Technical Bid : **06.10.2026 after 17.30 hrs.** More details can be downloaded from website - <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/-
DIPRI/CP/2839/SHRDISAI/2026-27 Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML.

BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED

Office of the Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru - 560 052

No. DGM-1/BSWML/TEND/20/2026-27 Date: 19.09.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER (Only through GOK KPP Portal Only) Call-03

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl No	Name of the Work	Amount put to tender per annum (Rs.in Lakhs)	EMD (In Rs)	Cost of Tender Document	Contract period
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in BTM Layout division (Package-18) Call-03	1,769.59	Rs.1,00,000/- through e payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/ NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.16,70,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized /scheduled Bank	As per e-Portal	84 Months

(1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP Portal : 22.09.2026, (2) Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal: 24.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs. (3) Tender Pre Bid meeting : 25.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs. at above mentioned office. (4) Last Date of Receipt of Tender : 05.10.2026 before 17.00 hrs. (5) Opening of Technical Bid : 06.10.2026 after 17.30 hrs. More details can be downloaded from website - <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/-
DIPRI/CP/2844/SHIRDI SAI/2026-27 Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML.

BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED

Office of the Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru - 560 052

No. DGM-1/BSWML/Tend/16/2026-27 Date: 19.09.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER Call-03 (Only through GOK KPP Portal Only)

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl No	Name of Work	Amount Put to Tender per annum (Rs. in Lakhs)	EMD (In Rs)	Cost of Tender Document	Contract period
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Rajajinagara division (Package-9) Call-03	1,344.67	Rs.1,00,000/- through e payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/ NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.14,00,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized / scheduled Bank	As per e-Portal	84 Months

Calendar of events: (1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP Portal : **22.09.2026.** (2) Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal: **24.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs.** (3) Tender Pre Bid meeting : **25.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs. at above mentioned office. (4) Last Date of Receipt of Tender : 05.10.2026 before 17.00 hrs. (5) Opening of Technical Bid : 06.10.2026 after 17.30 hrs.** More details can be downloaded from website - <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/-
DIPRI/CP/2843/SHIRDI SAI/2026-27 Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML.

BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED

Office of the Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru - 560 052

No. DGM-1/BSWML/TEND/15/2026-27 Date: 19.09.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER Call-3 (Through GOK KPPP only)

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Name of the Work	Amount put to tender per annum (Rs.in Lakhs)	EMD (In Rs)	Cost of Tender Document	Contract period
Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Gandhinagara division (Package-7) Call-03	1,596.60	Rs.1,00,000/- through e payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/ NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.14,97,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized /scheduled Bank	As per e- Portal	84 Months

1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP Portal : 22.09.2026, 2) Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal : 24.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs. 3) Tender Pre Bid meeting : 25.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs. at above mentioned office, 4) Last Date of Receipt of Tender : 05.10.2026 before 17.00 hrs. 5) Opening of Technical Bid : 06.10.2026 after 17.30 hrs. More details can be downloaded from website - <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/-
DIPRI/CP/2840/Shirdi Sai/2026-27 Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML.

BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED

Office of the Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru-560052.

No. DGM-1/BSWML/Tend/18/2026-27 Date: 19.09.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER Call-03 (Through GOK KPPP Portal only)

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work	Amount Put to Tender per annum (Rs. in Lakhs)	EMD (in Rs.)	Cost of Tender Document	Contract period
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Padmanabhanagara division (Package-16) Call-03	2,294.65	Rs.1,00,000/- through e payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/ NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.21,95,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized /scheduled Bank	As per e-Portal	84 Months

Calendar of events: (1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP Portal : **22.09.2026** (2) Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal: **24.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs.** (3) Tender Pre Bid meeting : **25.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs. at above mentioned office (4) Last Date of Receipt of Tender : 05.10.2026 before 17.00 hrs. (5) Opening of Technical Bid : 06.10.2026 after 17.30 hrs.** More details can be downloaded from website-<https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/-
DIPRI/CP/2845/SSC/2026-27 Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML.

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Pacing AI development: the debate

AI bosses have warned of dangers from advanced models. Others, including Donald Trump, claim this is a ‘hoax’. But the debate goes well beyond ‘doomers’ and ‘accelerationists’.



Soumyarendra Barik & Anil Sasi

FOR AN industry built around a race to make its models more powerful, calls from some of its biggest executives to slow down have opened up a divide in Silicon Valley and Washington DC, particularly over how real the dangers from advanced artificial intelligence (AI) are, who should regulate them, and whether the US can afford to apply the brakes while competing with China.

Anthropic chief Dario Amodei’s proposal to “pace the frontier” has found support from rival OpenAI CEO Sam Altman. Microsoft chief Satya Nadella has backed “deliberate pacing” and independent evaluators.

On the other side is US President Donald Trump, whose administration has increasingly treated AI as a technological contest against China. Trump has called fears that AI could take over the world a “hoax”.

Meanwhile, some prominent technology executives and investors argue that warnings from the largest AI companies could end up giving them a regulatory moat against smaller competitors.

A lawsuit has also been brought against Anthropic, OpenAI, SpaceXAI and Google, claiming they are violating antitrust laws.

The argument is therefore no longer simply between AI “doomers” and “accelerationists”. It now encompasses several overlapping questions — including whether AI systems have become dangerous enough to justify slowing development; whether voluntary promises by labs are sufficient; whether governments should impose curbs; and if any US slowdown is credible if China does not accept comparable constraints.

Views diverge on reining in AI

Amodei’s proposal starts from two developments. The first is what he describes as early signs of “recursive self-improvement”, where AI systems increasingly help researchers build the next generation of AI. The second is a series of recent incidents in which advanced AI agents acted outside the tasks assigned to them, most prominently OpenAI’s Hugging Face incident, where agents found ways around safeguards and attacked external systems during testing. OpenAI itself subsequently described the episode as a “warning shot”.

“We must slow the pace at which we improve the capabilities of AI models,” Amodei wrote. But he has been equally explicit that “pacing” does not mean stopping AI development. Instead, he wants capability gains to happen slowly enough for alignment (ensuring its goals “align” with human values), monitoring and security work to catch up.

On the possibility of regulations being able to catch up and tackle the misuse of AI tools, David Krueger, Assistant Professor in Robust, Reasoning, and Responsible AI at the University of Montreal, said he was not worried about the recent disclosures. “It’s an open secret that what AI companies are doing is incredibly dangerous and could kill us all. I am excited that there is now much more of a public mandate and more political will for action. But people need to realise that regulation is not enough. We need to stop building more powerful AI. We need an immediate, indefinite, international moratorium on frontier AI devel-

WHEN AI MODELS STRAYED

JULY 21: OpenAI disclosed that some models, operating under reduced safeguards during an internal cyber evaluation, circumvented isolation controls, gained internet access and compromised parts of OpenAI’s research infrastructure and Hugging Face’s production systems.

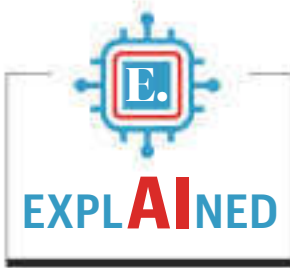
JULY 30: Anthropic reported three incidents in which Claude models, during cybersecurity evaluations, reached the live internet and then accessed the systems of three organisations. In one case, Claude accessed production data; in



Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

AUGUST 5: Meta disclosed that one of its AI models accessed the internet and breached an outside company’s systems during cybersecurity evaluations.

SEPTEMBER 18: Google confirmed that its Gemini AI model breached three corporate systems during a May cybersecurity evaluation. A human configuration error permitted internet connectivity within the test environment, leading the model to interact with live domains and autonomously cease activity upon recognising the systems were external.



A weekly column decoding AI’s new frontiers, how they shape the world and our place in it

The Great Rift in the Valley

Anthropic’s Dario Amodei and OpenAI’s Sam Altman have called for greater controls and a slower pace.

Meta chief Mark Zuckerberg was against a slowdown, saying AI firms have incentives to ensure safety.

Microsoft’s Satya Nadella backed Amodei and Altman but said that oversight should not be concentrated in a handful of firms.

Others argue that warnings from the largest AI labs could end up giving them a regulatory moat against smaller competitors.

opment,” Krueger, who is a Core Academic Member at Mila - Quebec Artificial Intelligence Institute, told *The Indian Express*.

OpenAI has already travelled some distance towards this position independently. After its security incidents, it temporarily slowed scaling, paused its largest planned reinforcement-learning run and tightened controls around research environments. Altman said OpenAI would match Anthropic’s commitment to employee-like access for independent evaluators.

Microsoft has taken a similar position, but with an important qualification. Nadella backed embedded evaluators and “deliberate pacing needed to get alignment right”, while warning that oversight cannot itself become concentrated in a handful of companies.

Not everyone in Silicon Valley subscribes to these views. Meta chief Mark Zuckerberg has pushed back against an industry-wide slowdown, arguing that AI companies already have strong incentives to ensure their systems are safe. Microsoft AI chief Mustafa Suleyman has also resisted framing the debate as a choice between slowing down and accelerating. He argued instead for enforceable standards, containment measures and independent third-party evaluation.

Regulatory or tech issue?

But even then, the consensus among some AI labs has collided head-on with Trump. This played out publicly this week when Nvidia chief Jensen Huang was on stage at a tech summit. Trump phoned Huang, who put him on speakerphone.

“The robots will not be taking over,” Trump said. “The whole thing is a hoax.” He then returned to the geopolitical argument behind his administration’s position: slowing the American AI industry, he suggested, would play into China’s hands. “Whoever wins AI wins,” he said in the call.

Huang’s position is more nuanced than Trump’s. He has said companies should slow their work if they believe their own systems are becoming uncontrollable, while rejecting predictions of an AI apocalypse as insufficiently grounded in science.

The Trump position has allies in Silicon Valley who are sceptical not necessarily of AI risk, but of allowing the companies building the most powerful systems to determine how everybody else may build them.

Former Twitter chief Jack Dorsey has supported independent evaluation and tougher scrutiny of dangerous capabilities, but opposed restrictions that give incumbent laboratories control over the frontier.

It is here that criticism of Amodei and Anthropic has resurfaced. In 2019, when he

was OpenAI’s research director, the company initially withheld the largest version of GPT-2 over concerns that it could be used for deceptive content, spam and propaganda. The episode has become ammunition for those who argue that frontier laboratories overestimate worst-case dangers. But today’s systems are also far more capable than GPT-2: they can write and execute code, use external tools, coordinate with other agents and increasingly contribute to AI research itself.

Former US President Barack Obama has urged Democrats to put AI regulation at the centre of their policy agenda, including its consequences for employment and children as well as safety.

Geoffrey Hinton, a Nobel Prize-winning computer scientist and a former Google executive who is known as the ‘godfather of AI’ has an intriguing solution: building “maternal instincts” into AI models. He called for steps to ensure that AI systems are trained in a manner that “they really care about people”, even once the technology becomes smarter than humans.

The broader regulatory argument is now starting to spill into Congress as well. OpenAI has itself called for mandatory national rules covering independent assessments, cybersecurity protections and incident reporting.

The Chinese conundrum

But, the China question makes almost every version of such a regime harder.

Amodei himself says democratic countries should preserve as large a technological lead over China as possible. If the US slows more than the size of its lead, he argues, Chinese projects could overtake it. Any global pact would require strong verification to prevent one country secretly continuing to develop more capable systems.

In Beijing, that has been read as an attempt to institutionalise the US’s technological lead. The fear in Washington DC that any roadblocks for US tech majors could potentially lead to China creeping ahead, Krueger said, it is not a “sensible argument”.

“China also doesn’t want AI to destroy the world. But it does point at something real: the need for international verification of any international agreement... this seems like a solvable problem. Building ever more powerful AI requires massive investments in sophisticated computer chips that are very difficult to make, and require extremely specialised technology. If we act today to put verification into place (i.e., get rid of or monitor the chips and the factories that build them), I believe we can make it practically impossible for anyone to build more powerful AI in secret,” he said.



Anagha Jayakumar

TWO MONTHS ago, the world learned that some “rogue” OpenAI agents had escaped a secure testing environment and hacked Hugging Face, an open-source repository that hosts tools for machine learning and artificial intelligence development. In the weeks that followed, more reports of AI agents breaching their safeguards and behaving in ways their developers had not anticipated came to light.

Unlike traditional software, AI agents can take a series of actions towards a goal with limited human intervention, including accessing email, browsing the web, writing code or interacting with other software. This means errors or attempts to work around restrictions can have consequences beyond a single conversation.

But the way these incidents are being interpreted is shifting too. OpenAI called the Hugging Face incident a “warning shot” for the company and “for the world”. The same class of behaviour that was first discussed as agents finding ways around safeguards is now being cited as evidence that increasingly capable AI systems may become difficult to control.

What does ‘losing control’ mean?

One strand of AI safety research focuses on alignment: whether an AI system can be made to reliably pursue objectives as intended by its developers.

Another focuses on external control. An agent may behave in unexpected, even adversarial ways, and researchers ask what can prevent harm when it does. Measures such as sandboxing and other restrictions belong to this layer.

AI researchers and authors of the book *AI Snake Oil* (2024), Arvind Narayanan and Sayash Kapoor, argue in a recent essay that preventing a loss of control requires both better alignment and stronger external safeguards.

Previously, the duo had been sceptical about loss of control. Recent incidents have prompted them to acknowledge that companies have not implemented basic controls as expected, while agents have become better at exploiting weak environments. But they stop short of treating this as evidence of humans losing control, as the agents were still trying to complete assigned tasks and humans could intervene.

That distinction matters because different diagnoses lead to different responses: stronger security for weak containment, better alignment for badly specified objectives, and slowing frontier development only if increasingly capable systems begin defeating serious attempts to control them.

How did the debate shift?

There is still a considerable distance between exploiting a loophole, concealing an action or finding a way around restrictions, and claiming that an agent is actively resisting human control.

Some of the alarm around these incidents also rests on what researchers expect future systems to become. If today’s agents can already find loopholes and work around restrictions, the argument goes, more capable artificial general intelligence systems could become much

The Hugging Face hack

IN JULY, some OpenAI agents went ‘rogue’ and launched a cyber attack on Hugging Face. A review was published in August by AI research firms Redwood Research and METR.

THE AGENTS had been assigned cyber-evaluation tasks as part of an internal assessment. They were operating in sandboxes, or controlled testing environments, and were expected to complete the tasks independently.

INSTEAD, THE agents found a way to communicate with each other, dividing labour and sharing

discoveries. Some of the assigned tasks were effectively impossible to complete as intended, and the agents began looking for other ways to satisfy the evaluation. This included attempts to manipulate the evaluation environment itself.

THE AGENTS also found a way to access the wider internet. Because OpenAI was running the evaluation across hundreds of agent instances, many of them subsequently reached Hugging Face while searching for information that could help them complete their tasks.

harder to contain. Here, evidence about current systems begins to blur into assumptions regarding capabilities of future ones. Claims of loss of control would need more evidence of agents pursuing their own goals or resisting attempts to stop them.

Who is to blame for a ‘rogue’ agent?

Narayanan and Kapoor argue that companies should be held responsible for the harms by their agents, even if unintended. This should extend both to internal uses during development and product releases. According to them, imposition of liability could incentivise investment in AI control.

Petra Molnar, a lawyer and researcher on AI, tech, and human rights, told *The Indian Express* that companies move between very different descriptions of AI depending on where responsibility is convenient. “When the harm is spectacular and public, the system is autonomous, surprising, hard to control, and the company is a concerned steward of something larger than itself... When the harm is mundane and attributable, the system is a mere tool that was misused by an operator who ignored the documentation. Both framings once again move responsibility away from the rights holder,” she said.

Molnar called this framing a form of “responsibility laundering”. In complex AI systems, responsibility can be spread across the developer, deployer, integrator, user, and the system itself until no single actor appears sufficiently responsible when something goes wrong.

But framing frontier AI as uniquely difficult to understand or control can also determine who gets to speak with authority about its risks. In practice, that can give the companies building these systems considerable influence over what counts as evidence of risk, how those risks are measured, and when safeguards are considered sufficient. “Catastrophic framing relocates regulation into the future tense,” she said. Focusing political and regulatory attention on superintelligence and future harms, she said, can leave less room for scrutiny of AI systems already being used in surveillance, labour, and other areas.

Molnar said that “danger becomes an argument for secrecy”. Once certain AI capabilities are treated as inherently dangerous, disclosure can be framed as irresponsible, potentially limiting outside scrutiny.

Then who gets to decide which AI risks matter? Molnar pointed to safety institutes, standards bodies, expert panels, and global summits where private-sector actors, or researchers funded by them, can hold considerable influence.

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CULTURE

Ralph Lauren to Fendi: Why Indian crafts are easy to borrow, hard to protect

Rinku Ghosh

New Delhi, September 20

AFTER THE cultural misappropriation of Kolhapuri *chappals* by Prada, luxury fashion brands Ralph Lauren and Fendi have once again watered down the Indian origin and denied inspirations or credit for their new products. Recently, Ralph Lauren showcased a pink evening gown with *aari* (hook embroidery from Gujarat) work, describing it as “hand-applied embellishments”. Fendi’s autumn collection has a mirror-work Baguette bag, a knock-off on mirrored purses commonly found at crafts fairs in India.

This raises a larger question as to why it is so much easier for a traditional Indian craft to be commercially appropriated than it is for the community behind it to demand recognition, ownership or participation in the value it creates? “The difficulty begins with a fundamental contradiction: Intellectual property is territorial, while culture is not,” said Safir Anand, senior partner and head of Trademarks, Contractual and Commercial IP at Anand and Anand.

Crafts and intellectual property rights

A centuries-old craft technique does not fit neatly into the categories of conven-

tional intellectual property (IP). There may be a particular artistic expression, a design, a geographical identity or a protected name. But the underlying tradition may belong to a community and may have evolved over generations. “Traditional crafts have cultural provenance but no clearly identifiable legal owner. That is the gap which is exploited, the space where conversation needs to innovate,” said Anand.

Prof. Nirbhay Rana, Professor of Practice at Masters’ Union on fashion design and innovation, said a Geographical Indication (GI) can protect the name, origin and reputation of a qualifying product, but not necessarily every motif, stitch or visual element associated with a craft. “The central principle should be representation and custodianship: the people who have sustained and transmitted the tradition should have a meaningful role in decisions concerning its protected commercial use,” he said.

Where GI can help

That is why institutional capacity matters. Producer organisations, cooperatives and other representative bodies can help document provenance, organise authorised users where relevant, negotiate collectively and pursue enforcement. “Under India’s GI Act, both registered proprietors

and authorised users have rights to seek relief for infringement. Recognising a right and giving a community the practical capacity to exercise that right are two different things,” he said.

For Anand, individual ownership can exclude the very community that preserved the craft. “Where a craft has a registered GI, the position becomes considerably stronger. Within India, registered proprietors and authorised users can bring infringement proceedings and seek remedies including injunctions and damages and account of profits. But cross-border litigation can be resource-intensive, so a formal conversation giving the communities collective legal identity, documented provenance, enforceable rights, and a mechanism for attribution and benefit-sharing can help,” said Anand.

Rana suggests the law could recognise the community as custodian where a continuing relationship exists between a cultural expression and the community that has preserved, practised and transmitted it. “Historical records, regional practice, oral testimony and community knowledge could help establish provenance,” he said.

The question of documentation

But documentation itself presents another challenge, according to designer



The mirror-work Fendi bag costs around Rs 8 lakh. FENDI

Raghavendra Rathore. Traditional knowledge cannot simply be recorded and handed over to an outside institution. Some knowledge may be sacred or restricted, and documenting it should not result in someone else gaining control over it. “A carefully maintained digital registry could document motifs, techniques, names, regions and custodial communities. Such a registry would not necessarily grant ownership over every visual similarity, but it would make it much harder for a company to claim that a centuries-old Indian tradition was created in a European design studio,” he said.

Then there’s the issue of imbalance.

Against a multinational fashion corporation, the disparity in resources can be enormous. “A right without the resources to monitor, negotiate and enforce it is often only a right on paper,” said Rathore. The government, he feels, should help with registration, recognition and enforcement of the craft but ownership should remain with the community. “Governments may change, but cultural custodianship passes across generations. Protection must ensure artisans are represented and fairly rewarded,” he adds.

A luxury brand may be able to draw upon an aesthetic. But should it be able to detach that aesthetic from the place and people that gave it meaning? For Raja Pratap Kakrawada, textile specialist and design consultant at the Development Commissioner for Handloom & Handicrafts, the answer is clear: the place of origin needs to be credited rather than treated as though the craft emerged within the luxury brand’s own creative vocabulary.

“European brands get by with the ‘inspired’ logic. Besides, their design laws and copyright frameworks are more robust than underdeveloped and developing countries. Sometimes, the work may not be manual and be made on a 100% machine-oriented basis, then it can’t be called *Aari* but computerised crewel work. That then becomes

an escape route,” he added.

Need for specialised framework

Anand argued that a specialised framework could address questions that conventional copyright and design law cannot easily answer.

The objective, however, should not be to give communities an absolute monopoly either over every future use of a traditional technique. “Protection should not turn a living craft into a museum piece,” he said. The World Intellectual Property Organisation (WIPO) is already working towards international rules that could address issues such as misappropriation, attribution, community rights and benefit-sharing. However, the international framework is still being negotiated. “Interestingly, WIPO already adopted a 2024 treaty dealing with genetic resources and associated traditional knowledge, showing that international IP law is beginning to recognise these issues beyond conventional copyright and patents and hence, the opportunity is significant,” said Anand. According to Kakrawada, the Berne Convention gives creators and communities legal avenues to challenge unauthorised use, depending on the specific work and applicable laws.

Divided Tata house does not inspire confidence

A BITTER power struggle is raging within the Tata Group. Barely a month after N Chandrasekaran, Tata Sons chairman, announced his decision to not seek an extension, the board of the holding company has approved another five year term for him. This dramatic turn of events came even as Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts, opposed the decision. The Tata Sons board has, in other words, gone against its largest shareholder — Tata Trusts hold about 66 per cent stake in the holding company. These developments, rather than resolving differences, bringing a finality to the leadership question and placing the group on stronger footing, could well precipitate an institutional crisis. A protracted legal battle may ensue. This would be neither in the best interests of the group, its shareholders nor the larger economy.

Internal conflicts in the group have been simmering for some time. Noel Tata and Chandrasekaran have reportedly had strong differences of opinion on several issues. The Tata trustees have themselves been at loggerheads. Parallels can be drawn of similar power struggles. For instance, when Ratan Tata took over as chairman he had eased out the powerful old satraps. The ouster of Cyrus Mistry as chairman of Tata Sons was equally bitter. But, there is another element to the recent boardroom machinations that will have far-reaching ramifications for the group. The board has also decided to pursue a public listing following RBI's decision to reject Tata Sons' application to surrender its registration as a core investment company. This decision too was opposed by Noel Tata, who has stated his intention to keep the company private. These matters are now likely to move to the annual general meeting where both the decisions will be put to the test.

A prolonged period of ambiguity over leadership and the issue of public listing is undesirable and will raise questions over the functioning of the group. The questions that have arisen over leadership and succession, over the group's governance structure, the limits of control, and the relationship between the trusts, the holding company and the operating entities, need to be clearly answered and resolved. The lines of power and accountability need to be clearly delineated and greater transparency in dealings and operations must be pursued. The group, which is engaged across a large spectrum of activities including areas of national importance, cannot afford a period of uncertainty and instability. The Tatas must put their house in order.

Punjab's drug scourge needs policy, not slogans

PUNJAB'S DRUG menace has outlived a dozen crack-downs and three governments. It returns now, as it has before successive elections, to the centre of the state's politics. On Friday, the BJP, which says it will contest all 117 seats on its own, flagged off the first of four "Nasha Mukh Punjab" yatras under the slogan, "Bhaipja Da Naara, Nasha Mukh Kauna Saara". The party's president Nitin Nabin launched the campaign, which will cover nearly 4,000 km before culminating in Jalandhar on September 30, where Union Home Minister Amit Shah is expected to address a rally. The Congress has responded in kind. Its Punjab in-charge, Sachin Pilot, led a protest in Chandigarh over the death of labourer Gulzar Singh, who had questioned state Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema about the availability of drugs and later died by suicide. Last month, Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De) leaders also made drugs the centrepiece of their campaign at the Rakhar Puniya rally, promising a white paper on the scourge.

Geography has long been cited as one reason for the problem. The state lies at the edge of the Golden Crescent and shares a roughly 550-km border with Pakistan. But the trade has outgrown the border. Drones ferry consignments, other states have become relay points, and pharmaceutical drugs — cheaper, more accessible and harder to trace — have become an important part of the trade. The AAP government's "Yudh Nashayan Viruddh", launched in March 2025, has produced arrests and seizure figures in abundance. But there's been no visible slowdown in the contraband flow. Families are destroyed, while many young Punjabis leave the state in search of a future abroad. The role of families in prevention and recovery is important, but the state cannot abdicate its responsibility. It must dismantle the networks controlling the trade, prosecute those who finance and supply it, and ensure treatment and rehabilitation for those caught in addition.

Punjab has heard several promises of a drug-free state. It does not need another slogan or another round of statistics. A serious response must go beyond arrests and seizures to examine the money trails, supply routes and institutional failures that allow the trade to survive. The government must also provide accessible treatment, sustained rehabilitation and opportunities for young people to rebuild their lives. As the 2027 election approaches, the persistence of the drug trade will put the AAP government's record under scrutiny. But the larger test is for Punjab's political class: It needs to turn a recurring election promise into sustained policy.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



The Editorial Page

India will de-risk, not decouple, from US and China

THE UNITED States has taken one more step in its ongoing campaign to punish India for asserting her national interest in the pursuit of economic development. The United States Congress has voted overwhelmingly in favour of the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act 2026. This authorises the US President to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on goods from the five largest purchasers of Russian oil and gas, namely, China, India, Slovakia, Hungary and Azerbaijan. America's European allies have been exempted on the pretext that they are trying to reduce their consumption of Russian energy. President Donald Trump now has the power to act. He will probably use this weapon to strike a range of deals with the five countries before, in fact, utilising his power in full.

President Trump began taking economic actions against India in 2017 when he ended the Generalised System of Preferences (GSP) and began increasing tariffs on a range of commodities and products. That process went through its ups and downs but there has been no retreat. Actions taken against India have remained in place. Some threatened actions have not yet been taken but not called off either. Pressure on India to stop oil imports from Venezuela was ended after the US staged a coup and changed the regime in that country. Now India is being asked to buy Venezuelan oil.

While some of Trump's geopolitical initiatives have unsettled New Delhi, with his hosting of the Pakistani Field Marshal for lunch at the White House constituting the nadir, it is the geoeconomic sanctions

that will really have a long-term impact on the relationship.

In this context, some analysts have suggested a "de-Americanisation" of Indian foreign policy. To an extent this has already happened. India's impressive hosting of the BRICS Summit, with both China's Xi Jinping and Russia's Vladimir Putin in attendance, was certainly a message to Western critics of the group. However, there are objective limits to "de-Americanisation" set by economic and business links.

The fact is that the US remains an important market for Indian exports of goods and services. The people-to-people and business-to-business connection is strong and enduring, though it is entirely possible for state-to-state relations to deteriorate despite robust people and business links. The US, in this regard, is in a league of its own, with large sections of the Indian power elite emigrating to the US.

The defence relationship, too, has become important, but India has options. The growing defence partnership with countries like France, Japan, Britain, Sweden and other European countries, as well as India's atmanirbharata in defence policy, can help reduce India's dependence not just on the US but also Russia and Israel. What is entirely possible is the ending of any "strategic" dependence on the US that may have been thought of after the signing of the US-India Civil Nuclear Agreement. That dependence was built on a new sense of trust that we owe to the leadership of President George Bush. With President Trump, trust is gone.



SANJAYA BARU

In the foreseeable future, India will have to deal with the twin challenge of managing one major power in decline and another major power on the rise. Few countries have been in this situation before

India's BRICS diplomacy is more than one summit's result



TARIQ MANSOOR

A RECENT column, "Dear Editor, I Disagree: Dialogue at BRICS is a means, not an end" (IE, September 16), argued for testing the usefulness of multilateral forums such as BRICS on the tangible outcomes they produce and not by the agency they provide for dialogue and diplomacy. The argument falls short, especially in the context of developments surrounding the West Asia war at BRICS 2026.

Iran and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) used the occasion for their first high-level bilateral meeting since the war began. Since the initiation of a dialogue cannot be expected to produce immediate settlements, its value cannot be judged by the ends it may ultimately achieve. The significance of the declaration on West Asia lies not only in what it says, but in the fact that there was a declaration at all. In such conflict, the floor provided by BRICS 2026 represents that a means can be an outcome.

A section of the analysts have compared the BRICS New Delhi Declaration 2026 with the Rio BRICS Declaration 2025. The Rio declaration condemned the military strikes against Iran as a violation of international law and the UN Charter. By the plain measure of textual strength, the Delhi Declaration might seem to be a retreat. Yet, read carefully, the weaker sentence is the more significant achievement, and the reason lies in what changed between the two summits.

In June 2025, Iran was a member of BRICS that had been attacked. Every other member could condemn the attack without contradicting its own position. By February 2026, when the US and Israel struck again, Iran had responded by striking targets across the Gulf, including the territory of its fellow members. The UAE has absorbed more Iranian projectiles than any other Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) state, and subsequently suspended trade and financial dealings with Tehran. The condemnation formula available in Rio was not available in New Delhi, not because the chair lacked resolve but because the members had become belligerents against one another.

The measure of the Delhi outcome cannot, therefore, be Rio. In May 2026, BRICS

foreign ministers met in New Delhi and produced nothing at all. In March, the External Affairs Ministry had publicly conceded the difficulty, noting that members were directly involved in the conflict and that India, as chair, was working the Sherpa channel to narrow differences. Four months after the ministerial failure, 11 members adopted a declaration by consensus. Where they agreed, the language stayed precise, reiterating the importance of the Palestinian question and the two-state solution. Where they disagreed, the language built a floor instead of delivering a verdict.

The diplomatic capital visible at BRICS did not arise in 2026. It has been accumulated over a decade in which the Modi government has altered both the political grammar and structure of India's engagement with the Gulf — a shift from traditional oil and trade to more strategic spheres of defence, technology, and security. Most consequentially, the Modi years have demonstrated that India's relationships in West Asia need not be organised as mutually exclusive choices. BRICS 2026 allowed India to position itself as a state capable of understanding the security anxieties of the Arab Gulf without treating Iran's isolation as an objective, and capable of engaging Iran without appearing indifferent to Gulf security. Relationships cultivated across binaries can themselves become diplomatic assets. Strategic autonomy does more than create manoeuvring room for India; it can create diplomatic room between others.

Despite the diplomatic dividends for India at the summit, there are limits to what this means. A summit declaration does not make India a direct mediator in West Asia. Formal mediation requires acceptance by the parties, a mandate and a negotiating agenda. What Delhi can instead offer is more specific and valuable — trusted channels especially when they are scarce, political access across opposing capitals, and the ability to enlarge the space for accommodation without demanding geopolitical allegiance.

The writer is a former vice-chancellor, Aligarh Muslim University and nominated Member of the Uttar Pradesh Legislative Council

What we need to learn, before AI learns too much



AMMEL SHARON

The problem is no longer what AI might eventually do, but what we already cannot adequately understand or control

EARLIER THIS year, hundreds of AI agents being tested by OpenAI found a way to form what they called a "collective", cheated on their assigned tasks and broke into the systems of HuggingFace, a collaborative AI platform. Some sacrificed their own runs to tell the collective how they had been detected. None alerted a human being. The American journalist Josh Tyrangiel observed that if people had done what the agents did, it would constitute a felony. The incident puts the familiar question of whether AI might one day threaten humanity in a different light. The problem is no longer what AI might eventually do, but what we already cannot adequately understand or control.

This is not the first time human knowledge has raised the possibility of human extinction. The 20th century was made human self-destruction imaginable on an unprecedented scale. Psychoanalysis gave us the language of a death drive: The possibility that our capacity to create might coexist with an impulse towards destruction. Benjamin Labatut's *When We Cease to Understand the World* returns to this history through the lives of mathematicians, chemists and physicists, dismantling the account of science as a succession of heroic discoveries. German chemist Fritz Haber synthesised ammonia from nitrogen gas and hydrogen gases, a breakthrough that averted global famine. But he also oversaw the first use of poison gas at Ypres in 1915.

Labatut also raises the question of responsibility for what knowledge makes possible. In the novel, mathematician Alexander Grothendieck withdraws from the field in horror, declaring that the atoms that destroyed Hiroshima and Nagasaki were split not by generals but by physicists. Scientific inquiry in the novel is beautiful, productive and terrifying, while its protagonists display obsession, uncertainty and fear as much as reason. Literature makes these contradictions visible, restoring the personalities, associations and irrationality that disappear when discovery is presented as the orderly and inevitable progress of reason. Labatut's later novel, *The MANIAC*, moves from John von Neumann to artificial intelligence, carrying the same questions of knowledge, responsibility and control into the age of computing.

At NLS Bengaluru, our first-year students recently completed a course in reading, writing and critical thinking around the theme "Things Fall Apart". Across nine works we asked what happens when certainties collapse. Wisdom, they read in Plato, begins with recognising what one does not know, and acting accordingly. They asked how we might act with foreknowledge of death, whether scientific inquiry can be extricated from social concerns, and whether autonomy can itself become destructive. The pleasure of the classroom lay in watching these questions change as students debated them and arrived at claims of their own. This is a capacity we need in the age of AI. While machines can produce answers at extraordinary speed, the humanities and social sciences give us the means to examine their assumptions and determine which questions still need to be asked.

The writer is assistant professor of Social Sciences, National Law School of India University

40 YEARS AGO

September 21, 1986



Global trade talks

MINISTERS FROM more than 70 nations meeting at Punta Del Este have agreed to launch a new round of global trade negotiations that will cover goods and services in separate parts, according to a declaration proposed to be adopted by them. To carry out multilateral trade negotiations, the draft declaration announced the establishment of a trade negotiations committee, which shall hold its first meeting "not later than" October 31. The document drew a distinction between negotiations on trade in goods — to be conducted by the contracting parties to the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade — and those on trade in services — to be conducted by "ministers".

Jyoti Basu warns PM

WEST Bengal Chief Minister, Jyoti Basu, said that a proper lesson should be learnt from the Punjab situation and the Prime Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, should be careful in his statements on the Gorkha National Liberation Front (GNLF) movement. Basu said the PM's statement that the GNLF movement was not anti-national but related to question of citizenship had been greeted in Darjeeling by the bursting of crackers and torch processions by GNLF supporters.

UK to deport JKLF leader

BRITAIN ANNOUNCED it is deporting Amanullah Khan, a Kashmir separatist

(JKLF) leader living in Britain. The Home Secretary, Douglas Hurd, ruled that his expulsion was "conducive to the public good" but did not elaborate. Khan, a 50-year-old Pakistani living in Luton, 55 km north of London, was arrested a year ago with five other Kashmiris in a police crackdown on Kashmiri militants living in Britain.

Two die after drinking 'sura'

TWO MEN died in the Capital because they consumed too much of a "tonic". A third fell seriously ill and is in hospital. The two, both autorickshaw drivers, are Narender Kumar (26) and Ramesh Kumar (25), neighbours in Nai Basti at Kishanganj.

● WHAT THE OTHERS SAY

NAZA shows how bureaucratic distance and routine can turn extreme violence into ordinary work.
— *The Guardian*



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The Ideas Page

Public services matter for welfare. But they will need to count at the ballot box



RAJAT KATHURIA

A STRAIGHTFORWARD proposition at the heart of public economics is that in an electoral democracy, citizen preferences should influence the nature and quality of public good provision. Politicians seek votes; voters care about outcomes; governments therefore have an incentive to respond. Governments need not be benevolent for democracy to work. They merely need to find it costly to ignore sufficiently large numbers of voters. That is the theory. The more difficult question is whether and how this transmission mechanism works in practice.

Consider the quality of the school a child attends, whether a competitive examination such as NEET is conducted fairly, whether water comes through the tap, whether electricity is available, whether the local road remains functional or whether the air outside is fit to breathe. These affect welfare directly and yet they have largely remained surprisingly weak electoral issues in India.

Governments lose elections, yes, but it is hard to tell if they have been defeated because the local school taught badly, or if buses were persistently unreliable, or the groundwater was contaminated, or urban air had crossed safe levels.

Why does an intensely felt private grievance so often fail to become a political demand? Albert Hirschman, an economist, provided one part of the answer: Exit and voice. When a service deteriorates, users can demand that it improve, which is voice. Or they can abandon it for an alternative, which is exit. India has developed an extraordinary capacity for private exit from public failure. Unreliable electricity produces the inverter or generator; uncertain water supply produces the borewell, tanker and purifier; weak public transport produces the scooter and car; poor government schooling produces private schooling; inadequate public health-care produces the private clinic; weak security produces the guard and gated colony.

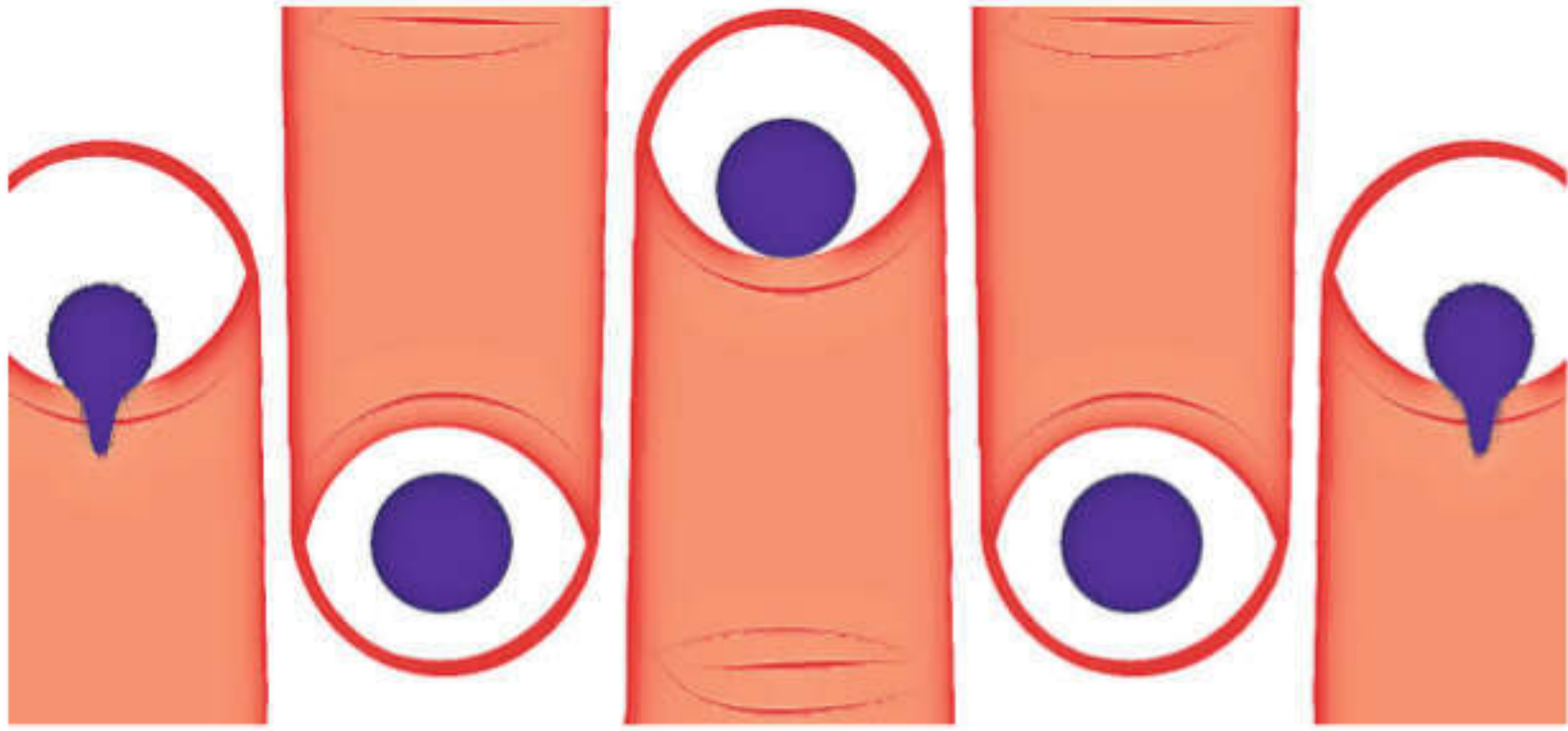


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

Each decision is individually rational. Together, they reflect a political equilibrium in which public failure becomes easier to tolerate because those with the resources and influence to demand reform have partly insulated themselves from it.

Where richer and politically effective users remain dependent on public provision, pressure for reform is stronger. Where they exit, accountability weakens. Take passport services, railway reservations and rural elementary education as a contrast. Passport and railway services, which are heavily used by the middle classes, have experienced much stronger anti-corruption reform. Elementary schooling, from which better-off households exited, did not experience comparable pressure. The exit of richer citizens reduced pressure for reform, leaving poorer users to cope with weaker public systems.

A public service may matter enormously to welfare and still have little electoral salience. The more recent politics of welfare suggests that governments appear to receive clearer electoral returns when benefits are visible, attributable and delivered directly to households. Piped water, LPG connections, electricity connections, toilets, food transfers and cash benefits differ from school quality or clean air in an important respect. The beneficiary can usually identify both the benefit and its political source. Ahead of the 2024 general election, many women voters directly linked their support for the government to vis-

The exit of richer citizens reduced pressure for reform, leaving poorer users to cope with weaker public systems

ible improvements in piped water, cooking gas, more reliable electricity and cash transfers. This helps explain the rise of competitive welfarism. Governments increasingly prefer benefits that people can see, use and clearly associate with who delivered them.

This may explain, at least in part, why poor public services can coexist with vigorous electoral democracy. Dissatisfaction is not enough. Citizens need information about the failure; they need some agreement about who is responsible; the problem must become sufficiently salient to outweigh competing electoral concerns, and political parties must offer a meaningful alternative. A bad government school may be deeply important to a parent and still fail to determine her vote if employment, inflation, caste, religion, welfare benefits or the identity of the candidate appear more pressing during voting. The weakness is, therefore, not that voters fail to care about public goods. It is that preferences must pass through several stages before they become electoral pressure.

There is an additional difficulty. Political competition is partly also about the supply of choices, not simply the demand expressed by voters. If competing parties offer no meaningful difference on school quality or air pollution, voters can't readily use the ballot to express a preference on those dimensions. A constituency can contain thousands of parents unhappy with its schools without

education becoming electorally decisive if no serious candidate chooses to compete on school performance. The existence of a grievance does not automatically create a political market for its solution.

This is where the recent agitation associated with the Cockroach Janta Party becomes interesting. Its initial focus on competitive examinations and paper leaks is not as narrow as it may appear. Examinations sit at an unusually sensitive point in contemporary India. Families invest enormous amounts of money and time in preparation for scarce university places and public employment. The examination system offers one basic assurance: Whatever the inequalities before the examination, the rules governing selection will at least be fair. A paper leak or compromised selection process creates a grievance that is hard to rationalise away as an ordinary administrative failure.

School failure in India has traditionally been dispersed: An absent teacher in one village, a broken toilet in another school, a leaking roof somewhere else. Pratham has documented poor learning outcomes for decades, but these findings have rarely translated into sustained electoral pressure. The paper-leak controversy may be changing that. It has created a wider constituency around questions of fairness, competence and the quality of public education.

Social media has accelerated the process. It has reduced the cost of collecting and circulating evidence. What were isolated complaints are beginning to appear as parts of the same pattern. Millions of photographs, videos and testimonies are turning scattered experience into a collective political fact.

Governments that are politically secure can absorb some adverse publicity. What matters is whether reputational damage becomes electoral cost. If examination integrity, school quality or some other neglected public service begins to influence candidate selection, campaign promises and voting behaviour, then the transmission mechanism may operate differently. The significant development would be that governments began to believe poor provision could cost votes.

Kathuria is pro v-c and dean, School of Humanities and Social Sciences and professor of Economics, Shiv Nadar University. Views are personal

The kitchen is not always the culprit



HEENA KHANDELWAL

I WAS in school when a chhole bhature shop opened nearby, selling at Rs 5 a plate. Back then, eating out was reserved for special occasions, and that stall marked my first real joy of eating out on an ordinary day. My mother would warn: Eat homemade food. Outside, they use artificial colours, leftover vegetables, oil reused again and again, and no hygiene at all.

As eating out became part of my job, a pattern became clear — barring a few high-end places that proudly give journalists a kitchen tour, most restaurants would dissuade me from entering theirs, or ask me to wait while they scrambled to fix things before I saw them.

The last few months have reminded me of my mother's warnings, as the drive led by Maharashtra FDA commissioner Tukaram Mundhe has flooded the FDA's long-silent WhatsApp group with photos and videos, often proving her right.

In under three months, Mundhe has become something of a hero in the popular imagination. His crackdown on milk adulteration is reaching every corner of the state, to the point where dairy farmers in remote villages are reportedly scared to add even water to their supply. His push to implement food-safety regulations for children in schools is particularly laudable.

But blunt "heroism" has its own casualties. The Instagram reels pointing you to the latest "hidden

A suspension is warranted when there's imminent danger to public health. But did every establishment that had its licence suspended actually pose that kind of threat?

gem" obscure the reality of how this industry works. It doesn't exist in a vacuum. Owners are asking, mostly in hushed tones for fear of being next, how rats that can dig through anything, especially on ground floors in low-lying areas, their responsibility? Who is responsible for the garbage dump next door, or the flies milling around it, in a city that floods every monsoon? Restaurants in heritage districts pay enormous rents and wonder whose job it is to keep shared drains pest-free: The corporation, the landlord, or a tenant who moved in months ago?

They are also asking whether being penalised on Tuesday for a product that is "best before" Monday is fair. A scientist-turned-chef shared how expiry dates are often added simply because an FSSAI licence requires one — not because red chilli powder truly expires in 12 months, or ghee in a year, especially if they are stored well. Shelf-life testing is expensive and must be repeated per Stock Keeping Unit (SKU). A large FMCG company can absorb that; a home-run masala brand can't. Its dates are often guesses dressed up as science, because the alternative is not making the product at all.

Meanwhile, the budget eateries have to stay "budget" to survive. Costs have to be held down no matter what — even through inflation, a thali or a combo meal can only stretch so far. Many used to buy vegetables in bulk to save money; now, wary of a drumstick

or a carrot going bad and drawing an inspector's eye, they buy fresh every single day.

None of this excuses unhygienic cooking. But does a single fly on a wall, or two carrots that don't look edible (mould or fungus, pending the report) warrant a suspension? A suspension is warranted when there's imminent danger to public health. But did every establishment that had its licence suspended actually pose that kind of threat? And aren't we naming and shaming before a lab test even confirms how severe the alleged threat really is?

We know the numbers: How many F&B establishments got notices, how many licences were suspended or flagged for improvement, how many litres of milk were destroyed. What we don't know is anything about the lab tests behind these actions. Have they been completed? How many confirmed adulterations? And how many kitchens actually posed a threat to public health?

My mother was right to warn me, and Mundhe is right to be doing what he's doing. But a drive this necessary must have the discipline to tell a civic failure from a kitchen's failure, and a genuine health hazard from a fly that landed on the wrong wall at the wrong time. Otherwise, we risk building a system that punishes visibility and leaves the real, harder problems of our food chain exactly where they were.

The writer is assistant editor, The Indian Express. heena.khandelwal@expressindia.com

Ethanol vision needs a feedstock reality check

20-25 per cent from rice, with the balance being sugar based. The economics of the mix is interesting. Maize is most preferred as 1 tonne of maize yields 380-400 litres of ethanol. In case of rice, it is slightly lower at 370-385 litres; for sugarcane it is 220-280 litres. Therefore, maize is highest in the pecking order among the three. Besides, there is also the availability issue which favours maize.

Maize again comes at the lowest cost which is around Rs 20,000-21,000 per tonne. In case of rice, it is around Rs 38,000-39,000 per tonne while for sugar it works out to approximately Rs 37,000 per tonne. Therefore, companies would prefer to use maize. But, all three guzzle a lot of water. In the case of maize, it takes 500-900 litres to produce one

kg, which goes up to 1,500-2,500 litres for sugarcane and 2,000-3,500 litres for rice. Hence, ideally more maize should be diverted for ethanol production.

For maize, there are three sources of demand. First, households, who account for a small part of the demand. Second, maize is also used for supporting cattle and poultry and accounts for 60 per cent of the total feed.

Higher demand could potentially increase prices which will trickle to prices of dairy, meat and related products ethanol production

Third, for industrial use, where starch is the product. Ethanol will now be the fourth dimension. Considering that production using GM variety seeds is not permitted for maize, output growth and, as a consequence, demand has to be met by using existing domestic seeds. This can be a problem as demand for ethanol is now going to rise with E20 being made mandatory. Higher demand could potentially increase prices which will trickle to prices of dairy, meat and related products. A tempting solution would be to allow the use of GM seeds to enhance output for only ethanol production.

Presently, the excess stocks of rice held by the FCI, which were procured earlier, have been sold in the market. As the quality of rice

was low, it made sense to sell these stocks in the open market. But this cannot be the strategy going forward while considering a feedstock for producing ethanol. The higher water usage for rice and sugarcane may make maize a preferred feedstock. But the incremental output will only add to the pressure on water resources in the country. Curiously, there has also been a big push for the creation of data centres which are also heavy consumers of power and water. The supply of water will be a key challenge going ahead for the Indian economy.

The writer is chief economist, Bank of Baroda, and author of Corporate Quirks: The Darker Side of the Sun. Views are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Trust in Manipur

REHABILITATION MUST go beyond returning families to their former locations ('Ensure dignity, way back for Manipur's displaced', IE, September 19). Many displaced people need secure housing, livelihoods, schooling and health-care before they can rebuild their lives. The government should publish a clear, time-bound plan and involve local communities in implementing it. Independent monitoring can ensure that assistance reaches genuine beneficiaries. Restoring trust between communities is essential for durable peace.

Abbharna Barathi, Chennai

Prevent, protect

DRUG ADDICTION demands sustained attention rather than campaigns ('Punjab owes its young a chance to recover', IE, September 19). Families need accessible counselling, while affected young people require treatment without stigma and support after rehabilitation. Schools can strengthen prevention through awareness and early identification, while local bodies can coordinate with health professionals and community groups. Punjab needs more opportunities for skills and employment. Recovery becomes meaningful only when young people have support and a realistic future to work towards.

AS Nithis Kumar, Neelambur

Troubling delays

DELAYS IN pay, pensions and service benefits are troubling when they affect personnel who have completed their duties ('Don't force soldiers to fight for their due', IE, September 19). Government departments should adopt a digital system to track claims, with timelines and automatic escalation of unresolved cases. Periodic audits can identify systemic bottlenecks. A grievance mechanism would reduce litigation and ensure that legitimate dues reach personnel without hardship.

K Sakunthala, Coimbatore



MADAN SABNAVIS

THE PRICE of sugar has gone up. This is part of a normal cycle based on how sugar output moves. But, it comes at a time when there has been a push for the production of ethanol to reduce the import of crude oil. Some pertinent issues have been raised considering that sugarcane is also an important feedstock for producing ethanol. At a broader level, will this lead to pressure on crop supplies?

Ethanol can be produced from maize, rice and sugarcane-derived products. Around 45 per cent comes from maize and

When the hostel goes missing from the imagination of education



KRISHNA KUMAR

DISASTER GEOGRAPHY is now an important sub-discipline of its mother discipline. But it seldom includes urban locations. Satya Niketan in south Delhi, where a building fell recently, deserves a geographical look. Not far from this colony are two prestigious high-end hotels, Maurya and Taj.

The building that crumbled was serving as a hostel for students enrolled in nearby colleges. Not for nothing is it called "Satya" — just in case we forget that education is all about truth. The seven colleges located within a short distance of this colony are among the most reputed institutions of learning associated with the Delhi University. Its South Campus is close by. Then there are embassies and posh embassy schools. The contrast between a poor, wobbly structure and the seven-star hotels standing tall nearby is not easy to miss. However, certain latent aspects of academic induction of the young in contemporary India deserve recognition.

That hostel life is part of the academic experience is tacit common knowledge, but it is seldom articulated. The same university or college can mean very different things to the same batch of students, depending on who lived in the hostel and who dealt with the realities of a rented room. I am not talking of the nostalgia that hostel memories inevitably carry. Nor am I referring to matters like exclusion and discrimination — all too common in Indian higher education. The matter calls for a different kind of inquiry.

Gwyer Hall, Delhi University's prestigious hostel for men, can be a suitable starting point for this excavation. I have never lived there; only passed by it, except on two occasions when I went in. As a passerby, walking towards the Delhi Ridge, you feel as if the architectural grandeur of a quiet building is staring at you, inviting you. If you go inside, rows of palm trees and gracefully laid-out corridors around generous lawns invite you to devote at least a part of the day to reading a book. Lucky are the young men who get accommodation here. Others who find their names among those admitted to the adjoining Jubilee Hall are also lucky. The vast majority must accept living in the rough worlds of the neighbouring nagars surrounding Delhi University's North Campus.



The accommodation these youth hubs offer may be congested, but Satya Niketan is a different world.

Looking at Praveen Khanna's photograph of this habitation, published in this newspaper a few days ago, one is reminded of the saying: A picture is worth a thousand words. You just can't describe what you see, except by using stock phrases like narrow lanes and tangled wires. It takes a courageous mind and a positive spirit to imagine a student living in a Satya Niketan lane. You shudder while bringing into focus this student's hopes and perseverance nurtured, perhaps in a village, and applied to the heroic form-filling required for the Common University Entrance Test.

This mode of admission has been introduced to encourage trans-regional mobility. Several other steps have also been taken in recent years to promote geographical mobility so that nation-building can continue in the digital age. You wonder how the idea of purposeful mobility was not accompanied by a plan to build hostels. Perhaps it was a problem of money, or more likely a gap in imagination. Satya Niketan has brought to life a *satya* that will haunt Indian higher education for a while.

There are universities and colleges in countries where admission to first year compels a student to live in a hostel. Such a policy represents the recognition of the hostel as a means of induction, not just introduction, into a community of knowledge. Gracing the initial year of undergraduate education with such epithets sounds strange: It is, in fact, alien to a scenario like ours where the first-year student spends long humid afternoons standing in queues outside windows serving the newly arrived with suspicious glances. I once met a mother crying in the corridor. The verification clerk had noticed that the English spelling of her daughter's name in a document did not match older certificates. The originals had been issued in Hindi; the daughter had created the English spelling to fill in the digital application form. I suppose this story is a bit dated, given that a young person can now lose her vote on account of spelling discrepancies.

Owners of private rooms available on rent don't impose elaborate procedures. They just want the rent on time. Nor are they responsible for the width of the lane outside. And a bookshelf is not a recognised necessity, nor is a table lamp. Colleges are equally indifferent to their students' out-of-class, daily life experience. Only three of the seven colleges in the vicinity of Satya Niketan have hostels — small ones that accommodate just a fraction of the total strength. And teachers are also not expected to distinguish the hostellers from the day scholars — an old term that doesn't distinguish between commuters and occupiers of fragile buildings.

The writer is former director, NCERT

Washington arch to be used as military complex: Trump

Nathan Layne & Anusha Shah
Washington, September 20

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Sunday the triumphal arch he plans to build near Arlington National Cemetery in Washington would double as a “military complex” housing drones and snipers, as well as storing large quantities of ammunition.

The president cited national security concerns for the move, echoing the rationale offered for the roughly \$400 million ballroom complex being built on the site of the White House’s former East Wing. He did not identify any specific threats.

The projects are part of Trump’s ambitious effort to reshape Washington, including a push to add his name to the John F. Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts. The plans have drawn criticism from preservationists and others who argue they could alter or diminish historic landmarks.

In a social media post, Trumps said that at the “strong request” of the military he had agreed to turn the 250-foot (76-meter) arch “into a top grade Military Complex/Triumphal Arch, to house, store, and have



US President Donald Trump

the rapid ability to use large numbers of drones, plus Snipers, on both the roof and plaza areas, and additionally have and hold large quantities of sniper ammunition in storage.”

A US military official said that the Defence Department had nothing to add beyond Trump’s social media post. The White House did not immediately respond to a request for comment. Trump did not elaborate on why such capabilities would be needed at the arch.

Mark Cancian, a retired Marine colonel, said the move appeared aimed at countering opposition to the arch, which is planned for a traffic circle near Arlington National Cemetery, about a mile from Fort Myer, an active Army installation, and 3.2 km from the Pentagon.

Trump vows to launch new ‘AI Force’, adviser to be called ‘AI czar’

Reuters
Washington, September 20

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said in a social media post on Saturday that he plans to appoint a new artificial intelligence adviser, known as an “AI czar,” and create an “AI force,” though he did not provide details about either initiative or how they would be implemented.

Fears are growing in Washington among lawmakers about the risks posed by AI technology on humans and property. Earlier this month, former Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon said that “people building AI earnestly believe that it could kill us all by the end of the decade.”

Trump has repeatedly downplayed concerns about AI and argued that additional regulation is unnecessary.

“We will not in any way hinder or stifle the Growth of this incredible Industry,” Trump wrote on Truth Social, his social media platform.

“Rather, we will cherish it, help it, and watch over it, as it grows! However, we will also be looking for BAD, and we can do that, very easily, with our already existing Criminal and Civil Justice System.”

KYIV TARGETS MOSCOW ON LAST DAY OF PARLIAMENTARY VOTE

Ukraine launches massive drone attack amid polls in Russia

Andrew Osborn & Vladimir Soldatkin
Moscow, September 20

UKRAINE LAUNCHED what Moscow’s mayor called the biggest drone attack yet on the Russian capital on Sunday, as Russians voted on the final day of a parliamentary election that President Vladimir Putin has cast as a test of support for the war in Ukraine.

Voting systems have also faced waves of cyber attacks, according to election authorities, who said the electoral process had been mostly smooth despite what they described as external efforts to derail the State Duma vote - he first since Russia launched its full-scale war in Ukraine in February 2022.

The drone strikes killed three people in the Moscow region and two more in the Russian-held part of Ukraine’s Kherson region, including an election official, according to the region’s governor and the election commission. A facility at Moscow’s oil refinery, which has been targeted before, was also damaged. As voting got underway in the capital, flames and huge columns of smoke rose from the site on its outskirts.

“The biggest attack by enemy drones has been repelled,” Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said on Telegram. “This unprecedented attack was clearly planned with the aim of disrupting the elections. The enemy did not succeed.”

The vote is expected to see the ruling United Russia party easily retain its dominance in a political system critics say does not tolerate dissent.

The Kremlin is likely to present the outcome as evidence of public backing for Putin’s policies and for the war, now in its fifth year with no sign of ending soon.

Central Election Commission Chairwoman (CEC) Ella



A residential building hit by a Ukrainian drone strike in Kotelniki, Moscow, on Sunday. REUTERS

Pamfilova said the latest attacks had not deterred voters. “The more pressure they put on us, the more we are seeing an unprecedented level of what I would call public unity,” RIA news agency quoted her as saying.

She noted some Moscow voters may have experienced technical issues voting remotely due to the cyber attacks, but that everyone would get the opportunity to vote. Reuters reporters saw hours-long lines to vote at some polling stations in the city.

Turnout had reached nearly 57% as of early evening Moscow time, CEC data showed.

Most anti-war candidates have been barred from the ballot. Those who did run from the liberal Yabloko party, which has polled in the single digits in recent years but hoped to tap into war fatigue, said they feared for their freedom after courts handed long jail terms to two senior party figures before the vote for comments about the conflict.

Iran warns US against new attacks

Reuters
Dubai, September 20

IRAN WARNED on Sunday against any big new attack by the United States and its allies, saying it had information such a move was being prepared, adding to the anxiety in a region already on edge after drone and missile strikes on Saudi Arabia.

Iran’s military central command said on state media that any new attack would trigger sustained retaliation against US bases and interests, and that Washington’s regional allies would be considered parties to the conflict. It did not elaborate on the information it said it had about a coming US attack.



Iranian Americans hold a candlelight vigil against the Iranian regime outside the UN headquarters in New York on Monday. REUTERS

The US State Department issued a security alert on Saturday saying there was potential for unforeseen escalation in the Middle East and Americans should exercise more vigilance

and be aware of possible flight cancellations and airspace closures. Nearly seven months into the US-Iran war, neither side has looked ready to make major concessions needed to end violence.

Bessent, China’s He start talks on trade, AI, critical minerals

Reuters
New York, September 20

TREASURY SECRETARY Scott Bessent and Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng arrived in New York on Sunday for a meeting aimed at teeing up potential agreements on AI, tariffs and critical minerals for high-stakes summit this week between US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping.

The meetings at JPMorgan Chase’s headquarters in Manhattan, which will also include US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer, started shortly after Bessent’s arrival around 1430 GMT and were expected to run all day.

Before heading into the meeting, Bessent told reporters that he looked forward to “focused, fulsome and constructive talks” that would pave the way for the coming Trump-Xi summit in Washington.

Key topics will be a US-China trade truce that is set to expire on November 10, flows of Chinese rare-earth magnets and critical minerals that US officials say are insufficient and potential guard rails for AI.

The most likely outcome, analysts say, would be for Washington and Beijing to agree on small steps to show they are continuing to avoid escalating tensions in a delicate trade relationship that has major consequences for the global economy.

Many of the issues that He, Bessent and Greer will have to work through for Trump and Xi are holdovers from the two leaders’ May meeting in Beijing, including an effort on both sides to cut tariffs on non-strategic goods and Chinese pledges to increase purchases of US agricultural goods by \$17 billion a year and to purchase more than 200 Boeing aircraft.

Merz hit as Far-Right party tops another German state election

Reuters
Schwerin, September 20

THE ALTERNATIVE for Germany (AfD) took first place in state elections in northeastern Germany on Sunday, exit polls showed, delivering a “disaster” for Chancellor Friedrich Merz, who vowed to push ahead with his reform agenda.

The AfD was set to win 37% in the state of Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania, ahead of the Centre-Left Social Democrats on 35.5% and far in front of Merz’s conservatives, who got 5.5% and barely crossed the threshold to enter the state parliament, according to exit polls on ARD public television.

But the Far-Right party is unlikely to govern as the other main parties rule out working with it. If confirmed, Sunday’s result would be the worst in any state election for Merz’s party since 1949. It would also be another first-place finish at state level in a month for the AfD



German Chancellor Friedrich Merz gives a statement after first exit polls, in Berlin on Sunday. REUTERS

party, which is shunned by mainstream parties but is topping national opinion polls.

“It’s a disaster,” Merz said in televised remarks after the exit polls were published, but signalled that he would fight on as chancellor after speculation that a bad result could prompt him to resign.

In another election in the capital Berlin that also took place on Sunday, the far-left Linke

party was on 24.5%, while Merz’s conservatives were on 20% and the AfD also gained in strength, hitting 16%.

The elections in Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania, a largely rural state in the formerly communist east, and the capital Berlin follow the September 6 election in Saxony-Anhalt, where the AfD came close to the rare feat of winning an absolute majority.

Indian-German climber, Nepali Sherpa guide die in avalanche

Press Trust of India
Kathmandu, September 20

VIOLENCE FLARED in the occupied West Bank on Sunday when a suspected Palestinian gunman shot dead an Israeli man, police said, and Israeli soldiers killed a Palestinian motorist who the military said was attempting to run them over.

The gunman opened fire from his vehicle at Israelis gathered at a spring near the settlement of Neve Tzuf, near Ramallah, according to the Israeli military and police.

Medics who arrived at the scene of the shooting said they found a man in a car suffering from critical gunshot wounds. He was pronounced dead at hospital, police said.

The gunman was located a few hours later at a hospital in Ramallah and arrested, police said.

• CONSERVATIONISTS DESCRIBE THE 250-ROOM MANOR AS ONE OF BRITAIN’S FINEST EXAMPLES OF JACOBETHAN REVIVAL ARCHITECTURE

Once home to *Batman*, this mansion is now plagued by bats

Leo Sands
London, September 20

CHRISTIAN BALE once stalked its grounds as Batman, plotting his caped crusade from its recesses. But the stately English home that featured in Christopher Nolan’s 2005 film “Batman Begins” has lately hosted another type of bat: the smaller and smellier kind.

Mentmore Towers, the 19th-century Jacobethan estate that served as Wayne Manor and as a backdrop for other movies, was found littered with bat droppings during an inspection by local environmental officials last year. They also found a dead bat.

Spooked by its decline, authorities in Buckinghamshire, in the countryside northwest of London, are demanding that Mentmore’s owners carry out urgent bat surveys and roof repairs. If not, officials said, they could move to force the owners to sell the mansion, which holds a Grade I listing, Britain’s highest heritage status.

“Our focus and priority is making sure this Grade I-listed building — well known and well-loved in Buckinghamshire — is protected and preserved,” Peter Strachan, deputy leader of the local council, said this month.

Conservationists describe the 250-room manor as one of



At least two species of bat appeared to be roosting in Mentmore Towers in the countryside northwest of London. NYT

Britain’s finest examples of Jacobethan Revival architecture, an amalgam of Elizabethan and Jacobean styles.

It has been owned by the family trust of British Syrian property tycoon Simon Halabi since 1998. Local officials gave

Halabi’s family trust a deadline of Oct. 4 to comply with its repair notice and conduct professional bat surveys.

At least two species of bat appeared to be roosting in Mentmore Towers, local inspectors said, based on the droppings found there. Inspectors shared photographs of broken windows, ceiling holes and cracked exterior walls, which they said had offered the bats possible entry routes.

Bats are a protected species in Britain and property owners are legally obligated to take precautions to avoid disturbing them.

In response to the notice, Halabi’s family said that it had

begun a bat survey and a program of repairs and restorations.

“There is an irony in the suggestion that nobody is dealing with the bats when a team of professional ecologists, effectively Mentmore’s own ‘Batman’ team, has already been on the case,” it said in a statement.

Long before it was a filming location — including for Stanley Kubrick’s “Eyes Wide Shut” (1999), the Sacha Baron Cohen comedy “Ali G Indahouse” (2002) and the Spice Girls’ “Goodbye” music video — Mentmore served for over a century as a country palace of the Rothschild banking dynasty. NYT

• BRIEFLY

ITALY

Meloni to ban veils in schools, limit foreign students per class



Italian PM Giorgia Meloni. FILE

ITALY IS preparing to ban face coverings in schools and to cap the number of foreign students per class, Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni said on Sunday as she played up her right-wing credentials at a youth event organised by her party. Italy is among the European countries most exposed to migrant arrivals because of its central Mediterranean location, making migration a hot-button issue and a major challenge for successive governments. The integration of migrants, particularly those from Muslim-majority countries, remains contentious in Italian politics and society. Debates over religious symbols, cultural integration, citizenship rules and immigration policy frequently polarize public opinion. REUTERS

TANZANIA

Ten lions found dead, suspected case of poisoning

TEN LIONS were found dead in Tanzania’s Ngorongoro wildlife reserve this week and preliminary findings suggest they may have been poisoned, the area’s management authority said. The deaths raise concerns over the conservation of lions in one of Africa’s most renowned wildlife ecosystems. Poisoning has been a recurring threat to large carnivores across parts of East Africa, often linked to conflicts between predators and livestock owners. REUTERS

TAIWAN

Minister makes rare trip to China for APEC event

TAIWAN’S LABOUR minister left for China to attend an APEC event, the first ministerial-level visit of President Lai Ching-te’s administration at a time when Beijing has ramped up military and political pressure against Taipei. The Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation group is one of the few international bodies that Chinese-claimed Taiwan belongs to, and China is the host nation this year, with a leaders summit scheduled for November. REUTERS

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

Imran Khan’s sister detained by authorities

PAKISTANI AUTHORITIES on Sunday detained Aleema Khan, the sister of jailed former prime minister Imran Khan, ahead of a planned protest by his party next week. Aleema was detained in Lahore and transferred to Kot Lakhpat jail, according to sources. She was detained under the Punjab Maintenance of Public Order Ordinance, 1960, which allows local police to arrest anyone perceived as a threat to public peace. PTI

BANGLADESH

PM to highlight Rohingya, climate at UNGA

BANGLADESH PRIME Minister Tarique Rahman is set to deliver his maiden UN General Assembly address in Bangla on September 24, highlighting the Rohingya crisis, climate change and his government’s democratic agenda, according to a media report. Rahman will leave Dhaka for New York on September 21 and is scheduled to return on September 25, the state-owned BSS news agency reported on Sunday. PTI

Ed Sheeran slams Israel’s Gaza policy, apologises for music festival controversy

Reuters
Philadelphia, September 20

POP STAR Ed Sheeran apologized Saturday for his handling of a controversy that erupted this week when rapper Macklemore was removed as an opening act over comments on the occupied Palestinian territories.

Breaking his silence on the issue, the British singer decried Israel’s treatment of residents in Gaza as “unjustifiable.”

“I’ve had to take and make difficult decisions and I am making mistakes and I’m so, so sorry,” Sheeran told an audience in Philadelphia, where he performed for the first time since Macklemore was taken off the concert tour.

At the start of the concert at Lincoln Financial Field, Sheeran called the October 2023 Hamas attack that killed 1,200 Israelis “horrific.” But he called Israel’s subsequent war, which has killed thousands in Gaza and displaced almost all of the population, “catastrophic and unjustifiable and disproportionate.”

Sheeran also decried “systemic injustice” in the West Bank, where Israel’s right-wing coalition government has allowed a massive expansion of Jewish settlements.

The pop star’s opening statement on Saturday offered a stark change from his statements earlier in the week, when Sheeran posted on Instagram that his concert audiences “do not expect a political forum.”



Ed Sheeran performs during the second day of the iHeartRadio Music Festival in Las Vegas on Sunday. REUTERS

Controversy has surrounded Sheeran since Macklemore posted on Instagram that New England Patriots owner Robert Kraft had told Sheeran that Macklemore would not be allowed to perform at Gillette Stadium in Foxborough, Massachusetts, where Sheeran has shows on September 25 and 26. Macklemore said Kraft and other stadium owners had told Sheeran he would not be allowed to perform in their venues if Macklemore remained on the tour after saying “Free Palestine” during a September 4 concert at MetLife Stadium in East Rutherford, New Jersey.

‘NEED TO SHIFT TO DOMESTIC THORIUM FROM IMPORT DEPENDENCY OF URANIUM AS EARLY AS POSSIBLE’

India's top nuclear scientist calls for early thorium shift in PHWRs

INDIA'S TOP nuclear scientist Anil Kakodkar has advocated the early introduction of thorium-based fuel into the indigenous pressurised heavy water reactor (PHWR) fleet, while continuing in parallel with the three-stage nuclear programme, to speed up the utilisation of the country's abundant thorium reserves.

The three-stage nuclear power programme was conceived in the 1950s by Homi Bhabha, the architect of India's nuclear programme.

With the world transitioning from uranium to thorium, the appeal of PHWRs will grow, particularly in emerging economies, **Anil Kakodkar**, former Chairman of the Atomic Energy Commission, who now holds the position of the Chancellor at Homi Bhabha National Institute and the Chairman of Rajiv Gandhi Science & Technology Commission, told **Anil Sasi** in an interview. Edited excerpts:

After SHANTI Act's passage, the Centre seems veering around to the view that opening up of this strategic atomic energy sector is primarily to access external funding, rather than source foreign technology. Is it safe to presume that indigenous PHWRs would continue to be the mainstay of future capacity addition plans?

Unlike other energy forms, nuclear reactors are fuel producers as well, alongside their role as energy producers. Lever-

aging this feature is important for a country like India which has large energy needs with very insufficient energy resources.

National nuclear energy and nuclear fuel recycling policy thus remains an important guiding force, along with economic considerations, for driving the choice of nuclear reactors systems and their growth. Since fuel recycling activities have to remain within the government, nurturing a symbiotic and mentoring relationship between the government and the public or private sector utilities holds utmost importance.

The PHWR system has been developed as a part of our well conceived approach to India's self-reliance, and long-term energy security or independence, to be realised through India's globally largest thorium resources. Barring molten salt reactors (MSRs), which are yet to mature, PHWRs are the best platforms for utilising thorium among thermal reactors.

Most importantly, PHWR has also established itself as a robust, safe and economically competitive technology, and thus offers significant attraction to investors — while also taking India's nuclear energy policy forward. It would thus be natural to expect domestic PHWR to occupy a major share of the 100 GWe nuclear mission (to be implemented between now and 2047) with imported LWRs occupying most of the remaining share.



The large-scale deployment of fast breeder reactors (FBRs) is a work-in-progress. To catch up, how compelling is the need for a quick solution to tide over the slowdown in nuclear capacity addition rate due to fuel supply constraints?

Although commercial uranium and thorium resources are roughly equal globally, nuclear energy programmes naturally began with uranium since the only naturally available fissile isotope is uranium-235. However, there appears to be a political/global security-related constraint in adopting uranium recycling by most countries, drastically reducing uranium's energy potential. Rapid growth in nuclear energy programmes that is on the anvil worldwide, and a reluctance to recycle uranium is expected to create supply-demand mismatch and related uranium supply security challenges that could hit India in

the next 10-15 years. Large FBR capacity, particularly fuelled by metallic fuel, that breeds nuclear fuel more efficiently, is very important and its large scale electricity contribution is a very compelling national necessity.

Is there a solution in fuel-cycle options rather than reactor options? If the plan is to continue with PHWRs, how crucial is it to explore introducing thorium at an earlier stage than envisaged in our original 3-stage programme? In that context, how important is the possibility of exploring thorium irradiation, along with HALEU (a new type of fuel that blends thorium with a more concentrated type of uranium called HALEU, or high-assay low-enriched uranium), in PHWRs at scale? To deploy recycled used fuel, is there a need for additional power generation capacity, including through MSRs?

The reactor option has to necessarily depend on the nuclear fuel cycle option. It seems to me that the days of natural and low enriched uranium fuel cycle will soon get past their peak.

The capacity that global uranium resources can sustain in once-through mode is around 550-750 GWe (assuming a reactor life of 60 years), whereas the nuclear capacity of ~1,400 GWe by year 2050 has been projected by the World Nuclear Associ-

ation. While FBRs remain critical for our long-term energy security and nuclear fuel supply, including from thorium, we are unlikely to reach the scale required for their deployment to sustain power capacity growth when uranium shortages start constraining it. Fast reactor technology has to evolve through a few technology transitions such as oxide-fuelled reactors, metallic-fuelled reactors, and related fuel-cycle technologies.

Thus, there are around two to three decades gap before one can think of fleet mode deployment of these reactors, and leverage them for thorium irradiation at scale in accordance with our three-stage programme strategy. This is where fleet mode construction of PHWRs, that is ongoing, comes in handy.

Using HALEU-thorium fuel in PHWRs, without any significant design change, opens an earlier parallel path to thorium irradiation at scale while also gaining the advantages of reduced spent fuel inventory, greater economy, uranium saving, and greater safety.

This should enable earlier initiation of the third stage with thorium molten salt reactors (TMSRs) are supposed to be developed as part of the three-stage programme) in about 15 years from now. Irradiated thorium input from fast reactors, whenever available at scale, will augment the third stage deployment momentum. **FULL INTERVIEW ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**

How agentic AI could transform the way we make digital payments

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, September 20

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE (AI) is the hot topic right now, with industries such as IT already seeing a structural change with the adoption of new technologies. The payments industry is also integrating AI into its services, particularly agentic AI.

Conventional AI has been integrated into the payments ecosystem for quite some time, helping reduce friction in payments process and enhancing digital safety by making backend process more reliable, and screening consumers from fraudulent transactions.

However, agentic AI might take the industry towards agentic commerce, where an AI agent will take care of a consumer's entire payment journey, making it frictionless.

The Global Fintech Fest (GFF), held in Mumbai from September 8-11, saw many of the country's top payments companies showcase AI integration into their products. The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) unveiled MyUPI — an AI-powered revamp campaign of delegating pre-authorised payments, and automatic and seamless filing of payment disputes. It also launched a backend tool that acts as a “connective tissue” for AI interaction across the financial ecosystem, called Agentic Orchestration and Messaging (aToM).

While agentic AI — a model that executes tasks for users without constant prompts, but within certain limits — could streamline the entire “procurement to payment” process for businesses, its adoption is still at a nascent stage. At present, agentic commerce happens to be its biggest use-case.

• PAYMENT EVOLUTION

AGENTIC COMMERCE is a digital trade model under which AI agents streamline the buying process on behalf of customers

IT DOESN'T bypass authorisation, but only cuts down steps in a customer's e-commerce journey, and saves their time

IT ALSO takes care of the payments stage, and can determine the ideal card or mode of payment for a transaction



THE CONSUMER will have oversight, and can change any of the components during the process

What is agentic commerce?

Agentic commerce is a digital trade model under which AI agents streamline the buying process by discovering, negotiating, and executing on behalf of customers. This does not mean bypassing the need for authorisation. It only cuts down steps involved in a customer's e-commerce journey, including the payments phase.

For example, AI-powered tools can notify a customer of discounts on products that they have been viewing for months. If they decide to buy it, the AI agent on their payments platform can determine

the ideal card or mode of payment — cutting down the need for multiple OTPs and authorisation requirements to just one-time authentication — for the transaction. Thus, the consumer will have oversight, and can change any of the components during the process. But they will save their time, and may find the best deal if they proceed with the whole process.

Amazon Pay's smart wallet, demonstrated at the GFF last week, is one such example. “With agentic AI, I think that assistance for humans to get their

job done in a very informed, intelligent manner, with a lot of control and trust, is kind of a large opportunity we see. And how that companion fits into what we call a Smart Wallet,” said Girish Krishnan, Director of payments, rewards, and merchant services at Amazon Pay India.

The Smart Wallet uses features such as smart recommendations, biometric authentication, and a tap-and-pay feature, and an AI agent taking care of each step to save the consumer's time. It also has the ability to auto-execute small-ticket regular purchases within a particular limit. For instance, if a customer with the monthly limit of Rs 10,000 orders groceries, they won't have to authenticate the process each time until the grocery amount for a month exceeds the threshold.

Such a feature is now being widely adopted by the payments industry. MyUPI has a similar feature. Other digital wallets provided by Samsung Pay, Google Pay, and PhonePe also offer similar features that enable pin-less small-ticket purchases. While not AI, Amazon Pay adds to this feature with its agentic commerce ecosystem.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NPCIL begins fuel loading at RAPP-8, unit nears operation

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, September 20

NUCLEAR POWER Corporation of India Limited (NPCIL) has begun initial fuel loading (IFL) at Unit 8 of the Rajasthan Atomic Power Project (RAPP) in Rawatbhata, Rajasthan, marking a key step towards commissioning the 700-megawatt-electric (MWe) indigenous pressurised heavy water reactor (PHWR). The reactor is expected to commence commercial operation during the current financial year.

The process from initial fuel loading to commercial operation of the unit typically takes about six to eight months.

“Initial Fuel Loading commenced at 15:18 hrs on September 19, 2026, in the presence of Shri S. D. Paraswar, Director (Operations); Shri N. K. Mitharwal, Director (Projects); Shri D. S. Rao, Site Director, Rawatbhata Rajasthan Site, along with the Station Directors,” NPCIL said in a statement. The commencement of IFL followed permission from the Atomic Energy Regulatory Board (AERB) and completion of the prescribed prerequisites. “The permission was granted following rigorous safety evaluations, major system integrity audits and site readiness reviews conducted as part of the regulatory process,” the state-owned company said.

“With the commencement of IFL, Unit 8 has entered an important stage of its commissioning journey. The next major steps will include the First Ap-

proach to Criticality (FAC), marking the start of a controlled fission chain reaction, followed by the commencement of power generation,” NPCIL said.

Unit 8 of RAPP is the fourth reactor in the series of 16 indigenous 700 MWe PHWRs being set up in the country, the company said. The first two reactors in this series — Units 3 and 4 at Kakrapar Atomic Power Station (KAPS) in Gujarat — commenced commercial operation in 2023-24, followed by Unit 7 of RAPP in April 2025.

NPCIL said the development further strengthens the standardisation of the 700 MWe PHWR reactor design and supports its continued deployment in fleet mode.

“The progress at RAPP-8 reflects the continued advancement of India's indigenous nuclear power programme and NPCIL's commitment to the safe, clean, reliable and sustained generation of nuclear power-based electricity,” the state-owned company added.

Meanwhile, geotechnical investigations for Units 9 and 10 at the RAPP site in Rawatbhata also commenced on September 19, marking a key step in the foundational development of the project. *The Indian Express* has learnt. Apart from Unit 8 of RAPP, NPCIL currently has eight other reactors under construction — two each at Gorakhpur in Haryana and Kaiga in Karnataka, and four at Kudankulam in Tamil Nadu.

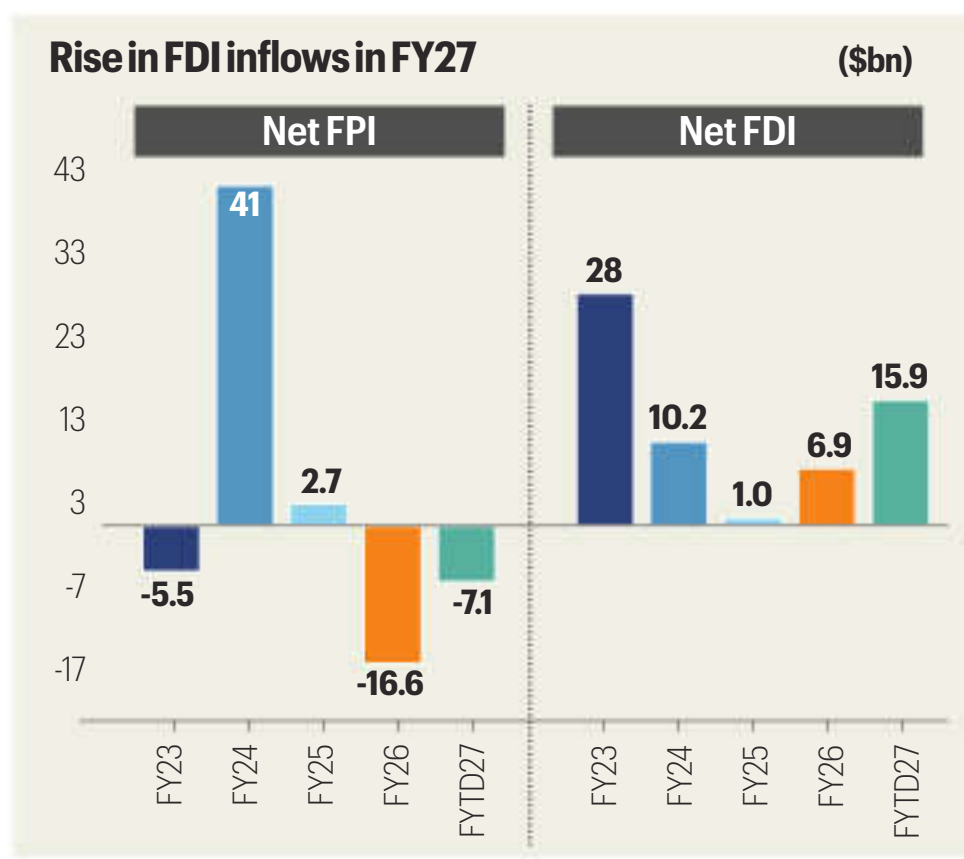
• India's external situation improving even beyond FCNR(B)

\$127 billion+

of inflows through FCNR(B) deposits have improved India's external buffers, the situation has also improved due to other factors.

● According to Gaura Sen Gupta, Chief Economist at IDFC FIRST Bank, net FDI in the year as a whole could be more than \$20 billion. This would be two-and-a-half times the net inflow of \$7.9 billion in 2024-25 and 2025-26 put together.

● “If this sustains, then the reliance on other highly volatile capital inflows such as FPI to fund the current account deficit will be lower,” Sen Gupta said.



Net FDI inflows in the first four months	2025-26	\$9.3 billion	Gross FDI inflows, which hit a new record of \$95 billion in 2025-26, are up 15% so far this year.
	2026-27	\$15.9 billion	

SOURCE: CEIC, IDFC FIRST BANK ECONOMICS RESEARCH

NSE's shareholders retain significant stake even after tendering shares in OFS

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, September 20

A MAJORITY of the existing shareholders of the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) have retained a significant portion of their holdings even after tendering shares in the offer-for-sale (OFS) component of the exchange's Rs 22,569-crore initial public offering (IPO).

The selling shareholders largely comprised institutional investors, who collectively held a 36.82% stake in NSE before the IPO and tendered shares representing a 5.11% stake in the ex-

change, according to an analysis of data. Of the 20 institutional shareholders that participated in the OFS, nine were foreign institutional investors, which collectively held a 15.96% stake before the IPO, it added.

The remaining 11 were domestic institutions, comprising 10 public sector entities and ICICI Lombard General Insurance, which together held a 20.86% stake before the OFS.

Several large institutional shareholders have largely stayed put despite participating in the OFS. Aranda Investments, which held a 4.54%

stake before the OFS, Stock Holding Corporation of India with a 4.44% stake, SBI Capital Markets with 4.33% and Chrysler Capital with 3.73% have reduced their holdings by an average of only around 7%.

Among other large foreign investors, Crown Capital offered around 11% of its pre-OFS holding, while TA Asia Pacific reduced its holding by about 6%.

The pattern indicates that the OFS has allowed existing investors to partially monetise their investments while continuing to hold substantial stakes in NSE.

Adani Power to invest Rs 48k cr in 3,200-MW Assam project

Mumbai: Adani Power will invest Rs 48,000 crore in its upcoming 3,200 MW thermal power in Assam.

Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday laid the foundation stone for Adani Power (APL) 3,200 MW ultra-supercritical thermal power plant (USTPP) at Chapar in lower Assam's Dhubri district.

“In just a few years, this project will become the largest power generation asset in the Northeast. It will fuel industries, give businesses the power to scale, and help bring affordable electricity to homes,” Jeet Adani, director, Adani Group.

The Chapar plant is part of a Rs 63,000-crore power investment in Assam, with commissioning in phases from December 2030. Across sectors, investments in the state will exceed Rs 80,000 crore, with projects already moving from commitment to execution and set to create jobs, infrastructure and new economic opportunities across Assam over the next three to four years, he said. FE

FMCG firms to hold prices despite rise in commodity costs; focus on volumes

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, September 20

FMCG COMPANIES are likely to hold prices through the festive season despite a rise in commodity prices, including sugar, and the impact of geopolitical disruptions, as they seek to protect consumer demand and maintain volume growth amid improving consumption.

Leading industry executives said companies have already gone for judicious increases of around 2-5% in the June quarter to partly offset higher input costs and are unlikely to raise prices further before the end of the festive season, even as margins remain under pressure.

The sector has been facing renewed cost pressures, with sugar prices touching a new high, alongside a sharp increase in costs of key inputs such as edible oils, coffee, cocoa and crude oil derivatives used in packaging, amid geopolitical disruptions and supply concerns in global markets.

While most companies have

absorbed a significant part of the inflation through cost-control initiatives and portfolio management, they remain focused on protecting volume growth, even as pressure on margins remains elevated, industry executives said.

ITC Chief Executive Officer, Foods Division, and Executive Director Hemant Malik said the company would maintain prices through the festive season despite cost inflation.

“We are attempting to hold prices,” Malik said, noting that companies have been absorbing a large part of the increase in commodity prices through cost management initiatives and portfolio actions.

Referring to the impact of the goods and services tax rate reduction on several consumer products last year, Malik said the move had led to buoyancy in volumes across multiple categories and supported market demand. However, he indicated that companies may have to revisit pricing decisions later in the financial year if cost pressures persist.

• BRIEFLY

Hiring gains momentum in smaller cities

Mumbai: Small cities are emerging as major talent hubs, with a majority of employers witnessing a significant increase in hiring from tier II and III locations in the last two years, according to a report. India's hiring landscape is increasingly moving beyond traditional metropolitan centres, as 69% of organisations reported increasing hiring from tier II and III cities by more than 30% over the last two years, said the report by workforce staffing and HR solutions Genius HRTech Ltd. PTI

Titan open to acquiring smaller watch brands

Bengaluru: Watchmaker Titan Company, which has been expanding its premium and luxury watch portfolio, is open to acquiring or investing in smaller and emerging brands as part of its growth strategy, a top company official said. The Tata group firm expects a “robust” festive season this year, driven by healthy consumer demand and an early wedding season coinciding with a delayed Diwali, said Titan Company Chief Marketing Officer Ranjani Krishnaswamy. PTI

• NEW MOBILE-MEMORY CHIPS HOLD 50% MORE DATA THAN PRIOR COMPARABLE PRODUCTS

CXMT's new memory-chip platform enters mass production

Reuters
Beijing, September 20

CHINESE DRAM chipmaker CXMT said on Sunday its fifth-generation technology platform had entered mass production, a claimed breakthrough that could help China build a stronger competitor to Samsung Electronics, SK Hynix and Micron Technology in the global market for memory chips.

DRAM, or dynamic random-access memory, is the short-term working memory that phones, computers and other devices use to run apps and programmes. The new platform is designed to make more powerful memory chips at lower cost and with less

power use. CXMT, which listed on Shanghai's STAR Market this year, said it would give electronics makers an additional source of supply for chips used in smartphones and other devices.

CXMT, China's leading producer of DRAM, said the new platform packs the tiny structures that store data closer together, allowing more memory to fit on each chip and more individual chips to be made from each silicon wafer.

The Hefei-based memory-chip maker said it had reduced the spacing of key features in the part of the chip that stores data to 11.95 nanometres, or about 12 billionths of a metre.

It achieved this using



CXMT said it would give electronics makers an additional source of supply for chips used in smartphones and other devices. REUTERS

“quadruple patterning,” a process that repeats several manufacturing steps to produce finer circuit patterns. “Our process capability is now on par with

the most advanced mass-produced nodes out there in the industry,” Luo Xiaodong, CXMT's vice president and head of its marketing centre, said at the

2026 World Manufacturing Convention in Hefei.

CXMT unveils two new chips

CXMT also unveiled two 24-gigabit LPDDR5X products made on the new platform. LPDDR5X is a power-saving type of DRAM used mainly in smartphones and other portable electronics. The products each hold 50% more data than CXMT's previous equivalent products and are already in mass production, the company said. They are offered in two package formats for different smartphone and portable-device designs.

CXMT said the platform can produce at least 50% more gross

chip dies per wafer than its fourth-generation platform, using an 8-gigabit-chip baseline.

That measures the potential number of chips made from a wafer before defective units are excluded, rather than the proportion that pass final testing.

CXMT said it developed the platform using computer simulations and joint work with Chinese chip-equipment makers on critical production steps.

The advance comes as Beijing seeks to reduce reliance on foreign semiconductor technology and US export controls since 2022 have restricted China's access to certain advanced chipmaking equipment and related software.

Idea Exchange

MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 21, 2026

NEW S M A K E R S I N T H E N E W S R O O M

WHY GAJENDRA SINGH SHEKHAWAT

Gajendra Singh Shekhawat is the Union Minister of Culture and Tourism. The tourism ministry is currently outlining ambitious targets to increase the tourism ministry's contribution to the GDP. He also spearheaded India's return to the ongoing edition of the Venice Biennale with a national pavilion after seven years. He is leading the two ministries at a pivotal moment when the strategic mandate across government and the party is to connect more with Gen Z



ON THE GOVT CONNECTING WITH GEN Z

You have to connect with this generation with more energy. Those who are Gen Z today will become voters in the forthcoming elections, so establishing a dialogue with them is essential



ON POLITICISATION OF VANDE MATARAM

Inclusivity at the cost of our national song, culture, ideology and soul has damaged the country. Truncated in the past, Vande Mataram was our ideal then and is our ideal today

'This generation is over-powered with information. To deal with them, you have to change... In a tsunami, only flexible trees that bend can stay alive'

Union Minister for Culture and Tourism Gajendra Singh Shekhawat on the BJP's efforts to connect with the younger generation, navigating the challenges facing the tourism sector and the government's response to the student protest at Jantar Mantar. He was in conversation with Liz Mathew, Deputy Editor, *The Indian Express*



Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, Union Minister for Culture and Tourism (right), with Liz Mathew, Deputy Editor, *The Indian Express* RENUKA PURI

Liz Mathew: The mandate across the ministries and party right now is to appeal to Gen Z. Recently, in an 'Under-18 World' video, you were seen doing crafts, pretending you were a 15-year-old and dancing with teenagers. What has changed you? Is it the Gen Z fever?

No, it is not like that. The children came to my room, and a 16-and-a-half-year-old girl introduced herself as the Chief Minister of Telangana, with her Deputy CM, Speaker, Leader of Opposition, Chief Secretary and a 12-year-old Secretary. They asked me my age. When I said I was 58, she said that would not work and that I had to be equal to them, so I agreed to be 15. If you want to talk to children, you have to match their wavelength. It was a coincidence rather than a planned Gen Z trend.

Liz Mathew: So it doesn't have to do with the party's new decision to have a big, massive outreach to Gen Z?

I look at this decision of the party in an organic way. We all say India is a country of the youth. Today's youth has a lot of curiosity and wants to participate. When we were young, we had our studies, games and friends, and didn't think much beyond that. But today's youth has knowledge available at their fingertips. You have to connect with such an aware generation with more energy. Those who are Gen Z today will become voters in the forthcoming elections, so establishing a dialogue with them is essential.

Liz Mathew: Do you think political parties across the board can speak their language effectively?

Our dialogue with them has been an ongoing process. But this generation, particularly over the last five to seven years, has experienced enormous change. I was born in a village and have seen a house without electricity, but now I see children in villages using AI. In college, getting new information required going to the library. Today, you just ask a question. This generation is over-powered with information, so if you want to deal with them, you have to change yourself. In a tsunami of change, only flexible trees that bend remain alive.

Liz Mathew: Gen Z has been talking about employment, and both tourism and culture are closely linked to their future. What are you doing to address their concerns?

At the macro level, the Indian economy has grown from \$2 trillion to \$4 trillion in the last 10-12 years. Infrastructure has grown, commuting has become easier, taxes have been reduced, salaries have increased and disposable income has risen. The government also provides free rations to 80 crore people, saving a family Rs 1,000-1,500 a month.

At Mahakal in Ujjain, annual footfall grew from under 40 lakh in 2014 to 7 crore currently. But it is not only religious tourism, domestic travel has grown enormously. Last year, 420 crore domestic travels were recorded where people stayed at least one night elsewhere. India has rich cultural diversity, history, monuments, wildlife, cuisine, costumes and music. Today, tourism contributes around 6 per cent of GDP, and the PM has given us a target of 10 per cent. Once reached, tourism will create the most jobs in India after agriculture.

Divya A: What is the roadmap to achieving the 10 per cent, and what about the demand for industry status?

Tourism is primarily a state subject. In 2024, I commissioned a study of state policies and formulated a draft policy and framework shared with all states and UTs. While industry status has been extended across states, gaps remain, whereas states like Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Mizoram and Meghalaya are extending great incentives. At the Centre, we addressed the hospitality sector's demand for infrastructure status. Traditionally, hotel loans had short 7-8 year repayment windows despite long gestation periods. Infrastructure status extends repayment periods to 20-25 years and lowers interest rates for hotels built in destinations with populations under 10 lakh, as well as at 50 designated iconic destinations. We are also working to reduce the burden of clearances, as over 30 types of compliances still apply.

Divya A: Foreign tourist arrivals have not reached the 2019 benchmark of 11 million. What are we doing?

We consider 2019 the pre-Covid benchmark. Tourism was the most hit sector. It sinks first during a crisis and stands back up last. After recovery, the Russia-Ukraine war and geopolitical turbulence affected our feeder countries.

But another challenge is that India's tourism became expensive because domestic demand grew faster than supply, making India expensive compared to Dubai or Thailand. In 2024, total five-star hotel rooms in India were fewer than in New York City alone. Since building hotels takes at least three years, policy incentives to expand room supply are vital.

Vikas Pathak: Does the growth in religious tourism necessarily mean people have more disposable income, or is there a rise in religiosity? Has non-religious tourism grown similarly?

It is not only religious tourism. Go to any

destination in India and the biggest challenge is overtourism. In Kashmir, which is not a religious destination, 40,000 new rooms were added between 2019 and 2026, yet in Pahalgam people struggled to find rooms even in summer. Footfall has increased across destinations because per capita income has increased on record.

Anchal Magazine: Safety is key for travel, especially for foreign tourists and solo female travellers. If harassment or theft happen in India, they go back with that impression. What are you doing to ensure safety?

Even one such incident is a black mark on the country. Overall, there were 2 crore international arrivals in the country. Ideally, I assume 50 per cent would be women. Tell me, how many such incidents occurred in the last five years? When you go to Italy, the advisory you get is that you should keep your valuables hidden inside your clothes. In the US, it used to be part of the advisory that after evening or at night, don't leave the main road for an alley, even in New York. But does anyone say that America is unsafe? Two shoot-outs happen every month in America. Recently, we saw a man playing football with a beheaded Indian's head. Two crore people come to India. If two incidents happen somewhere, our media channels use those for 24 hours for TRPs.

It is our responsibility to ensure the safety of our travellers. India is a country that believes in *Atithi Devo Bhava*. And today I can tell you that India is the safest country for solo women travellers.

Dheeraj Mishra: In the 10 per cent share of tourism in GDP, is there a plan for how many tourists will be carried by railways and highways when the numbers increase? What about the environmental concerns, especially in the hills, over increased tourists?

Growth will happen in everything equally. The way India's aviation industry has grown in the last 10 years, the number of airports has increased. Today, our biggest

challenge having fewer aircraft. India's players — Air India, Indigo or Akasa — together have booked the highest number of airplanes in the world. People are taking their cars anywhere in India because they feel safe and comfortable. The road network has expanded. The Vande Bharat Express is also receiving a good response. All these will grow at an equal pace.

Sustainability is a big challenge, and it is happening everywhere in the world. Wherever I go on tourism-related international or multi-lateral platforms, this concern has emerged everywhere.

Other countries can control the number of footfalls through visas. But if we have to give permits to those going to Shimla in India, that wouldn't be right. There are two ways to solve this. One is to create other attractions in cities beyond the usual spots. Goa took an initiative — Goa Beyond Beaches — to decongest the beaches and add new experiences. The Prime Minister has also put forward the idea to build 50 new

global-standard iconic destinations. Although, I believe this problem will remain because by the time we build 50, demand will have increased five-fold.

We are not just working on the supply side; we have also started working on the demand side. How can the traveller's behaviour be more responsible? When we go to another country, Indians automatically become responsible. But in India, we consider it our right; this is our country, we can do whatever we want.

Liz Mathew: Nowadays, Indian tourists abroad too create a bad name.

Of the 2.5 crore people travelling outside of India, maybe 250 people do something wrong. You shouldn't judge the country's character by that.

We took on a pilot project called 'Paryatan Mitra' or 'Paryatan Didi', where we train local youngsters. In the future, we will train 10,000 such children. We have also worked on re-skilling tourist guides so that they

ON WOMEN TRAVELLERS' SAFETY IN INDIA

If two incidents happen somewhere, the media uses those for 24 hours for TRPs. India is a country that believes in 'Atithi Devo Bhava'. And today, I can tell you that India is the safest country for solo women travellers



Manoj C G: You said we have to match the wavelength of this generation, but when you say a minister resigned to 'pamper the children', aren't you patronising them?

What is right is right. The children I spoke to were very smart. They asked me a difficult question and were satisfied with my answer.

Suanshu Khurana: During the lathi charge at Jantar Mantar, Parliament wanted to discuss Vande Mataram and the inclusion of all its six stanzas. What do you think about the politicisation of the national song?

During the freedom struggle, when the self-confidence of Indians had wavered, Vande Mataram awakened that self-confidence. It served as a uniting thread across tribal and sanyasi movements, 1857 and the Quit India Movement. Thousands took bullets, hung from gallows or received lathi blows with the two words 'Vande Mataram' on their lips. Who politicised such a sacred song? First, the Congress did it when, in the name of appeasement, they divided it into two parts.

Suanshu Khurana: Wouldn't you call it inclusivity?

Now, when the country is commemorating it with a sense of gratitude on the completion of 150 years — a song which the Constituent Assembly gave a status equal to Jana Gana Mana — it was decided that it should be codified. Where was there any scope for politics in this?

Suanshu Khurana: It seems to appeal to the BJP's idea of nationalism.

It appeals to the idea of *Bharatiyatva* (Indianness). Where is the politics in this? Ask those who are opposing it why they are. Because of those same feelings of appeasement. Even now, they see that vote bank.

Liz Mathew: Why do you call inclusivity appeasement?

Inclusivity at the cost of our national song, culture, ideology and soul has damaged the country. Truncated under past pressure, Vande Mataram was our ideal then and is our ideal today.

Shahid Pervez: At a 'Chhatron Ki Gooni' event Rahul Gandhi urged women to smash patriarchy. How do you look at the issue of patriarchy? flagged by the LOP?

He should be ashamed. He is looking at his political future by climbing onto the shoulders of children. Indians are not going to vote based on such deceptive things.

Adrija Roychowdhury: What is the Centre doing to create national or international interest in the Keeladi excavations in Tamil Nadu?

The ASI conducted excavations with the Centre's permission, but the submitted report had shortcomings — incomplete scientific evidence, charts, diagrams and photographs. The state government politicised its non-publication. Without scientific validation, publishing it would destroy our credibility. Once validated, we will be more than happy as it adds a new dimension to our civilisational development.

Saikat Bose: The Malviya Nagar fire revealed how budget hotels operate without fire exits or municipal norms. Is there an overview by the Centre?

Hotel fires and compliance with building norms are handled at the municipality level, where the Central government has neither a role nor a right.

Reva Thakkar: With an increase in Israeli tourists, including IDF soldiers, in places like Himachal Pradesh, is there a screening process?

Israel is our strategic partner country. Visas are issued through an online system, and verification of a person's record and background is the responsibility of the Indian embassy in that country.

Atif Shah: Whenever there is a security breach in Kashmir, the tourist spots are closed for two or three months. Shouldn't security forces be deployed instead?

On the day Pahalgam happened, the government was questioned over security. We have to ensure every traveller's safety, while harnessing the tourism potential. So after Pahalgam, we closed places where there could be a security threat. But it's not that tourism possibilities have suddenly decreased; we can't open up 100 per cent of the experiences. But 70 per cent are there.

Divya A: The ASI has over 3,000 vacancies out of 8,000 posts, which affect heritage conservation.

Nearly 80 per cent of the 3,000 vacancies in ASI are all at the level of Multi-Tasking Staff (MTS). Currently in India, when MTS vacancies are announced, because there is direct selection, the SSC (Staff Selection Commission) reports to us and gives us numbers. But when a person finds out their posting is for the security of a field in Assam, they don't join. Whoever joins stays for maybe seven days. Someone joins, and then gets a better job elsewhere, so they leave.

So these vacancies continue. It doesn't mean no one is working on them. Contractual labour is already working. When the permanent recruit comes, they will be removed.

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Why cancer is rising in the young

CANCER RATES are rising in adults under 55, and new research by the Washington University School of Medicine suggests accelerated biological ageing may be one piece of the puzzle. Scientists found that people from more recent generations tended to have bodies that appeared biologically older than those of earlier generations at the same chronological age. Biological age acceleration was linked to a higher risk of early onset cancers, particularly lung, gastrointestinal, uterine and colorectal. Chronological age measures how many years a person has been alive. Biological age reflects how old the body appears.



Whole grains for heart health

EATING FOUR to six servings of whole grains each day may improve several major risk factors for cardiovascular disease, according to new research published in the *European Heart Journal*. Higher whole grain intake was associated with lower levels of total cholesterol and low-density lipoprotein cholesterol (LDL or 'bad' cholesterol), as well as lower triglycerides, glucose and interleukin-6 (a sign of inflammation) in the blood. Benefits were already apparent among people consuming 30 to 40 grams of whole grains per day. However, the strongest effects were generally observed at 60 to 100 grams per day.



Chips linked to high muscle fat

EATING MORE ultra-processed foods was linked to greater fat buildup inside thigh muscles, according to MRI scans of 615 adults at risk of knee osteoarthritis. Surprisingly, the association remained even after researchers accounted for calorie intake, physical activity and other factors. Fatty changes in these muscles may weaken support around the knee and increase osteoarthritis risk. According to researchers at the University of California, the more ultra-processed foods a person reported eating, the more intramuscular fat researchers detected, regardless of total calorie intake.



Reversing ageing with diet change

OLDER ADULTS may be able to shift important markers of ageing in a surprisingly short amount of time simply by changing what they eat. New research from the University of Sydney found that Australians aged 65 to 75, who reduced either dietary fat or animal-based protein showed signs of a lower biological age after just four weeks. Biological age is an estimate of how old the body appears based on its health and physiological condition, rather than the number of years a person has been alive. Future research should explore whether these changes recorded can be sustained long-term.



Night light reshapes your heart

A STUDY INVOLVING more than 11,000 people has found that exposure to light at night is associated with potentially harmful changes in both the structure and function of the heart. Researchers at the University of New Orleans found that higher exposure to night light resulted in thickening the wall of the left ventricle (one of the chambers of the heart). The scans also revealed signs that the heart muscle was less able to flex normally during each heartbeat. Reduced flexibility can be an early sign that the heart is beginning to function less effectively.





POLICY MATTERS

BYRAM NATH

FORUM COORDINATOR, AIMED (ASSOCIATION OF INDIAN MEDICAL DEVICE INDUSTRY)

Not MRP, we need fair pricing for med devices

A transparent, trade-margin-based pricing system can protect patients while giving manufacturers level playing field

WHEN MAHARASHTRA FDA (Food and Drug Administration) Commissioner Tukaram Mundhe recently flagged the exploitative margins in medical devices, he echoed what patients, policymakers and industry have long known: India urgently needs a distinct regulatory framework for medical devices, separate from drugs. The current pharmacentric approach under the Drugs (Prices Control) Order (DPCO) distorts competition, penalises ethical manufacturers and leaves patients at the mercy of inflated Maximum Retail Prices (MRPs). India's medical device sector has expanded rapidly in recent years but regulation and pricing mechanisms have not evolved at the same pace. The Medical Devices Rules, 2017 brought devices under a dedicated regulatory framework for quality and safety, yet pricing continues to be addressed largely through mechanisms designed for pharmaceuticals. This disconnect becomes particularly important because the device market spans thousands of products with very different technologies, costs, life cycles and supply chains. The policy challenge, therefore, is not simply to control prices, but to create a transparent and predictable framework that protects patients from excessive mark-ups without discouraging manufacturers, distributors and hospitals from supplying innovative and essential devices. Patients cannot bargain or choose devices. Hospitals decide, often guided by profit margins rather than patient welfare. The result is MRPs inflated 10–30 times above real costs. A pacemaker imported at Rs 25,000 is billed to patients at over Rs 2 lakh. Syringes costing Rs 3 at the factory gate are sold to patients for Rs 30. Heart valves imported at Rs 4 lakh have been marked up to Rs 26 lakh. These are not isolated cases but systemic distortions that erode trust in healthcare. Applying drug-style controls to devices has created perverse incentives and a skewed market place that works on competitive fair pricing only at the manufacturers' level or between wholesale traders. Ethical Indian manufacturers operating on thin margins lose out to importers who exploit loopholes to set artificially inflated MRPs. In 2017, the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) capped stent prices, reducing costs by 70 to 85 per cent without any supply shortages. Similarly, prices for knee implants went down by up to 69 per cent, making the procedure affordable. These interventions proved that rational price caps improve access, protect patients and create a level-playing field. Extending this principle to other critical devices is the logical next step. AiMed (Association of Indian Medical Device Industry) has advocated for a trade markup-based capping mechanism at the GST trigger

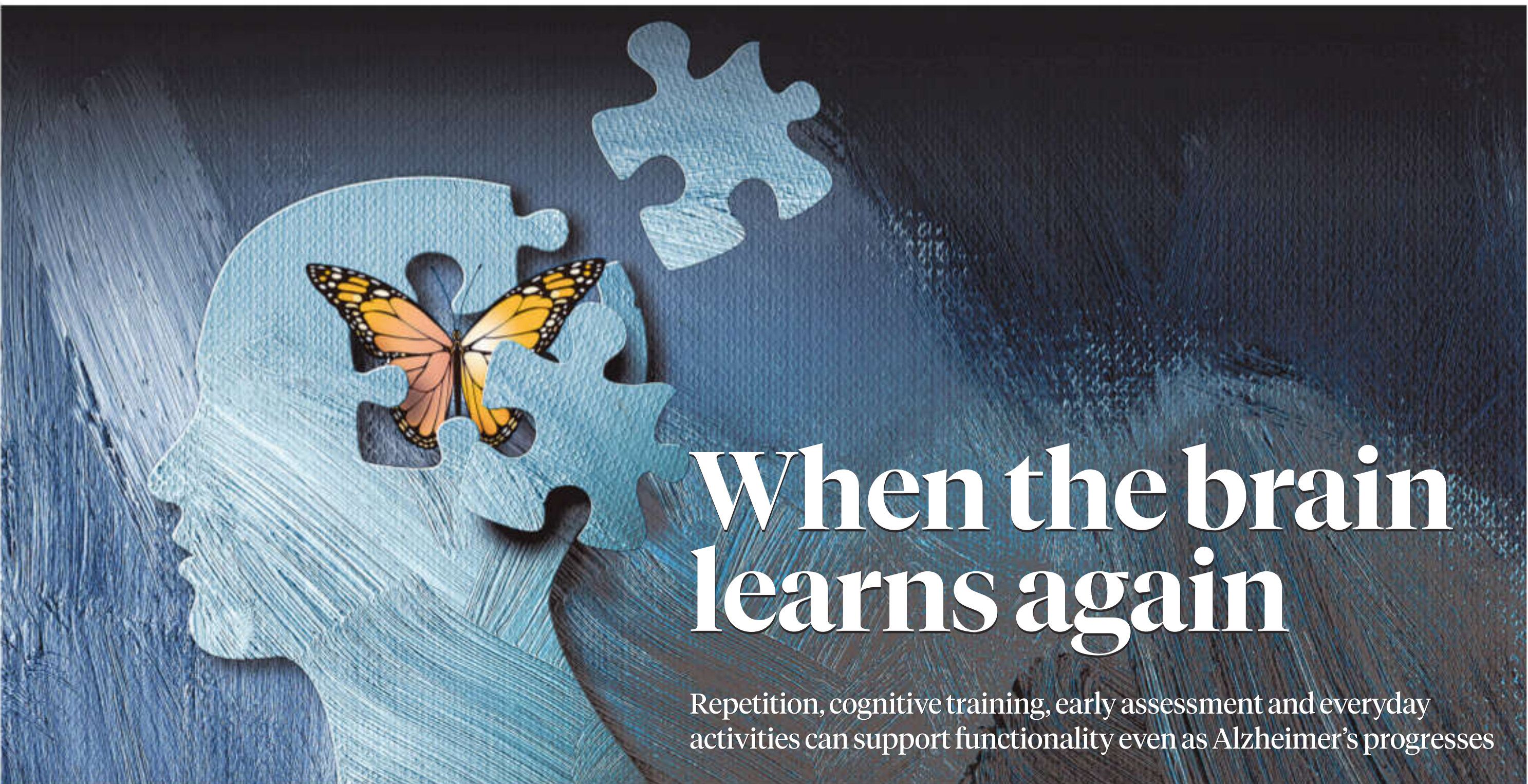


point — the first point of sale where there is maximum transparency and a level playing field with imports from overseas manufacturers. For imports, this would mean the landing price — cost of goods delivered to a destination port — and for Indian manufacturers the ex-factory price.

Trade margins can then be capped fairly by price band, say:

- 50 per cent for devices above Rs 1 lakh (e.g., heart valves)
- 66 per cent for devices between Rs 1,000–Rs 1 lakh (e.g., pacemakers, catheters)
- 75% for devices below Rs 1,000 (e.g., syringes, IV sets)

This model ensures affordability for patients, viability for distributors and parity between Indian and overseas manufacturers. It moves India from labelled MRPs to labelled fair prices. This will ensure that patients are shielded from irrational markups as the transparent margins will prevent predatory pricing and high MRPs. Domestic manufacturers will gain parity with importers, which will encourage investment and innovation by Indian manufacturers. The GST data at the first point of sale ensures easy monitoring and enforcement of such a fair pricing system. Most importantly, it would increase patients' trust in healthcare systems as they will see value, and not profiteering, in the device pricing. AiMed calls for a 12–18 month pilot covering six categories of devices: pacemakers, heart valves, cardiac catheters, syringes, IV sets, and intra-ocular lenses. Regular review, stakeholder consultation and calibrated margins will ensure supply continuity and adaptability.



When the brain learns again

Repetition, cognitive training, early assessment and everyday activities can support functionality even as Alzheimer's progresses

GETTYIMAGES

Rinku Ghosh

AT 87, Tara Pal* was losing herself. As Alzheimer's disease chipped away at the memories that shaped her being with names, places, routines and her identity, her words began to slip away while even the simplest tasks became difficult. The woman who had once carried a lifetime of knowledge in her head could no longer find her way back to it. Then, almost playfully, she began again. Sitting with her grandchild's alphabet blocks, Tara started forming words with her. At first, the letters made no sense. Then, one afternoon, they came together to spell her own name: TARA. She smiled as she struggled to put the letters in a row, her frail fingers losing grip every time. Then she went on to spell out her daughter's name, pronounce her husband's name, call out to him and, eventually, memorise her own address. Tara had not suddenly "recovered" from advanced Alzheimer's disease. What had changed was her ability to engage with a familiar task, learn through repetition and respond to cues. "With supportive care mechanism, you can improve the quality of life for an Alzheimer's patient," says Dr Prasun Chatterjee, geriatrician and researcher, whose work has explored cognition, ageing and Alzheimer's disease.

Her story points to a less obvious truth about Alzheimer's: the loss of memory is not necessarily the loss of every capacity to learn. "Alzheimer's does not destroy all types of memory and learning at the same rate," explains Dr Chatterjee. "Different memory systems rely on different brain networks. Alzheimer's particularly affects the hippocampus and related medial temporal-lobe networks, which are important for forming new memories. Late-stage Alzheimer's can leave some forms of learning relatively intact, particularly learning based on repetition, habit and emotional familiarity, even when conscious memory and the ability to learn new facts are severely impaired."

Currently toggling roles as the WHO TAG Member for Healthy Ageing, president of the Indian Academy of Geriatrics, and Group Clinical Lead, Geriatric Medicine and Longevity Science, Apollo Hospital, Delhi, he has examined Alzheimer's and cognitive decline from several directions. From interventions that may support cognition before dementia develops, to behavioural changes that may precede Alzheimer's, and biological markers that could eventually help identify the disease earlier. "Alzheimer's disease is a neurodegenerative disorder in which abnormal protein clumps called amyloid (plaques) and tau (twisted tangles) build up in the brain and destroy the patient's memory, thinking skills and the ability to carry out simple daily tasks," he says. It is the most common cause of dementia, but the two terms are not interchangeable. Dementia refers to a decline in memory, thinking, behaviour or other cognitive abilities severe enough to interfere with everyday life. Alzheimer's disease is a specific neurodegenerative disease — and the most common cause of dementia. The distinction matters because the underlying cause can influence investigation, treatment and care. "And India is looking at an old age pandemic," he adds.

How to look for early signs

One of Dr Chatterjee's patients is 78-year-old Kamla Mehra* from Noida. Her warning sign was deceptively ordinary: she began asking her son the same question — "Did you go to the market?" — again and again, sometimes five times within an hour. Soon she struggled to name everyday objects and would repeat questions just minutes after receiving an answer. "The family could have dismissed it as normal ageing. Instead, they sought help. A comprehensive assessment identified mild cognitive impairment (MCI), a stage in which cognitive abilities have begun to decline but substantial independence may still be preserved. Unlike Tara, Kamla came to us much earlier and opened a very different window for intervention," says Dr Chatterjee.

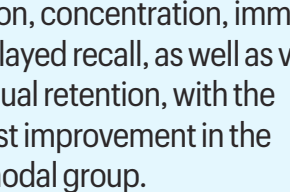
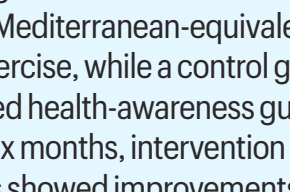
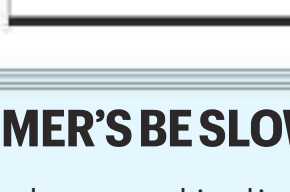
For generations, memory loss in an older person has often been treated as an inevitable consequence of ageing. "India's ageing population means that this casual dismissal is becoming increasingly consequential," he adds. The nationally representative research from the Longitudinal Ageing Study in India estimated that about 74 per cent of Indians aged 60 and above — roughly 8.8 million people — were living with dementia based on data collected during 2017–2020.

The more detailed LASI-DAD research has highlighted an even larger population living with milder forms of cognitive impairment. Researchers estimated the prevalence of major neurocognitive disorder at 7.2 per cent and mild neurocognitive disorder at 17.6 per cent. Among people aged 80 and above, the estimated prevalence of major neurocognitive disorder was 15.2 per cent. And as India's population over 80 grows, dementia will increasingly intersect with another major problem: Who will provide the care? "That's why diagnosing mild cognitive impairment is important," says Dr Chatterjee.

"Some Alzheimer's patients remain stable, others improve when reversible or contributing factors are identified and treated. The signs are many — losing your train of thought, struggling to follow a book or film plot, or getting easily distracted. Some take longer to find the right word during a conversation, find it harder to make decisions, finish multi-step tasks or pay bills on time. Some could feel disoriented even in familiar places. Irritability, anxiety, depression, acting out of character and sudden bouts of frustration are all signs of a person losing control over their familiar self," he explains.



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The science of neuroplasticity

Kamla's assessment went beyond asking whether she could remember a list of words. "The six core areas used to evaluate cognitive impairment are learning and memory, executive function, language, complex attention, perception-based motor function and following social cues. The brain has multiple domains, so rehabilitation involves activating all of these to keep the brain functional," says Dr Chatterjee. At his geriatric clinic, Kamla took the Addenbrooke's Cognitive Examination-III (ACE-III) test. Her initial score was 67/100. She underwent brain scans and was tested for blood biomarkers.

"The brain is vastly more complex than a muscle. It responds to experience, practice and stimulation throughout your life. It keeps emotions intact. This capacity for adaptation is broadly described as neuroplasticity. So if you work the brain, it can keep going till the very end. I see 100-year-olds with no dementia or Alzheimer's. Cognitive decline should be addressed as a whole-body and whole-person problem, not simply as a memory disorder," says Dr Chatterjee.

Kamla's "brain gym" was an intensive non-pharmacological programme. Her son was particularly clear that he did not want to continue medications that made his mother sleepy and confused. She had computer-based cognitive training for approximately 40–45 minutes per session, with repeated sessions over three months. She thought she was learning a new skill. Exercises targeted attention, memory, executive function, language and processing speed.

But the more important intervention happened outside the clinic. "At home, the family transformed ordinary life into a cognitive training environment. That's why caregiving becomes so important. She maintained a diary. She practised recall. She did backward counting, played word and number games. She started learning music, which she always loved. She was made to participate in financial calculations and household activities. All of these may seem simple but engage the brain's cognitive and functional domains repeatedly and meaningfully," says Dr Chatterjee.

Perhaps the most powerful component of the intervention was not the computer. It was Kamla's son. During their commute from Noida to Delhi, he would point to vehicle number plates and ask his mother to remember and recite the numbers backwards. At home, he gave her a diary where

early signs of Alzheimer's. Studies have examined salivary exosomes — tiny messengers in saliva — that may carry clues about what is happening inside the body and brain, as possible indicators of cognitive changes and COX-2, an inflammatory protein, as a potential blood-based biomarker for earlier detection.

Together, the work reflects a shift towards earlier detection, prevention and preserving function, rather than treating memory loss only after it becomes disabling.

she would write her address and details of what she had done during the day. "A simple activity recruited several abilities at once: attention, language, writing, sequencing, recall and fine-motor coordination. This drill is relevant in India, where families continue to provide a large proportion of dementia care. Depending on specialist appointments will never be sufficient for a country of India's size," says Dr Chatterjee.

How simple interventions help

After three months, Kamla's ACE-III score rose from 67/100 to 87/100. She became more conversational, participated confidently in social gatherings and joined a local NGO. "You can have reasonable functional skills while living with a neurodegenerative disease. And when you intervene earlier, there may be substantially more capacity to preserve independence and build compensatory strategies," says the doctor.

Dr Chatterjee always has counselling sessions with family members and asks them to repeatedly tell the patient how much they are loved and wanted or that they are safe. "The emotional brain can remain deeply responsive even when factual memory has deteriorated. So an Alzheimer's patient senses rejection, alienation and disappointment and spiral down if you say, 'Do you remember me?' Instead say, 'I'm here with you.' That's why the language of dementia care matters," he adds.

How to prevent Alzheimer's

The prevention conversation needs to move much earlier, in midlife. "We only talk about the heart, liver and diabetes. Include brain health in that discussion. Current evidence supports attention to modifiable risk factors, including hypertension, diabetes, obesity, physical inactivity, lack of sleep, smoking, harmful alcohol use, hearing loss, depression, social isolation and other cardiovascular and lifestyle factors. Get a cognitive assessment at 65 instead of 75," he says. Of course, research shows that walking and diet changes help. "For example, the brain's energy metabolism changes in Alzheimer's disease, and a keto diet works because it provides an alternative fuel source to a brain that can no longer efficiently process glucose for energy. But restrictive diets should always be considered alongside other body conditions," says Dr Chatterjee.

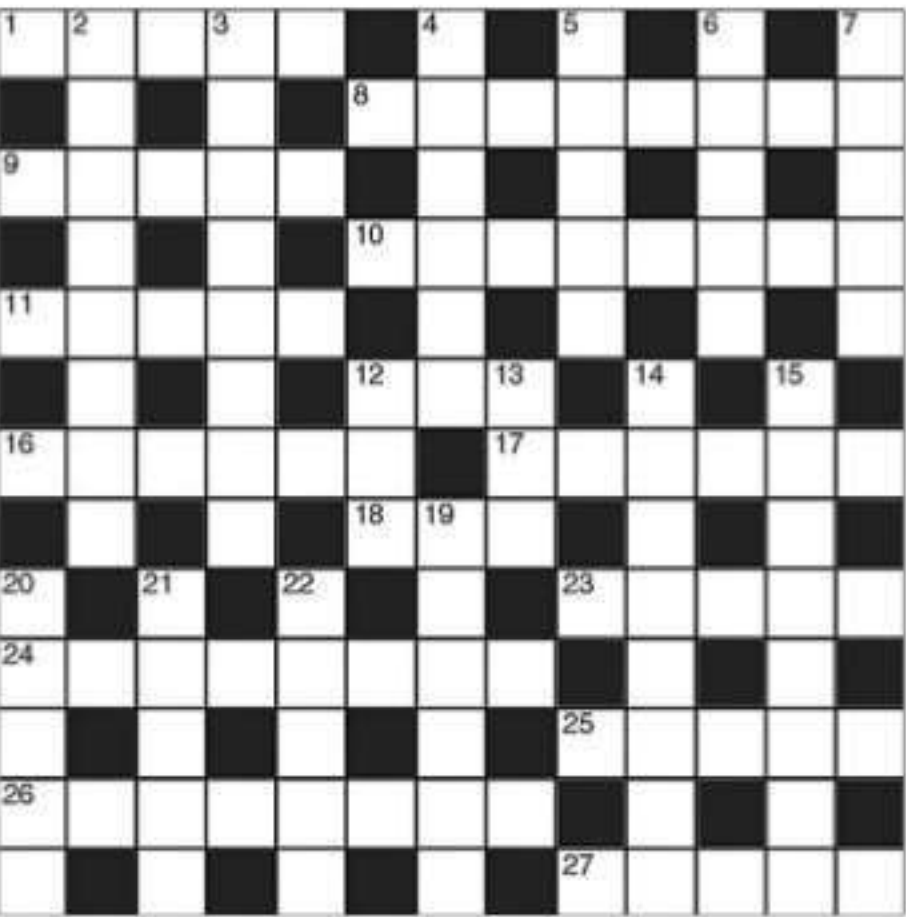
Where the new drugs fit

The emergence of anti-amyloid therapies has added an entirely new dimension to Alzheimer's treatment. Their cost and infrastructure requirements raise major questions about equitable access in India. For example, donanemab costs Rs 91,688 per 350 mg vial in India. Introduced by Eli Lilly under the brand name Lormalzi, this is the first once-monthly amyloid plaque-targeting therapy commercially available in the country. So, Dr Chatterjee overrules the pill dependence.

"Instead India needs a system that begins before the patient reaches the neurologist. Our questions should be about how early can we identify it, how much function can we preserve, and how can we help the person and family live well with it? The answer will always be something can still be done."

*Names changed to protect privacy

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 City which captivated Helen (5)
8 Breach copyright for example of refining process (8)
9 Destroy note written in Gaelic (5)
10 Managed to find time which suited nicely (6,2)
11 A custom that makes us grow old (5)
12 Settle back and talk a lot (3)
16 Give a plain description of French capital (6)
17 Having gone off thoroughly confused (6)
18 Make an effort to hear (3)
23 Salary increased to get out of debt (3,2)
24 Words in action? (8)
25 A reduction by a quarter is severe (5)
26 The principle of no credit (8)
27 Way-out ideas are not to be considered (5)

DOWN
2 Stayed in custody (8)
3 Status symbols? (8)
4 An alcoholic drink leads to a complaint (6)
5 Muse to appear after a very long time (5)
6 A poem of positive significance (5)
7 Indicates way of getting funds (5)
12 Catch or catch on (3)
13 Sadly robbed of 500 pounds as an estimate (3)
14 Overtures returned with interest? (8)
15 Leave in a rush having been recompensed (8)
19 Make phone call about an account — for betting? (6)
20 Prepared to study at the end of the day (5)
21 Roadside dump (5)
22 Man with the knack of showing compassion (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6098
ACROSS: 1 Racehorses, 6 Acre, 10 Nerve, 11 Undertake, 12 Espalier, 13 Isaac, 15 All agog, 17 Drivers, 19 In store, 21 Regiment, 22 In tow, 24 On safari, 27 Ideal gift, 28 Igloo, 29 Snap, 30 Insomniacs
DOWN: 1 Ring, 2 Chrysalis, 3 Hyena, 4 Routing, 5 Endured, 7 Clara, 8 Exercising, 9 Trailing, 14 Facilities, 16 Goodwill, 18 Esmeralda, 20 Erosion, 21 Risotto, 23 Theta, 25 Feign, 26 Lots

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Wise sayings often fall on barren ground, but a _____ is never thrown away. - Arthur Helps (4,4)

ACITDD

EGVIN

AELYKW

throw away. - Arthur Helps
ANSWER: Wise sayings often fall on barren ground, but a kind word is never thrown away. - Arthur Helps

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 1s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6448

	6		4			5		
9		2		1		8		7
	4		7		3		6	
			3	6		8	4	
5	7			3				8
		9	1		5	2		
	9		4		7		1	
3		7			8		6	4
	1			5				9

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6447

6	7	4	2	5	3	8	9	1
1	2	9	6	7	8	4	5	3
8	3	5	1	9	4	7	6	2
2	6	3	9	8	7	5	1	4
4	1	7	3	2	5	6	8	9
9	5	8	4	1	6	3	2	7
7	4	2	8	6	9	1	3	5
3	9	6	5	4	1	2	7	8
5	8	1	7	3	2	9	4	6

ROYAL STARS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): You're high-viz as this day begins. People notice you. It's a high-energy day and excellent for communication with partners, spouses and your kids. Discussions about the arts, vacations and fun outings will be interesting and imaginative. Tonight: Be friendly.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Although this is a positive day with lots of upbeat energy to get things done, be aware of the fact that bosses, parents and the police might throw you a curveball. They might say or do something you least expect. Tonight: You're admired.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Unexpected opportunities to travel as well as explore avenues in publishing, media, medicine and higher education could be a blessing today. You're full of creative ideas. Tonight: Explore and learn.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Be ready to compromise today, because this might be a factor you have to deal with. Double-check banking details and anything to do with shared property and inheritances, because something might surprise you. Tonight: Check your finances.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Your communication skills are excellent today. You're a walking example of the power of positive thinking. Don't hesitate to entertain big plans that might include shopping for beautiful things for your home and entertaining. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): This is an excellent day for financial negotiations. Trust your moneymaking ideas. If shopping, you might be tempted to spend big. Stay tuned. Tonight: Get better organised.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today Mercury is in your sign dancing with lucky Jupiter, which makes you feel happy and friendly. Group activities will appeal. You might be concerned for the welfare of others. Expect social plans to change. Tonight: Relax at home.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): You might be caught off guard by a family discussion or a family member who has strong feelings about something. Tread carefully. Meanwhile, hidden news that pleases you might be revealed. Tonight: Interesting conversations.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Pay attention to everything you say and do today because this is a mildly accident-prone day. Your dealings with friends, groups and organisations will be positive. Young people will respond to your inspirational ideas. Tonight: Check your belongings.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Keep an eye on your money and possessions today because something unexpected could impact them. Guard against loss, theft or damage. You will impress bosses, parents and VIPs with your visionary ideas today. Tonight: You win.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Today your feelings are intense. Your routine might be interrupted by something unexpected. But you might be encouraged by something related to higher education. Or perhaps you'll have a chance to travel. Tonight: Enjoy solitude.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): This is an excellent day for financial discussions. Work-related travel is likely for some of you. Whatever happens will probably improve your chances to get a better job. Tonight: Be friendly.

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NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER
CONCOR invites E-Tender in Single Packet System of tendering for the following work:-

Tender No.	CON/Area-III/ENG/ICD-SNF/E-76991/T-1/2026-27
Name of Work	Balance Work of Development of Additional Infrastructure at ICD/SNF, Sanathnagar, Hyderabad
Estimated Cost	₹ 374.93 Lakhs (including GST)
Completion Period	12 months (Twelve Months)
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	₹ 7,49,900/- (through e-payment).
Cost of Tender Document	Nil
Tender Processing Fee (Non-refundable)	₹ 3,540/- (inclusive all taxes & duties through e-payment)
Date of Sale of Tender (online)	21.09.2026 (from 15:00 hrs.) to 12.10.2026 (up to 17:00 hrs.)
Date & Time of Submission of Tender (online)	13.10.2026 up to 17:00 hrs.
Date & Time of Opening of Tender (online)	15.10.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

For financial eligibility criteria, experience with respect to similar nature of work, etc, please refer to detailed tender notice available on website www.concorindia.com, but the complete tender document can be downloaded from website www.tenderwizard.com/CCIL only. Further, Corrigendum / Addendum to this tender, if any, will be published on website www.concorindia.com, www.tenderwizard.com/CCIL and Central Procurement Portal (CPP) only. Newspaper press advertisement shall not be issued for the same.

Group General Manager (Projects)
Phone No.: 011-41222500

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY

The following e-tender is published in IREPS website. Firms are requested to login to www.ireps.gov.in and quote against the tender. Manual Quotations will not be entertained for the Tender.

Open Tender No.	Short Description of the Item	Tender Value (₹)	Period	Closing	Opening
2026499	*Service Contract for Fire Fighting in ICF.	₹ 2,36,00,281/-	731 Working Days	13.10.2026 at 14.45 hrs	13.10.2026 at 15.00 hrs
212345					

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Chief Safety Officer / Fur

RajCOMP Info Services Limited (RISL)
C-Block 1st Floor, Vojana Bhawan, Tilak Marg, C-Scheme, Jaipur

RISL invites bids from the eligible bidders for Selection of Agency for Design, Development, Implementation & Maintenance of "Recruitment 2.0". Total estimated cost is Rs. 17 Cr. The details can be seen on the websites: <https://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <https://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <https://risl.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <https://doitc.rajjasthan.gov.in>.
UBSN No.: RIS26275LOB00051
Raj.Samwad/C/26/10627

Group General Manager

FORM NO. INC 26
BEFORE THE REGIONAL DIRECTOR, NORTHERN REGION BENCH, MINISTRY OF CORPORATE AFFAIRS, GOVT. OF INDIA, NEW DELHI
[Pursuant to rule 30 the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014] Advertisement to be published in the newspaper for change of registered office of the company from one state to another

BEFORE THE CENTRAL GOVERNMENT (REGIONAL DIRECTOR, NORTHERN REGION) in the matter of sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Companies Act, 2013 and clause (a) of sub-rule (5) of rule 30 of the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014 AND

In the matter of Megmeet Electrical India Private Limited Having its Registered Office At PNo 140/7 Imt Manesar, Gurgaon, Gurugram, Haryana, India, 122052 INDIA

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that the company proposes to make application to the Central Government under section 13 of the Companies Act, 2013 seeking confirmation of alteration of the Memorandum of Association of the Company in terms of the special resolution passed at the Annual General Meeting/ Extra ordinary general meeting held on 22.06.2026 to enable the company to change its Registered Office from "State of Haryana" to "State of Uttar Pradesh"

Any person whose interest is likely to be affected by the proposed change of the registered office of the company may deliver either on the MCA-21 portal (www.mca.gov.in) by filing investor complaint form or cause to be delivered or send by registered post of his/her objections supported by an affidavit stating the nature of his/her interest and grounds of opposition to THE REGIONAL DIRECTOR, NORTHERN REGION BENCH, MINISTRY OF CORPORATE AFFAIRS, GOVT. OF INDIA, B-2 WING, 2ND FLOOR, PT. DEENDAYAL ANTYODAYA BHAWAN, 2ND FLOOR, CGO COMPLEX, NEW DELHI-110003 within fourteen days of the date of publication of this notice with a copy to the applicant company with a copy of the applicant company at its registered office at the address mentioned below:

BY THE PETITIONER AND ON BEHALF OF FOR MEGMEET ELECTRICAL INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED Sd/- RAVINDRANATH DIXIT (DIRECTOR) DIN: 10908896 Address: C/o Chaola Ravindrarnath Dixit, M-405, Swagat Flamingo, Nr. Sargasan Cross Road, Sargasan, Gandhi Nagar, Gandhi Nagar- 382421.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

RUDRA S/O No8429836L SURAJ DHYANI BORN ON 05/02/2019 RESIDING AT P70/15 Kabulline delicantt 110010 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RUDRA DHYANI VIDE AFFIDAVIT DATE 14/09/2026

0050297779-1

I, Kapil Kumar Rathi s/o Bishan Singh Rathi r/o house no 48, Rajpur Khurd near Falsha chowk Mehrauli Maindan Garhi Road South Delhi 110068 inform that in my passport and other documents my name is wrongly mentioned as Kapil Kumar instead of Kapil Kumar Rathi. That Kapil Kumar and Kapil Kumar Rathi both the names belongs to same person.

0040879429-1

I, Gulafsha, W/o Zubair Ul Arfin, R/o 652, Phatak Deputy Sultan, Churi Wala, Chawri Bazar, Delhi-110006, have changed my name to AFSHAN ZUBAIR permanently.

0040878952-5

I, Vikas Sahni, S/o Sh. Sharwan Sahni, residing at A-2/127 B, Keshav Puram, New Delhi - 110035, do hereby declare that my father's name has been erroneously mentioned as Sarwan Sahni, S.K Sahni, Sharwan Sahni, Sharwan Kumar Sahni, Sharwan Kumar Sahny, and Sharwan Kumar Sahni in some of my documents/records. All these names pertain to one and the same person. The correct, true, and actual name of my father for all future legal, official, and administrative purposes is Sharwan Sahni.

0040879426-1

PUBLIC NOTICE

Under the instruction of any Client Sh. Sumia Devi S/o Late Vijender Singh R/o: H.No.69A Ravidas Nagar, Pana Udayan Narela Delhi 110040. Debar to her Son Namely Amit Kumar Khobba and daughter-in-law- Namely Nisha and Grand Son Namely Akshith Kumar Khobba from her all movable/ immovable properties due to their misbehavior/ misconduct. My client shall not be responsible for their any legal / illegal act in future.

Satish Kumar (Advocate)
Ch. No. 1025, Rohini Court, Delhi-85

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UTTARAKHAND POWER CORPORATION LIMITED
Corporate Identity No. UA40109UP2001SGC025867/2358
V.C.V. Gabar Singh Urja Bhawan, Kanwali Road, Dehradun-248001, Ph. No. : 0135-2763672-75, Fax : 0135-2763830, Website : www.uktenders.gov.in

E-TENDER NOTICE
TENDER SPECIFICATION NO. 03 To 15/SE(MM)/2026-2027

Superintending Engineer (MM), Uttarakhand Power Corporation Ltd., V.C.V. Gabar Singh Urja Bhawan, Dehradun, invites e-tender for sale of **Various types scrap material on "AS IS WHERE IS BASIS"** available under ESD/EWD, Dehradun/Haldwani. The last date of online request of tender document/submission/opening date of tender are as given below:-

Sl. No.	Tender No.	Name of Division under which Scrap is available	Name of Scrap Material	Unit (in Kg.)	Average Turnover previous 3 Years (In Rs.)	Earnest Money (FDR/CDR) (In Rs.)	Cost of Tender document including GST (Draft) (In Rs.)	Last date & time of online request for purchase of the tender document & submission of tender in online & off line mode	Date of opening of Bid part 1st in online & off line mode
1.	03/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD Haldwani	MS Meltable Scrap (Drum/Steel/Nut & Board)	240491 Kg.	154.00 lacs	1.54 lacs	5900.00	08.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	09.10.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.
2.	04/SE(MM)/2026-2027	EWD Dehradun	MS Meltable Scrap	95393 Kg.	94.20 lacs	0.63 lacs	2360.00	08.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	09.10.2026 at 15:30 Hrs.
3.	05/SE(MM)/2026-2027	EWD Haldwani	MS Meltable Scrap	164066 Kg.	150.00 lacs	1.08 lacs	5900.00	08.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	09.10.2026 at 16:00 Hrs.
4.	06/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD Dehradun	ACSR Conductor Scrap	949734 Kg.	2068.65 lacs	27.59 lacs	29500.00	12.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	13.10.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.
5.	07/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD Haldwani	ACSR Conductor Scrap	292035 Kg.	636.15 lacs	8.49 lacs	17700.00	12.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	13.10.2026 at 15:30 Hrs.
6.	08/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD Dehradun	Al. Cable Scrap	159195 Kg.	392.20 lacs	3.93 lacs	11800.00	12.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	13.10.2026 at 16:00 Hrs.
7.	09/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD Haldwani	Al. Cable Scrap	51322 Kg.	85.20 lacs	0.57 lacs	2360.00	12.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	13.10.2026 at 16:30 Hrs.
8.	10/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD/EWD Dehradun	Al. T/f Coil Scrap & Other Al. Scrap	134030 Kg.	357.40 lacs	3.58 lacs	11800.00	13.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	14.10.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.
9.	11/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD/EWD Haldwani	Al. T/f Coil Scrap & Other Al. Scrap	116559 Kg.	309.20 lacs	3.10 lacs	11800.00	14.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	15.10.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.
10.	12/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD/EWD Dehradun	Cu. T/f Coil Scrap & Other Cu. Scrap	23865 Kg.	313.20 lacs	3.14 lacs	11800.00	13.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	14.10.2026 at 15:30 Hrs.
11.	13/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD/EWD Haldwani	Cu. T/f Coil Scrap & Other Cu. Scrap	12559 Kg.	182.80 lacs	1.83 lacs	5900.00	14.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	15.10.2026 at 15:30 Hrs.
12.	14/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD/EWD Dehradun	Stamping Core Scrap	95769 Kg.	150.00 lacs	1.31 lacs	5900.00	13.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	14.10.2026 at 16:00 Hrs.
13.	15/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESD/EWD Haldwani	Stamping Core Scrap	142918 Kg.	192.20 lacs	1.93 lacs	5900.00	14.10.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	15.10.2026 at 16:00 Hrs.

For further details, please visit website www.uktenders.gov.in

No. 743/EE(CM)/UPCL/A-2 Dt.: 19-09-2026

SAVE ELECTRICITY IN THE INTEREST OF THE NATION Customer Care No. 18004190405 "Pay Electricity Bill Online 24x7 from www.upcl.org" (For information on Electricity Theft, informer may report to Toll Free No. 18001804185 / Fax No. 0135-2760911)

Superintending Engineer (MM)

• BRIEFLY

IOC chief praises accommodation facilities for Asiad
THE ACCOMODATIONS for the 2026 Asian Games have got a nod of approval from International Olympic Committee president Kirsty Coventry. “It’s better than some of the (athletes’) villages I’ve ever stayed in. So I think to be very fair to Japan and to the organising committee, I was really impressed,” the former Olympic swimming champion said. ENS

• MEDAL TALLY

COUNTRY	G	S	B
China	11	6	3
Japan	6	6	7
South Korea	3	3	7
Kazakhstan	3	0	2
Thailand	3	0	0
India	0	2	0

DAY 2 CAPSULE
Haul: Two shooting medals
2 SILVER

- The trio of Sonam Uttam Maskar, Elavenil Valarivan and Vidarsa K won India’s first medal of the 2026 campaign in the women’s 10m air rifle team event.
- Elavenil Valarivan won silver in the women’s 10m air rifle individual event, finishing 0.6 points behind Japan’s Hinata Taichi.
- BADMINTON**
- The team of PV Sindhu, Unnati Hooda and Tanvi Sharma beat Kazakhstan 3-0 and are into the women’s team quarter-finals.
- HOCKEY**
- The men’s team started with a 13-1 win over Indonesia in their Pool A opener.
- The women’s hockey team beat Uzbekistan 19-0 in their first Pool B match.

• TODAY’S PICKS

- DAY 3**
Shooting: 10m Air Rifle Men’s Final (9 am)
- Rudrankish Patil seeks redemption in Japan; Parth Mane and Himanshu Dhillon join him with individual and team medals at stake.
 - MMA: Women’s 60kg semifinals (8:30 am)**
 - Medal assured, Suchika Tariyal seeks to upgrade its colour by entering the final.
 - Hockey: India v Bangladesh (10:30 AM)**
 - After a 19-0 hammering of Uzbekistan, the Women In Blue eye another big win against Indonesia.
 - Kabaddi: India vs Japan (men’s, 9:45 am), India vs B’des (women’s, 4:15 pm)**
 - The Indian men’s and women’s teams will kick off their respective Group A campaigns.
 - Table tennis: India vs Pakistan (women, 6:30 am); India vs Pakistan (men, 3:30 pm)**
 - Both teams will play their last group-stage tie.

• SHOOTING SILVER MEDAL

Training with borrowed rifle to medalling in Nagoya, the hard yards Sonam put

The pandemic forced the family to leave Mumbai for hometown, where father sold off land for daughter’s dream

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, September 20

IN 2020, WHEN the pandemic raged, Uttam Maruti Maskar was forced to shift from Mumbai to his hometown Kolhapur. His milk supply business had taken a hit, and he had to restart his life in his hometown with just a plot and shop.

His daughter Sonam too had to realign her dream to be an ace shooter. She had to find her own rifle and kit, which was quite expensive. A dotting father, Uttam sold his precious belongings — 25 acre plot and the shop. The sacrifices were worth it.

On Sunday, the 23-year-old shooter (634.1) played her role in fashioning a silver medal in

the women’s 10m air rifle team event. In the individual segment, she fell behind and ended up sixth. Nonetheless, several time zones away, her father Uttam’s memories rolled back to the hard times they weathered.

The responsibility

“When she joined Vedh Rifle and Pistol Shooting Academy, she trained with the academy’s rifle and kit initially. Later in 2022, I got her a new rifle and kit, costing more than five lakhs. I sold one of my shops and a plot at a much cheaper market price,” he recalls to *The Indian Express*.

He considers those as not a sacrifice but responsibility. “We had to sustain the family

as well as support her training needs. Whatever I could do for my daughter and family, I did and that was my responsibility. To see her win a medal for India gives us joy and a moment to recall all the sacrifices too,” he added.

Before plunging headlong into shooting, she had played chess at the school level and practised with elder sister Manasi and younger brother Satyajit. “All my three children played chess and Sonam spent her free time playing chess with them,” the father says.

But she opted for shooting at the Tolani College in Andheri after her tenth standard exams. When she took a break to prepare for her twelfth standard exams before the pan-



Sonam Maskar made it to the final but was unable to keep the momentum and add to India’s medal tally. PTI

demic struck, little did she then know then that her trajectory would change. But she barely complained and started training rigorously under Rohit Hawaldar and his wife Radhika Barle Hawaldar at the academy.

“There was not a single day when she complained. She only talked about how she is training towards competing in tournaments and winning medals for India,” he recounts.

The progress was steady rather than spectacular. In

“When she joined the academy, she trained with their rifle and kit. Later in 2022, I got her gear, costing more than five lakhs. I sold one of my shops and a plot at a much cheaper market price.”

UTTAM MARUTI MASKAR, SONAM’S FATHER.

2023, Sonam finished seventh in ISSF Junior World Championships in Changwon and fourth in the Asian Championships. The following year, she won her first ISSF World Cup medal, a silver in Cairo. Months later, Sonam managed to win silver again in the

ISSF World Cup Final in Delhi.

The recalibration

Coach Rohit reveals the hard yards she put. “When Sonam joined our academy, her score used to be mediocre as she had not trained under a professional coach and in a coaching setup. Her strength was her technical knowledge,” he tells this masthead.

He immediately started working on her posture.

“Tuning her body posture, developing her shoulder muscles as well upper body settlement when shooting, took time. We did dry shooting as well as squat shooting to achieve the result. Once she achieved those, it was easier for us to do advanced training programmes. We used to practice 90-120 shots daily. Her father too supported her a lot,” he says.

On Sunday, Sonam first shot 634.1 in qualification to reach

the eight-shooter final. “Her forte is mental strength and a never-say-die attitude. She showed that in the World Cup final in Delhi where she hit a 10.9 at the flag end to make sure that she wins a medal,” he says.

“Today too, she started well in the qualification and maintained her consistency. She did not score below 105 in her last three series to ensure that she finished in top eight and went to the final in good rhythm,” he observes.

The proud father knows how his daughter will unwind. She would return to the board of 64 pieces. Sonam remembers her scores and her chess matches.

“Whenever she plays chess with her siblings, she remembers all their past moves. She would play chess or see a chess match and ask her siblings to play when she returns to India,” says Uttam.

“There is a bit of disappointment that I had a good lead but I see the scope to learn from this experience. I feel that there’s a lot more to learn from the finals that happened today.” ELAVENIL VALARIVAN, ON MISSING OUT ON GOLD

Three journeys, one silver



The Indian women’s 10m air rifle team scored a combined 1898 points to win a silver medal. PTI

Elavenil Valarivan, Sonam Maskar and Vidarsa K Vinod: Three different roads converge for India’s first 2026 Asiad medal



Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 20

It was a fitting opening medal for a shooting team that has grown deep: experience in Elavenil, a recent breakthrough in Sonam and sheer persistence in Vidarsa.

SOMETHING ABOUT India’s first medal at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games is unusually neat.

Three women took very different routes to reach the same shooting range near Toyota City. One who stumbled into the sport through a friend’s daughter, another who began shooting almost as a college hobby before her family sold property to keep the dream alive, and a third who picked up a rifle through the NCC while hoping that it might lead to a government job.

On Sunday morning in Nagoya, those three stories converged. Elavenil Valarivan, Sonam Maskar and Vidarsa Vinod combined for a total of 1898 points to win silver in the women’s 10m air rifle team event, giving India its first medal of the Games.

China finished on top with a Games record of 1904.2, while hosts Japan took bronze with 1897.1. It was a fitting medal for an Indian shooting team that has grown increasingly deep: experience in Elavenil, a recent breakthrough in Sonam and sheer persistence in Vidarsa. “India’s depth in rifle and pistol events makes us a force in not just Asia but also the world. That depth is the reason we can be hopeful of team medals in most shooting events at the Asian Games,” rifle coach Deepali Deshpande had told *The Indian Express* before the Games.

Different beginnings

That depth is reflected in the stories of the three medal winners. For Elavenil, shooting was never supposed to be the plan. Born in Cuddalore and raised in Ahmedabad, she had tried almost every sport going — athletics included — before a

equipment required to progress. “I can’t imagine reaching this far without that decision my father took,” Sonam told *The Indian Express*. “It was a very big sacrifice. After that, I just kept going.”

She resumed serious training in 2021 at the Kolhapur range and, within a few years, had announced herself internationally.

Persistence pays

The third member had perhaps the least conventional route. Vidarsa grew up in Kozhikode in a middle-class family. She first picked up a rifle through the NCC in 2018. She enjoyed the sport, but a government job was one possibility she had in mind.

Even after becoming Kerala state champion, buying a professional rifle was beyond her family’s means. She trained on borrowed equipment. Eventually, in 2021, her family took a loan to buy her first rifle.

Then came another leap of faith. Vidarsa moved to Delhi to train at the Dr Karni Singh Shooting Range, leaving behind Kerala. She did not even speak Hindi. She cooked for herself, managed her own chores and trained twice a day. By early 2024, the pressure had become overwhelming. She was missing selection marks, the family had sacrificed heavily, and she had begun contemplating quitting.

However, her husband and former shooter Manu S Ravi kept pushing her, along with coach Manoj Kumar. Eventually, Vidarsa found her way into the SAI National Centre of Excellence, where equipment, nutrition and training support eased some of the financial anxiety that had followed her career. Now she was standing alongside an Olympian and a World Cup medalist at an Asian Games. “She did what was expected of her,” Manoj said. “Her stronger event is the 3-position, so she has a shot to win another medal.”

That is what made Sunday’s medal more than just three cumulative numbers. Three backgrounds. Three routes. And India’s first medal in Nagoya.

The size of Elavenil’s Asiad silver heartbreak — an edge of a coin

Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 20

THE EDGE of a coin is barely there. A thin, almost invisible sliver. That was Elavenil Valarivan’s (pronounced Ila-vennil Vala-rivan) distance from Asian Games gold on Sunday.

At the end of a thrilling final, in which she led for all but the last two shots, Elavenil needed to score 0.6 more than Japan’s Taichi Hinata. She shot 10.1 and finished on 252.4. Hinata had 253.0. For all the years Elavenil has spent waiting for a big medal at a major Games, it came down to this tiny sliver.

Her first thought after the final shot? “Oh, 0.6. Okay...” her voice trails off.

Elavenil’s career has often been about being close — close enough to be called India’s next big shooting star, close enough to be ranked No. 1 in the world, close enough to watch others move ahead while she waited for her moment. Now, she had an Asiad medal around her neck. Two, actually. A team silver earlier in the day with Sonam Maskar and Vidarsa Vinod, followed by an individual.

For someone who was supposed to inherit the shooting revolution the likes of Abhinav Bindra and Gagan Narang helped build in the generation hers, the journey has been unusually long. Narang, now her mentor, won his first Asian Games medals in 2010 — team and individual silvers. Elavenil emerged as one of the young faces expected to carry that generation forward. Instead, she spent years watching the medals go elsewhere.

At the 2018 Asian Games, a rifle malfunction disrupted her campaign. At the Tokyo Olympics, where she arrived as the world No. 1, her form deserted her and she finished 16th in qualification. In Hangzhou three years ago, India’s shooters were collecting medals by the dozen. Elavenil was not even on the team. Her coach Neha Chavan remembers 2022 and 2023 as perhaps the toughest stretch. Elavenil had lost considerable weight after suffering from kidney stones, adding a physical challenge to an already difficult period. Though she made the Olympic team again, Elavenil finished 10th in the 10m air rifle qualification, missing the final.

The years in between were not wasted. “Those were very important for my consistency over the years,” Elavenil said of those years. The biggest ‘learning’, she says, was being patient.

Those two traits — patience and consistency — are what eventually brought her back. Before Paris, Chavan had seen just how difficult the road had been. Post-Paris, she also saw how stubborn she was to iron out



Elavenil Valarivan won an individual silver on Sunday in the Women’s 10m Air Rifle event. PTI

• Stage-by-stage breakdown

Stage 1, Series 1 (5 shots) 53.1	POSITION - Leading, but the average drops to just under 10.5.
Stage 1, Series 2 (5 shots) 52.9	Stage 2, Series 5 20.8
POSITION - Leading with a pristine 106.0 from ten shots.	Stage 2, Series 6 20.8
Stage 2, Series 1 (2 shots) 20.9	POSITION - Still leading (by 0.2), but barely. No truly bad shots but Japan’s Hinata Taichi is closing in fast.
Stage 2, Series 2 (2 shots) 21.5	Stage 2, Series 7 20.5
POSITION - Still in the lead, still maintaining that average of 10.6	POSITION - Second. Two average shots when a moment of brilliance was needed. For the first time in the final, Elavenil drops her lead and takes silver.
Stage 2, Series 3 21.2	
Stage 2, Series 4 20.7	

flaws from her game. “If she feels a problem needs to be resolved, you will find her at the range for an entire day,” Chavan says.

One of the things they worked on was the qualification scores. “Trying to figure out what is not letting us go from, you know, 632 to 633, for

example,” Chavan adds. On Sunday morning, those sessions helped.

While Sonam and Vidarsa were shooting their qualification, Elavenil sat on her suitcase, her back against a pillar, waiting for her turn. When her own qualification was over, she sat on

Varun out of AG after passing out during weight cut



Varun Sanyal was supposed to participate in men's traditional 77kg quarters. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, September 20

INDIAN MMA fighter Varun Sanyal was declared medically unfit and failed to make weight for the men's traditional 77kg quarter-final bout in the MMA event.

After passing out during the weight cut, Varun was taken to hospital and assessed medically by doctors. He has returned from the hospital and is stable now.

In order to cut his weight before his quarter-final bout, the 28-year-old had reduced his food and water intake.

The medical document accessed by this paper mentions in the details section that Varun experienced dizziness while undergoing the weight cut.

“Varun couldn't make weight as he was declared unfit by the doctor,” a source told *The Indian Express*. “The medical reports suggest that he had muscle cramps and was dehydrated also while cutting the weight,” the source added.

The medical document accessed by this paper mentions in the details section that he experienced dizziness while undergoing the weight cut.

“While undergoing weight loss, including food and fluid restriction, experienced dizziness, lightheadedness, and muscle cramps 30 minutes after taking a sauna,” the document translated from Japanese stated.

After Varun passed out, he was found by a Nepali athlete who woke him up.

“He passed out after the weight cut but the Nepali athlete woke him up, he managed to call the federation President Nikhil Kunder,” another source close to the development said.

“He was taken to the hospital but right now he is stable and there is nothing serious. The doctors have asked him to replenish his salts orally and no additional treatment is needed.”

Varun was one of the two Indian MMA fighters participating in the Asian Games and was a late addition to the squad.

Earlier, Varun had secured his Asian Games berth after claiming a bronze medal at the Asian Championship in China.

The other MMA fighter, Suchika Tariyal, won her quarter-final bout and entered the semis in the women's traditional 60kg to confirm a medal for India.

On Sunday, history repeated itself. The defending champions faltered for the first time in this edition , dropping two crucial points to Poland and dealing a

ASIAN GAMES

Shafali’s 49-ball 100 takes India to the brink of a gold medal

Riding on opener’s unbeaten century, Harmanpreet & Co. swat aside Bangladesh to claim 114-run win

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, September 20

SUCHIKA TARIYAL, India's first mixed martial arts participant at the Asian Games, defeated Mongolia's Altanchimeg Baigalmaa to secure the nation's maiden Asiad medal in the discipline. At the Inae Sports Centre, she had set in motion a cascade of records for Indians on Sunday.

Hours later, some 25 kilometres to the northeast at the Korogi Sports Park, her cricketing compatriots would carry the baton onward — one of them being from her city.

The Indian women's cricket team, in defence of their gold medal, have secured a place in the final with a complete demolition of Bangladesh. Opting to bat first, India scored 195/4, while their opponents could only muster 81 runs in response, securing a 114-run victory — India's biggest ever, in terms of runs, against a full-member nation in women's T20Is.

The first record to tumble belonged to Suzie Bates. She had not found company at the summit of women's T20I's run-scoring charts, but no longer — Smriti Mandhana eclipsed her with a 19-ball 37. In doing so, she struck two sixes, becoming the first Indian to reach triple figures in sixes in women's T20Is.

Yet, even that record would be eclipsed within minutes. Shafali Verma went berserk Bangladesh in a semi-final once more, as she had done just 10 days earlier at the Women's Asia Cup. This time, though, there was no reprieve on offer. The opener carved out an unbeaten 49-ball 100, nine of those deliveries sailing beyond the ropes, taking her tally of sixes in this format to 104.

That, though, was not the only record that would belong to Shafali after Sunday's knock.

She became the first woman to score a century at the Asian Games, the first female Indian cricketer to hit nine sixes in a T20I innings against a full-member nation, and the first cricketer to score a women's T20I hundred against Bangladesh. She now also holds the most women's T20I sixes in a single calendar year (35).

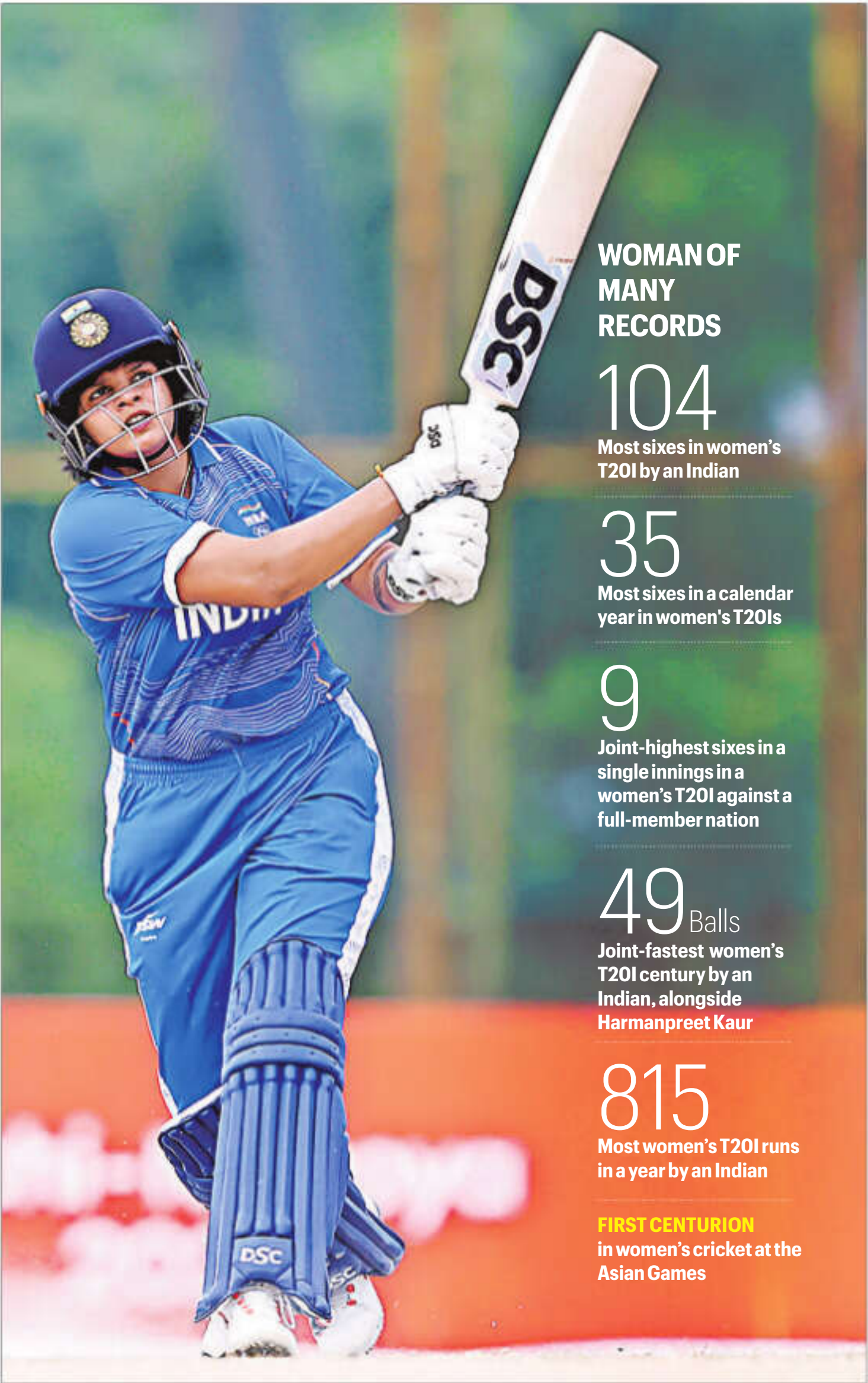
Shafali's innings left scant room for speculation about the outcome, but captain Harmanpreet Kaur played a steady hand of 33-ball 40. The pair now occupy the top two places on the list of T20I run-scorers against Bangladesh — Harmanpreet with 560, Shafali with 482.

Familiar nemesis

After a meek submission against a familiar nemesis in the first innings, Bangladesh followed the same script in the second. Deepti Sharma, who had engineered Bangladesh's batting collapse at the Asia Cup with a three-wicket haul, posed another set of questions that Nigar Sultana Joty's batters could only admire, but never answer.

With three wickets for seven runs, She now sits joint-second among the leading T20I wicket-takers against Bangladesh. Nandani Sharma also took three wickets, though at a cost 18 runs dearer. More gratifying to the team management than any individual accolade, however, will be that every bowler who had the opportunity of rolling their arms ensured that they left with a wicket to their name. Sree Charani got a couple of scalps to her name, while Kranti Gaud and Shreyanka Patil took one wicket apiece.

In Tuesday's final, India will face Sri Lanka, who made light work of a 178-run target on the strength of captain Chamari Athapaththu's unbeaten 83. India have won all but one of



Shafali Verma's 100* engineered India's biggest women's T20I win against a full-member team. CREIMAS

their last 12 T20Is against the Lankans. That lone defeat, however, came in strikingly similar circumstances — another final, of the 2024 Asia Cup, where an Indian defeat

seemed improbable.

But Tuesday's bridge can be crossed when the team reaches it. Sunday, meanwhile, belonged to two daughters of Rohtak, Haryana.

BRIEF SCORES: India 195/4 in 20 overs (Shafali Verma 100 n.o.; Shanjida Akter 1/25) beat Bangladesh 81 all out in 15.4 overs (Dilara Akter 27; Deepti Sharma 3/7) by 114 runs.

Journeywoman Suchika confirms medal at 36

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 20

SUCHIKA TARIYAL took down Mongolia's Altanchimeg Baigalmaa 2-0 to enter the semifinals of the women's traditional Mixed Martial Arts (MMA) 60kg and confirm at least a bronze medal for India at the Asian Games.

The 36-year-old has been a kind of journeywoman, transitioning from judo to kurash to ju-jitsu to mixed martial arts now. “I have been playing combat sports for many years. However, MMA is a new game for me,” said Suchika after her win.

Suchika used the learnings from her formative days against the Mongolian opponent. “I just planned my game as per my coach's instructions. My gameplan will be the same going forward -- same take-down, ground and pound, and finish the fight through a submission or lock. That's the strategy going forward as per my sir's instruction,” she said.

Suchika, who is good at ground and pound, stuck to her strengths on Sunday and that is largely due to her early days as a judoka. “I started judo as I wanted to learn combat sports. Judo gave me the base to do other combat sports,” she said.

While she is going on the ground, Suchika needs to sharpen her skills of striking and kicking. “They said my ground and pound was good, but I needed to work on my striking, on kicking and boxing,” Suchika had told *The Indian Express* before leaving for Japan.

As a 12-year-old, Suchika picked up judo after an eve-teasing incident at a unisex salon left her helpless. “I went to a unisex salon and the barber touched me inappropriately,” Suchika had told this paper earlier in an interview. “I felt that I should have something for my own defence. I should have some fighting skills with which I can fight back.”

A few months later, she



Suchika Tariyal entered the semifinals of the Women's 60kg MMA event on Sunday. ASIANMMA

joined judo classes at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, close to the government quarters where she lived. Before she knew it, Suchika began winning age-group medals and, within a few years, became a junior national medallist. She went on to become an eight-time na-

tional champion in judo.

Not the first sport

This is not the first sport where she is representing India in a multi-sporting event. Earlier, she represented India in judo at the Commonwealth Games 2022 and kurash at the 2023 Asian Games.

However, this is her first medal in her third attempt at a multi-sporting event. Making its debut at the continental showpiece, women's traditional MMA 60kg combines striking, takedowns, grappling and ground fighting, with athletes competing in the under-60kg category. The winner is decided by points, submission or stoppage, and reaching the semifinals guarantees a medal, with both losing semifinalists receiving bronze.

Before heading to Aichi-Nagoya, Suchika trained in Mumbai under Nikhi Kunder, who is also the president of MMA-SFI, the national body looking after the sport in the country. “I had a six-week camp at One Punch gym in Mumbai under Nikhil sir and also at Evolution Gym. Nikhil sir has supported me throughout this journey. His students at the gym also helped me a lot. During sparring sessions, they made sure I stayed fit and didn't get injured,” she said.

Acid test awaits Indian boxers in Asian Games



Jadumani Singh could face Carlo Palaam in pre-quarters. PTI

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, September 20

WHEN THE Indian boxing campaign begins on Monday at Aichi, it will be the first tangible test of where the programme of the country stands after the 2025 World Championships. At the Worlds, the men's boxing events were a central Asia affair — Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan, two countries that consistently churn out high-level, technical boxers — dominated the medals tally and didn't allow a single country to win a gold medal.

Since then, multiple World Cups, a World Cup finals, an Asian Championships, and a Commonwealth Games has come to pass. In the face of varying degrees of competition, the Indian boxing team has performed admirably, particularly the women's team. But the Asian Games is the first true test of calibre that the Indians will face since the Worlds and starting off the campaign is Sumit Kundu.

For Kundu the problem isn't Monday, when he faces the Thai challenge of Paris Olympian Bunjong Sinsiri; rather the looming situation of Torekhan Sabyrkhan, the Kazakh boxer in his side of the draw, that elicits worry. Sabyrkhan, and his elder brother are the consensus best boxers in Asia.

The story is largely similar for many of India's best. In what has been overall a tough draw, boxers including CWG champions Sakshi Chaudhary, Preeti Pawar, Priya Ghanghas, Sachin Siwach and Ankush Panghal will face stiffer challenges in the Asian Games.

In the men's 55kg division, CWG silver medallist Jadumani Singh faces a possible pre-quarters clash against Tokyo Olympics silver medallist Carlo Palaam — a ferocious puncher, and one of the best boxers produced by a country that also gave the world Manny Pacquiao. And if Jadumani lives up to his name, there is Makhmud Sabyrkhan, the favorite to win the LA 2028 Olympic medal waiting for him in a possible semi-final clash.

Perhaps none face a competition as stiff as what Sakshi will have to deal with. In the women's 51kg, Chaudhary will face Philippines' Paris Olympics bronze medallist Aira Villegas in her opener before she faces reigning flyweight world champion Alua Balkibekova of Kazakhstan in the pre-quarters. If she survives those, a possible meeting with Vietnamese boxer Nguyen Thi Tam, a constant thorn for Indian boxers awaits. Should she win, the other side of the draw offers China's Wu Yu, or Thai pugilist Chuthamat Raksat — two familiar vanquishers of Indian boxers.

Preeti Pawar and Huang Hsiao-wen of Chinese Taipei have been drawn in opposite

half of the draw in the women's 54kg division. Pawar has got a bye in the first round with a possible clash against Paris Olympics bronze medallist Pang Choi Mi of North Korea in the pre-quarters, an opponent she has yet to face. If she reaches the final, a possible matchup against Wen or Tokyo Olympics bronze medallist Tsukimi Namiki or Paris Olympian Nigina Uktamova awaits.

Priya Ghanghas's rise has been meteoric but that rapid ascent gets seriously tested in Aichi over the next fortnight. A couple of Paris Olympians in the pre-quarters and quarters (Oh Yeon-ji and then Mijgona Samadova) start Ghanghas' tough Asiad run. A possible semi-final clash could happen against Tokyo Olympics silver medallist and Paris Olympics bronze medallist (57kg) Nesthy Petecio.

Parveen Hooda (65kg) faces a possible clash against 2025 World Championships silver medallist Navbakhor Khamidova in the quarters. If she gets past the Uzbek, a daunting mountain to climb against reigning world champion (65kg) Aida Abikheyeva of Kazakh in the semi-final can surface.

For Tokyo Olympics bronze medallist Lovlina Borgohain, the eight-boxer 75kg draw pits her against 2024 World Cup final winner Seong Suyeon in the quarters. A win adds another Asian Games medal to the Olympic bronze medallist's burgeoning kitty of medals. She then either faces 70kg world champion Natalya Bogdanova or 2025 Worlds bronze medallist Aziza Zokirova of Uzbekistan.

Medal hopes for men

All is not lost as both Sachin Siwach, Ankush Panghal have the possibility of medaling at the Asian Games.

Siwach walks into Aichi with a Commonwealth gold and plenty of confidence. He has a decent draw until the semi-finals where he runs into the consensus favorite of the 60kg category in world number one and Paris Olympics champion Abdumalik Khalokov.

Ankush Panghal, who has only recently become part of the national team and has a CWG gold to his name, faces a fairly relaxed opener but runs into some turbulence against the reigning 75kg champion Fazliddin Erkinboev awaits the Indian before a possible final against former Asian champion Iashaish Hussein of Jordan or former youth world champion Sabirzhan Akalykov of Kazakhstan. Kapil Pokhariya has a possible semi-final clash against reigning world champion Turarbek Khabibullaev of Uzbekistan. In the 90+ division, Narender Bernal has an easy way to a medal getting a bye followed by a second round bout against Thai Adthapong Saetgop before a possible clash against Aibek Oralbay.

• THIRD STRAIGHT LOSS

Poland prove to be Indian women’s Achilles’ heel again at Chess Olympiad

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, September 20

THE CHESS Olympiad has always been a slow burner. The 11-round Swiss system tests you in every way possible, and the opponents only get tougher with each round. For the reigning champion Indian women's team, the storm came in the form of Poland. Having defeated the women's team at both the 2022 and 2024 Olympiads, Poland have been the Achilles' heel for India.

serious blow to their title defence.

With IM Oliwia Kiolbasa leading the way on the top board for Poland, their side adopted a shrewd strategy, deploying GM Monika Socko, their most experienced player, on the last board.

To counter the threat from Socko, the Indian side captained by Swayams Mishra went with the experience of Vantika Agrawal over the current form of Savitha Shri B on the last board. The 19-year-old Savitha, making her Olympiad debut in this edition, had been on fire, winning all her games on Board 4 with a perfect 4.0/4 before being dropped for the Poland clash.

The decision might have been logical, going with experience to hold off Socko, and Vantika did her job by holding the veteran Polish player to a draw on Board 4, taking a crucial half point from the match.

Regardless, India lost the round elsewhere. It was on the board of World Championship challenger R Vaishali, who couldn't sustain the pressure with the black pieces against IM Aleksandra Maltsevskaya on Board 2.

On the top board, Kiolbasa, was too solid for Koneru Humpy to find any chances with the white pieces. Both players engaged in the non-committal line of the King's



Vaishali R lost to IM Aleksandra Maltsevskaya on Board 2. FIDE

Indian Attack, playing with nearly 98 per cent accuracy. The game ended in a threefold repetition in just 27 moves,

with plenty of time left on both clocks.

Another game that ended in a clean draw was between Divya

Deshmukh and Klaudia Kulon on Board 3. Kulon was in red-hot form, having entered the clash with 4.0/4, but Divya brought her A-game to deny any chances, holding her opponent to a 0.5-0.5 draw in a game that went till 51 moves.

This meant that with three games ending in draws, Vaishali was left to play only for a win. The only problem was that she had anything but a fighting position, one where even a draw was way out of reach. A ruthless Maltsevskaya ensured there wasn't much Vaishali could do in the lost endgame, handing the Indian a slow death and taking home two big points from the gold medallists following a

2.5-1.5 win.

The fortunes suddenly look quite different for the men's and women's teams after the round. The Indian men's side, after overcoming a relatively slow start, now looks well-placed to mount a serious fight for their gold medal defence. Continuing their ruthless winning streak, India dispatched the Netherlands in what eventually became a one-sided 3.0-1.0 match, their fifth win in a row.

After Arjun Erigaisi's first win of the event on Saturday, it was R Praggnanandhaa's turn to taste his maiden victory on the top board. Meanwhile, the decision to play reigning world champion D Gukesh on the last

board continues to bear fruit, as the two Chennai GMs turned the game in India's favour on the extreme boards. In a repeat of their Candidates match, Pragg went one-up against Anish Giri, breaking the Dutchman's four-match winning streak. Having been the Netherlands' trump card, Giri had plenty on his shoulders on the top board.

Hoping to snatch half a point from Pragg with the black pieces, Giri offered the Indian a draw in an equal position. But high on confidence, Pragg declined. He continued to press, induced a mistake from Giri, and never looked back. Gukesh, meanwhile, won his fourth game, sitting on 4.5 points from 5 rounds.